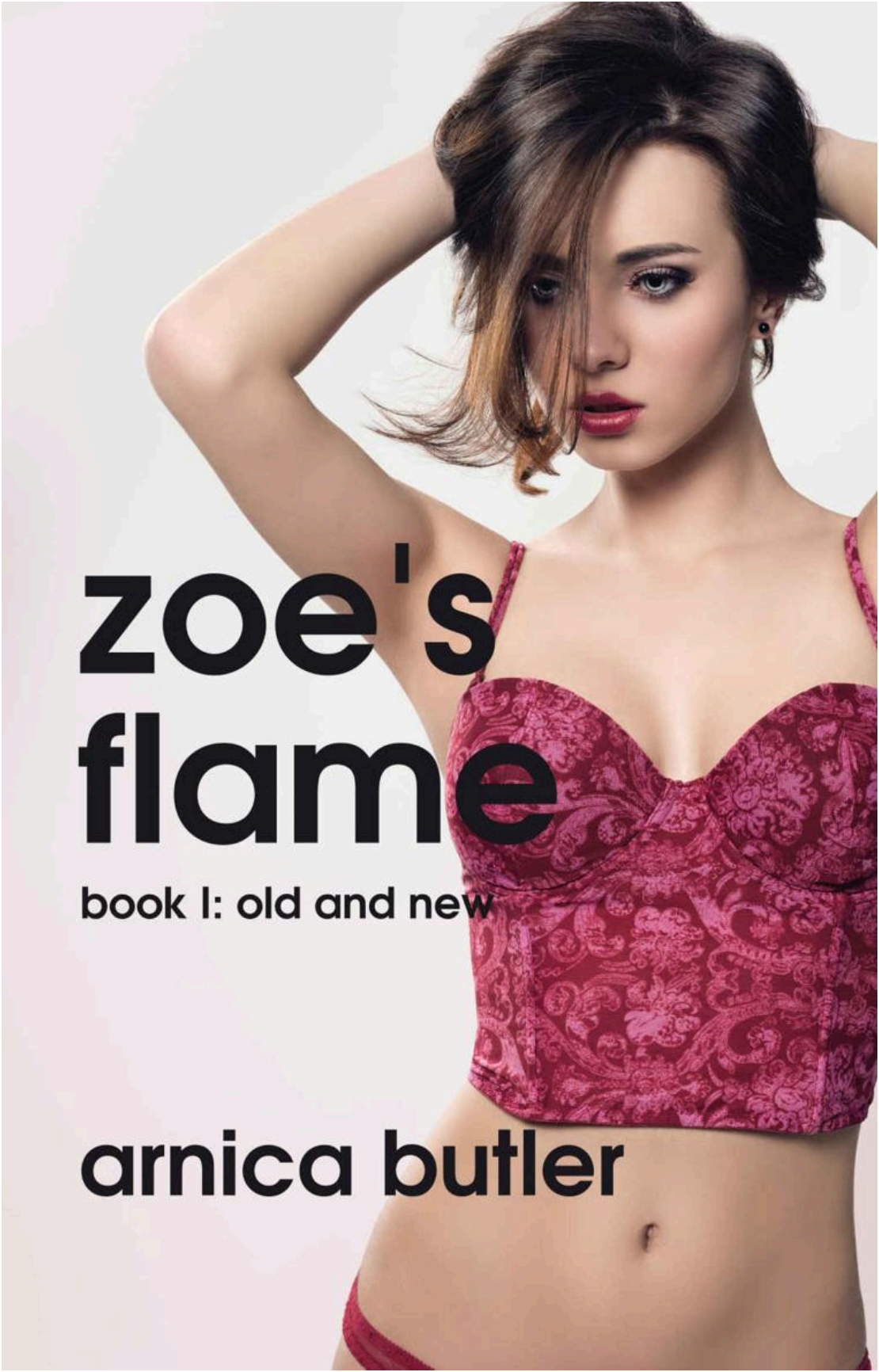




zoe's flame

book I: old and new

arnica butler

ZOE'S FLAME

BOOK I: OLD AND NEW

By Arnica Butler

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CHAPTER 1

"Come. On. *Zooooooooooooo!* " Alicia clapped her hands together and balled up her fists, bouncing on a bar stool with an excitement she almost never demonstrated. Her breasts traveled with her, rolling crests in the black

ocean of her tight shirt, and the men from work who were treated to this spectacle carefully balanced their dual goals of personal safety and adolescent titillation, by staring only with eye-paining peripheral glances.

Alicia picked up her drink, a rum and Coke she was using to wash down a long list of cocktails, and placed her plump lips to the straw. "I cannot believe," she said loudly, without taking her eyes off Zoe, "that I am actually this excited about this stupid game." She sucked on the straw, and it was anybody's guess if she intended to do so as arousingly as she did.

"Me either," Gina said breathlessly, both elbows propped against the bar. "I mean, she is actually *killing* it. She's going to win!

This is crazy."

Zoe waved from behind a cage of tight-mesh, heavy-duty chain link. She herself was a few too many in - it wasn't too hard to do at her weight - but the drinks seemed to have energized her. The drinks, and the fact that at 5'3" and 90 pounds, she was *destroying* a man who was evidently a league champion, at the team-building exercise of the month.

Currently being held at Blanche Axe Throwing.

That league champion, a grizzled man with a bright orange beard flecked with gray, and the sort of thick-waisted, tree-trunk-limbed build one would expect of an axe-throwing champion, glared at her. Zoe flapped her hand at him and shrugged, smiling.

How was she to know she was going to be an axe-throwing genius?

Longer ago than anyone cared to remember, their boss had attended a "life-changing" seminar - one of hundreds, because he loved attending conferences, seminars, conventions, and meetings

the way Labradors love to fetch things from the water - over the course of which he became convinced that team-building through fun activities was crucial to the success of the company.

And so, the tired employees of Hessler Insurance had dragged themselves once a month to escape rooms and Chuckie Cheese, Dave and Buster's, and paintball and laser tag events, usually scheduled on an inconvenient weeknight such as a Tuesday. Having run the gamut of "fun" activities, they had resigned themselves to bowling forever, until a cousin of one of the accountants had opened an axe-throwing business.

"Oh Gooooood," Alicia had complained. "They probably won't even let you get drunk while you're doing that."

Alicia had long ago established her level of participation in team-building activities at "drinking and making cynical comments"

only. Upon her arrival at any "fun" event, she settled into the bar area and rolled her eyes at her high-fiving coworkers. They did not have a Bronx accent or Latin heritage, nor - perhaps because they did not have them - the ability to blink slowly and say, "you canna make me run around like an idiot in cosplay camo shooting people in the face with paint. And another thing, you are paying for my babysitter," with any conviction. So *they* participated. Like idiots. While Alicia drank and checked her Instagram account.

It turned out, however, that there was no law against selling large amounts of alcohol to axe-throwing patrons.

It also turned out - and this was unexpected by all - that Zoe Wilson was a pint-sized, axe-throwing savant.

At the beginning of the evening, the owner had patiently taken each person into the throwing cage to show them how to throw an axe, and, predictably, the axes had gone flying in all directions but at the target.

"This is so bad," Alicia had commented, a faint smile on her lips.

"Somebody is gonna get an axe in the dick."

"Maybe I'll just take a pass on this," Zoe had commented, watching an axe chucked by one of the underwriters bounce off the chain-link fence and

whirl back halfway down the court.

Alicia had shrugged and continued drinking, because everyone knew that Zoe was not going to actually take a pass at something if it

was an implied requirement of the job. Also, everyone knew that Zoe was the only employee who felt bad for Neil, and so tried to save his ludicrous team-building activities with relentless and aggressive cheer.

And finally, anyone who knew Zoe well would know that she never, ever, *ever* passed up dangerous things. She was constitutionally incapable of it.

The owner, and everyone watching, and Zoe herself, had all been fairly certain Zoe wouldn't even get the axe *to* the target. It wasn't like she had huge guns or something, and while she managed to get through a softball game, she was not a whiz at those kinds of sports.

"Just do the best you can," the owner had told her cheerfully, with the kind of sappy encouragement men save for encouraging attractive women who are about to screw something up.

Zoe had snorted, planted her feet, and set up her throw. Alicia and Gina had assumed she was doing it in a half-mocking way, as she did when she was bowling, and made a big show of setting herself up properly.

Whack.

"Holy fuck," Alicia had said dryly in the silence that followed.

"Wow," the owner said, a look of actual amazement on his face.

"Nice... one. Uh, go get your axe. That's uh, that would be, if this wasn't practice, that's a six-point throw."

"Probably just lucky," Zoe said.

But that was twenty-some throws ago, and she had thrown almost every single throw almost in the dead-center of the target.

The league players, who were waiting to have a match, could not believe it, and so Zoe had been enrolled in the match by a wave of enthusiasm and incredulity.

And rum and Cokes, because all of the other employees were just watching by now, mostly in awe, but also because Neil had not given them permission to leave yet.

Whack!

"Oh my God," Alicia commented.

"Another six points, and Zoe from Hessler's is in the... lead."

Zoe bounced around excitedly, her ponytail bobbing, and clapped her hands. It was hard to tell if she was serious or not. Her small breasts bounced in her tight green shirt, and even the nearly-defeated league champion could not help enjoying the show.

Her five throws were completed, and the league champion was throwing.

"Wow," Zoe said, taking a seat at the bar next to Alicia, a faint sheen of sweat at her hairline.

"You want to have something to drink after that, seriously,"

Alicia said, snapping her fingers at the bartender. Snapping fingers at people was another habit she got away with because of her accent and latent Latina energy.

The champion lost, and Zoe took him a beer and gave him a hug in her typical, cheery fashion, and it worked the same charm it always did: even the gruff league champion, defeated by a tiny pixie, could not help but smile and take advantage of the opportunity to squeeze the pretty little Zoe, lifting her off the ground for a bear hug.

"I need a cigarette," Alicia said, rolling her eyes, when Zoe returned to the bar, and stood up to leave just as the bartender set a drink down in front of Zoe.

"What is *that*? " Alicia said, incredulously. She flicked her eyes up at the bartender, red-hot anger flashing beneath the surface. "You told me all you had was like, two-ingredient drinks," she said. "Yeah.

You said, 'if it has more than two things in it, I can't make it.'" Alicia said this last part in her "imitation white man" voice, which sort of sounded like a very gay Texan, but managed to be terrifying at the same time.

The bartender, like many of the people in the immediate vicinity of Alicia, was starting to look scared. Alicia had come to a standing position, and between her heels and her hair, she was the terrifying height of 6'3".

"I didn't... uh... that guy -" he jammed a finger behind him, "paid me extra to make it, told me what to put in it."

He backed away, hands in the air, like a robbery was taking place.

Alicia hissed and then clicked her tongue before looking down at the drink. "What you think that is, anyway?" she demanded of

Zoe.

"Californication," Zoe said, without hesitation, staring at it as though mystified.

"He put like, all the alcohols in there," Gina said. "I saw him."

"White people, I swear to god," Alicia said, before turning on her heel and heading for the door. She already had her cigarette and lighter in hand, and she had, in her magical way, already identified a young man to take with her outside.

Gina leaned on her elbows and stared into the drink. "You gonna drink it, or what? Looks gross."

"It's... my... it's a, sort of a favorite, I guess, cocktail," Zoe said, still staring at the drink. She was shaking her head.

Gina gave it another grimace and turned her attention to the rest of the bar. "You think we can get out of here now? You seen Neil?"

Zoe barely heard her. Remembering, suddenly, that the bartender had been asked to make the drink, she lifted her eyes to look at the other side of the bar. A cool sensation had begun to pulse through her, from the chest outward, into her limbs, and she was almost afraid to find what she expected, because there was only one person she could think of who would send her that drink.

As happened any time she thought of Derek, something coiled up inside of her lower abdomen, and an electric cool zagged through her, from the face of her clit to the base of her spine and back again.

A feral desire gripped her for a moment, and her skin turned hot with it. And then, as the memory of everything else "Derek" elbowed its way into her physiological reaction, the desire cooled, and wound itself up tightly in her stomach, like a snake of ice.

Derek McIntyre, to whom she had lost her virginity. High school sweetheart, plus one tumultuous year of college. Black, straight hair, and piercing navy blue eyes, and a sort of serious and mean solemnity that she both hated and missed, for she had never found it in another man. It wasn't relationship material, but it definitely secured Derek's place as top performer in bed. Not that the list was especially long.

Almost unable to breathe, the coiled snake wrapping itself up tightly inside her abdomen, she lifted her eyes, wondering in those

few seconds what Derek would look like now, how he might have changed, how he might not have.

When she spotted him, she blinked in surprise: he was tan, more muscular than before - even bigger, somehow a different shape, and his hair was... salt and pepper? His stubble was almost entirely gray.

He lifted a glass to her and she stared back, the icy feeling flooding her bloodstream again. She opened her mouth, and a useless, non-syllable left

her lips like a hiccup. "Ough," she said.

"Dude that guy is like, old enough to be your dad," Gina informed her. Then she tipped her head and squinted. "Buuuuut...

he's pretty hot. Looks like maybe he has - oh my God, he is coming *over here*, what are you *doing*? "

He *was* coming over, and Zoe was still staring, her mouth hanging open, the edges turning up in a smile, and somewhere beneath all of that, the cool feeling she only got from Derek was not fading the way she might have expected it to.

"Zoe Landon," he said, sliding his drink up to the corner where she and Gina were perched.

"Dr. McIntyre," Zoe managed to say. Her mouth was smiling, she could feel it. But inside, there was something going on, and she didn't know what it was.

"I think maybe now that you're allowed in a bar you can call me Randy," he said, clinking his glass against hers.

Zoe, because she couldn't quite figure out what else to do with herself, or the sudden suffocating heat that was gripping her chest, looked down at her drink. "You remembered," she said.

"That's...crazy."

"You guys drank all my booze and left orange peels all over the place," Randy said. "How could I forget?"

Zoe looked up at him and smiled, partly out of apology. It had been, like so many things were in adolescence, pretty absurd to think that Derek's dad wouldn't notice all the missing alcohol in his cabinet, the summer Zoe and Derek had "house-sat," which had really been not much more than getting drunk on Californications, having sex, and throwing house parties until they got boring.

"Well, thanks," Zoe said awkwardly, lifting her glass. "I... wow, what are *you* doing here?"

"Well, I'm not throwing axes like a world champion. Is this your career or something? I always thought you'd do something... less violent."

Randy's eyes, like Derek's, were a dark blue that, indoors, sometimes appeared brown. Zoe met them, and for a moment she felt like she was staring at Derek. She cleared her throat to cover for the zing that traveled through her, and picked up her drink. "Don't worry," she said, and was horrified at the way she said it, because she almost sounded... flirtatious. "I'm an insurance agent now, so it doesn't get much safer than that."

Bitterness laced the end of her sentence, and she was surprised by that as well.

Randy leaned on the bar, and didn't say anything. Zoe crunched a piece of ice between her molars. It was so like Randy to listen like that, and the familiarity of this sort of conversation struck her like a slap in the face.

"So," she said. "I'm here for team-building. What brings you to the best and only axe-throwing place in town?"

"Similar stuff," Randy said. His voice was quiet, patient, unalarmed, non-reactive. And yet he used this listening like a surgical scalpel. Inevitably, Zoe thought, he would probe into something inside of her that she herself hadn't considered for years.

"Psychiatrists have team-building exercises?" she said, quizzically. She gave a shake of her head to emphasize the

"quizzical." She was exaggerating her movements, acting strangely, and she knew it, but she felt powerless to stop it.

Randy did not answer this question.

"You're married," he said, in matte-white voice, one finger extended toward her hand.

He sipped his drink.

Zoe looked at her hand, as if she were surprised by the ring.

Inside, she cringed at her behavior, but there was no way to take it back, or bring it under control. She listened to herself helplessly as she flapped around like a fish on a dock. "Huh? Yeah, no, yeah. Oh, yeah, I guess that you wouldn't...have... anyway, yes. Married a little

over, no, I guess almost two... years, now. Soon. In a month or so.

To, uh, Josh. Wilson. He's a good, a really good, a great guy. And so, yeah. That's... really the only thing that's different. About me. Now."

Randy looked at her, his impassive face giving no indication of his thoughts on the matter. Then he said, "You don't have kids."

Statement, not question.

"Uh," Zoe said, caught off-guard. "I... no, but...?"

"You don't look tired enough to have any kids," Randy explained. "You look really... very well, Zoe."

There was a moment of awkward, liquid heat in the air between them, and then, with his ninja-like therapist skills, Randy somehow dissolved it all by laughing in a dismissive way and slamming his drink. "This is a colleague, I take it?"

He looked at Gina, who had been watching the entire scene with her mouth falling open in tiny increments and who now clamped it shut and threw a hand at Randy. "Gina," she said.

Behind Randy, Alicia was returning from her cigarette break, and making no effort to hide the fact that she was astonished to see Zoe with a silver fox. She pointed at his ass and made an okay sign.

"Yeah, sorry, so...this is... Gina," Zoe said, and was unable to keep a straight face as Alicia's movements became more and more exaggerated. "I... this..."

I'm sorry, this, my other coworker here, Alicia, she's like, making a fool of herself," Zoe said.

There. She was regaining some control over the conversation.

She waved Alicia toward them and introduced her.

"Alicia, this is Dr. McIn- Randy. My, uh, the dad of a friend," she said. "Dr. McIntyre, this is Alicia," Zoe said.

"I'm the office slut," Alicia offered shamelessly, but as things tended to be with Alicia, this somehow gave her leverage and made her a little bit scary. "Are you single?"

Randy smiled, and gave Alicia an up-and-down glance, which, as with everything *he* did, somehow managed to be respectful and somewhat clinical. "Alicia. I am single, but I am sure I'm not the first man to tell you, I think you're way too much for me to handle. At my age, anyway."

A wink.

Alicia, whose mercurial moods came only in extremes, was silent for a dangerous moment. Then she laughed, patted him on the shoulder, and tsked. "If you change your mind," she said, in her most nasalized Bronx baritone. "Zoe," she said, suddenly all business. "I got another thing lined up here with..." she waved a hand carelessly in the direction of the man she'd taken outside to smoke. "So I'm just... I'm going. You don't gotta drive me to the light rail. Okay.

Great. It's been a gas."

"Can we go?" Gina asked. "I guess we can go. Zoe, I'm sorry, but I gotta run as soon as we can, Mark gets all whiny and he doesn't feed the kids when I'm out."

Zoe looked down at her drink. The appropriate thing, now, was to give Gina her keys and have her drive to the station, and then take the light rail home herself, and go home now. She looked up at Randy, ready to start in on this

awkward explanation, but he was already shaking his head slowly. "You shouldn't drive," he said.

Unhelpfully, Gina squeezed her shoulder. "It's okay, I'll just get a ride with Mike and those guys. Hey! Mike! You got room in your car?"

And she was gone.

Zoe watched the entire scene unfold as though it was happening to someone else. The truth was, she didn't want to leave, which served as sufficient evidence to her that she probably *should*.

She grinned uncomfortably and looked at Randy. "I have no idea how I'm going to get home," she said.

"I'll get you home. Stay a bit. Or better yet, let's go over to a nicer bar. Catch up."

This exchange, for whatever reason, sent a shiver of pleasure through her, and it was, undoubtedly, a very sexual one.

"I..." she began, and Randy gave her another one of his looks, so she shrugged.

To catch up.

That was all.

*

"So. When I last saw you, you were headed off for skydiving in South America or something crazy like that," Randy said, once they

were installed at The Blue Parrot, an upscale bar not far from the axe-throwing place. "I take it you don't want another Californication,"

he said. "That was sort of a joke."

Zoe smiled. "I can't believe I used to drink stuff like that," she admitted.

"What are you now? A white wine kind of girl?"

Zoe smiled. "Sure," she said.

"Can I pick it?"

He ordered a bottle, and Zoe probably should have interrupted the order, but she didn't. She just let the vague tendrils of guilt sneak down her spine and the backs of her arms.

She wasn't *doing* anything, after all.

To make herself feel better, she took out her phone and ostentatiously sent a text to Josh. "Just gonna tell Josh I'll be late,"

she said.

Ran into a high school friend's dad, staying a little while for drinks.

Love you, hope work isn't awful

She plopped her phone into her purse and smiled. "He's...

working late. Anyway," she said.

"So Josh. Wilson," Randy said, as if Josh Wilson were someone whose name he should know. "And what does this Josh Wilson do for a living?"

The fatherly tone was deliberate, and she knew it, so she rolled her eyes and laughed for him, while something very strange, very sexual, very unrecognizable, squirmed around inside of her. "He's a design guy. Website. Graphic design stuff. He's really, really talented, actually. He's worked on... like, all kinds of big sites: Fevr, Cheapie, Swyft, SnooperDog... you... do not know any of these," she laughed, as Randy made a face and nodded agreeably.

"They sound vaguely familiar, so they must be big."

"Yeah, he's really... very talented. You know. So... that's kind of the focus right now. Of everything. His, uh, career."

"Hmm."

The bitterness that had surprised her earlier had crawled back into her voice.

"And what happened with all of your adventures? I'm actually a little surprised to see you're still alive. Surprised. And glad."

The bartender uncorked the bottle of wine and poured it for them. They were sitting in a cozy, two-person booth. Zoe's foot brushed against Randy's leg, entirely by accident, and he didn't react, but another mild tremor passed through her.

"Oh, you know," she said, taking the glass and bringing it to her lips. "I got older, and wiser, and...same old story."

"How old are you, now?" Randy said, cocking his head. "Like, twenty-six?"

"Eight."

"Shockingly old," he said.

Zoe gulped a large swallow of wine. She was more drunk than she had originally bargained on, and she realized it just then. "My life is really pretty much a drag," she said. "How about you?"

Randy gave her the same implacable look and seemed as if he weren't going to answer. Then suddenly, he decided to, and leaned his elbows on the table, putting his head closer to Zoe's. Her ankle was against his calf now, and there was no way to move it, and while it seemed mildly inappropriate, she did nothing to change it... in fact, she almost wanted it there.

"Ah, well," he said. "I'm fifty-two this year, so I'm long past expressing disappointment with life. Cherie and I are getting divorced."

Zoe brought her thumb to her teeth and bit her nail. "But you guys are both shrinks," she murmured.

This made Randy laugh, which made her laugh, and broke up some of the tension that had been getting a little too hot. Randy shook his head. "Most shrinks I know are divorced."

"Even the marriage therapists? That's what Mrs. - Cherie did, right?"

"Marriage therapists," Randy said, leaning back and stretching his arms over the back of the booth. Zoe tried to keep her eyes from lingering on his physique: he was in excellent shape for his age, or even, really, for any age. A flat stomach, thick, strong arms. He was

like a deeper, bigger, more manly version of Derek as she remembered him. "..are the worst. They're always talking to you in that marriage-therapy voice and making sure you get the blame."

Zoe laughed.

"I'm sorry, though," she said, suddenly. "God, what am I thinking?"

"It's life," Randy said. "We probably should have gotten divorced ten years ago. But enough about me. What about you? Are you happy? I still don't know if I like this Josh kid or not."

Zoe smiled, her lips closed, shaking her head very quickly in appreciation of yet another dad-toned joke. "He's fine," she said. She brought her wine to her lips. "It's... all... everything is fine. Great.

Really, he's my soulmate, he really is."

Randy looked at her for a long time, and then brought his wine glass up to clink against hers. "Well. Derek definitely wasn't, so here's to you finding the right man."

She couldn't be sure, because there wasn't much she could be sure of, but she thought that as the glasses clinked, Randy's finger brushed over hers.

*

They ended up talking for almost two hours, the subjects becoming more personal with each glass of wine. Randy ordered a second bottle, and Zoe made a feeble effort to decline, but in the end she didn't try very hard. There was something fun about talking to Randy. Beneath that fun, there was a hint of it being wrong, and dangerous, but it was the kind of danger she thought she could handle.

After all: this was her ex-boyfriend's dad.

It's not like anything was going to actually happen.

It was just fun to flirt, fun to have someone new to talk to.

But then the wine was gone, and some kind of decision needed to be made. An awkward silence rolled like a fog and hung about their cozy table.

"Uh," Zoe said. "Well, I should probably get... going. Home."

There was a pregnant pause, long enough for Zoe to feel her heart jump around in her chest, while Randy looked at her. "Of course," he said at last. "Wow. I've... done a very bad job of staying sober to drive you home, haven't I?"

"I just need to get to the Light Rail stop," she said. "On Lexington."

Randy pulled his phone out and moved his fingers swiftly over it. "It's nearly twelve," he said. "I'm an old-fashioned guy, I can't let a young lady ride home on the train in the middle of the night."

Zoe snorted. "It's the *light rail*," she said. "We're not in Chicago."

The light rail was a public transportation project that circumnavigated the city: through suburbs only. The idea that there was anything dangerous about it on a Tuesday night was absurd.

"Where do you live?" Randy asked, ignoring her comment, still typing on his phone.

"Uh, near Jackson Park, in Westglenn," Zoe said.

Randy let out a low whistle. "Jackson Park, huh?"

"Not *in* Jackson Park," Zoe corrected. Jackson Park was a gated community of enormous houses, and served as a reference for "wealthy" to anyone who lived in the city.

"Well, perfect," Randy said. "I'm going that way, so we can ride together." He slipped his phone in his pocket. "ETA ten minutes.

Want one last drink?"

Zoe was shaking her head, because that was the prudent thing to do. But she was doing it with that smile, that feigned disbelief, that universally means to all men: I'll go along with it.

So they had tequila.

CHAPTER 2

Zoe's message had destroyed any chance Josh had of concentrating on work, so he ended up staying until almost eleven-thirty. She couldn't know, because he had never told her, about an important component of his fantasies. Because Josh didn't just enjoy thinking about Zoe with other men.

He enjoyed thinking about her with *older* men.

A "high school friend's dad," therefore, sent Josh's mind spinning into all sorts of dark, erotic places.

And when Zoe wasn't home when he got home, at midnight, and she hadn't sent him a message, his mind went even darker. By the time one of the many cars that had set his pulse racing finally rolled to a stop in front of their townhouse, his cock was rock-hard.

He stood up, and walked cautiously to the window - which was silly, because the glass was a modern, tinted black and the lights were off in the room, so there was no way to see him from outside - and looked out.

A man, who from this distance did not look old enough to be the father of a friend from high school, was opening the door of the vehicle for Zoe. Zoe stumbled a little as she exited the car, and her hand landed on the man's arm. Close together, Zoe laughing loudly enough to be heard by Josh all the way up there, the pair walked tipsily to the sidewalk.

Where they paused, very close together. Josh had to get close to the window and look straight down, so he could only see the tops of their heads. They paused for a very long time. As the seconds ticked by, and the pause turned into a minute, and then several, his erection began to throb painfully. He couldn't see anything more than the top of their heads, but they were huddled so closely together that it was easy to imagine them doing just about anything.

It was plain to see that they weren't making out, but they were intimately close.

And they remained that way for a long, long time.

And then, the dark head of the man moved toward the street, and Zoe's was gone. Josh heard the unlocking of the door downstairs, a swish as the air pressure changed. The man had turned back to the townhome, and once the door was closed again, he looked up.

Josh inhaled sharply and stepped backward, his heart pounding as though he had been caught red-handed at something. The man's face burned into his mind, for, in that flash, it had been plain to see that he *was* older. And very handsome.

Downstairs, Zoe was bumping into things and dropping her keys.

With the blood pounding in his ears, Josh looked around the room in the darkness helplessly. His cock throbbed painfully: he wanted to have sex with Zoe desperately. But he also wanted to see how this would play out, what Zoe would do when she came upstairs. As perverse as it was, he almost wanted her to sneak around in their bathroom, to come and lie down in bed and not try to wake him, so that he could feel the heat of her body

against his back and wonder if she had crossed some line with this "friend's dad."

He oscillated between those choices, taking a step towards the bed and then a step back, several times, before throwing himself onto his side of the bed and lying on his side, trying to calm his breathing. Zoe was coming up the stairs now: it was definitely not a trick to know where she was, even though his ears were ringing and sound came to him through the pulsing of his blood.

She didn't turn on the light. Once she reached the room, she tried to move with a little more grace. It was obvious that she didn't want to wake him up. This made Josh's cock even harder. He heard the bathroom door close quietly, the running of water, and pictured Zoe beneath the shower-head, her slender figure slippery and wet.

He knew that Zoe always took a shower before she went to bed: it was proof of nothing except that she was doing what she usually did. And the same went for trying not to wake him up. Zoe was considerate. No matter where she had been that day, she would have tried to be quiet.

But the idea that she might be in the bathroom, rinsing away some trace of another man, captivated his mind anyway. Especially

as the shower dragged on, for almost ten minutes, which was not like Zoe at all.

She padded softly into the bedroom when she finally ended her shower, and by then he felt like his cock might explode. Her weight settled gently into the bed. She was on her side, a trace of her body wash wafting over to him.

He waited as long as he could. And then, at first attempting to act as though he had just been woken by her coming to bed, he stirred, and rolled over, and slipped his arm over her.

"Hey," he growled, doing his best to sound sleepy. "What time is it?"

"Sorry," she whispered, smiling as he kissed her ear. "I tried to be quiet. It's late."

He kissed her neck, and she responded to him by smiling, and purring a little. This wasn't a green light from Zoe, but it also wasn't a slap to the face. He kept going, moving his hands down the length of her torso, over the swell of her hip, onto her bare thigh. She was wearing only her underwear and a camisole.

He drew his hand up, using a feathery touch until he slipped it under her camisole. Once he had his hand there, brushing his fingertips over the curve of her right breast and then the stiff peak of her nipple, he lost his patience for pretending he was sleepy, and rolled her toward him, climbing on top of her, hungrily.

Her body rose up to meet his, and she ground her pelvis against him. He slid his hand between their groins: by now she had felt his erection, and she seemed to like it, and welcome it. When his fingers slipped into her panties and found the slick wetness that was pouring from between her lips, he knew why.

They were kissing, he smiled, and with his lips on her mouth, growled: "What have you been up to that got you so horny?"

Zoe's mouth spread out into his favorite expression, a wide and juicy smile, her mouth open, her eyes teasing. Her hand slid between their bodies and grasped his cock through the fabric of his boxers. "Someone might ask you the same question," she said.

With his palm against her mound, he dipped two fingers inside of her, and they glided through her arousal like butter. Inside, she

seemed hotter than usual, her pussy like silk around his fingers. She mewled as he pushed against her swollen clit.

"So," he said. "A friend's dad, huh? And what did you and this older man get up to?"

It was bait for their game, and he didn't expect her to take it at all. After all, he had never shared this older man component, and she probably thought he was making a joke. She was pushing his boxers down, working her other hand between their bodies. Soon he would be inside of her, and he wouldn't be able to last very long with all the thoughts in his head, anyway.

But Zoe's mouth was moving beneath his, and he didn't hear the first words she said, but she pulled at the nape of his neck and brought her lips close to his ear. "He talked me into doing some very, very naughty things in the car."

Josh pushed himself up a little, to look at her face. She bit her lip, and smiled.

He exhaled, and stared.

Zoe spread her legs beneath him, running her hands over her thighs, and then her calves, kicking her feet carelessly as her wet slit spread open beneath him, and her juices gushed from inside, all over his cock and his balls, his thighs, between her buttocks.

"I told him he was too old for me," Zoe said, and Josh's whole body jerked a little. "But one thing led to another, and before I knew it, I was sitting on his lap and he had his fingers in me."

Josh slid into her pussy, and had to close his eyes. Between what she was saying, and the hot flesh of her cunt pulsing around his dick, he thought he might come right at that moment. Zoe wound her legs around him, and her heels fit snugly into the hollow of his lower back. She pulled him into her, tightly, and mewled when his cock was as deep as it would go.

He wondered if she would say it, there in that brief few moments as she squirmed underneath him, and her breath was ragged, and he could feel an orgasm building inside of her.

She purred for him.

And then, with her nail raking his back, her heels digging into his tailbone, and her body pulsing around his cock, she said,

"Mmmm. He got so much deeper."

How long he was able to fuck her from that moment until his cock exploded inside of her, he would not be able to recall with any certainty. But he lost his composure and thrust himself into her, pounding her soaked slit as her legs flopped on either side of her body.

He felt Zoe come. Her abdomen grew tight like a drum and the flesh around his cock quivered, then rolled around him in waves, and the hot liquid of her pussy turned to a pulsing, velvet sheath. When he looked down at her face, her mouth was open, and her eyes were closed. He enjoyed the brief, erotic thought of his wife thinking of another man, before he was over the edge and emptying his seed inside her.

Usually, when Zoe entertained his fantasies, she brought a hand to her mouth and bit into her finger with a grin, before laughing a little. It was, he supposed, her confirmation of the theater of the act, a way of brushing off what she had said, a way to reiterate that none of it was real.

He had always entertained arousing fantasies of Zoe *not* giggling at the end of one of these sessions. He enjoyed the cold curl of jealousy and betrayal around his balls, creeping into his abdomen, settling like icy lead in his chest.

He held himself up on his forearms, his lips very close to Zoe's, panting. This was the moment when Zoe would smile, maybe even laugh.

Instead, she purred, and pushed him gently to the side, without saying anything or cracking so much as a smile.

The cold that gripped him as she curled into him, spooning, was much different than the one that gripped him when this was only his imagination.

He tugged at a strand of damp hair and tucked it behind her ear. Her eyes were still closed, a faint smile was on her lips, and she didn't move. He kissed her. "That was hot," he said.

Zoe made a noise in answer, something between a growl and a

"mm-hmm."

He stared at her as she started to drift off, the cool feeling spreading all over his body.

Trying to be as casual as possible, forcing himself to smile and say the words lightheartedly, he kissed her ear. He made sure to do it in the "noisy, smacky" way that she hated, which was a sign that he was only kidding, only being fun.

"But you didn't really sleep with this guy in the car, right?"

There was a terrible moment of silence, and he thought maybe Zoe had fallen asleep. Just as he was deciding that was for the better, feeling relieved that she hadn't heard his bizarre desperation, she stirred.

"Hmm."

The tone of her voice revealed nothing. She didn't sound sleepy, as if she hadn't understood the question. Perhaps it was playfulness, or maybe she was still teasing him.

Or maybe - his groin throbbed with pain that followed the cold fingers of jealousy all over his body - maybe, she was telling him something else.

He watched her for a few minutes. Soon her breathing was slow, and she was clearly asleep. She smelled like tequila, he realized, sniffing the warm air hovering just above her damp neck.

He fell onto his back and closed his eyes.

Just drunk. Part of the game.

But the cold jealousy slithered inside of him and kept him awake for hours, his cock erect again, and Zoe sleeping peacefully, as still as a log.

*

The plan had been to wake up and casually draw Zoe into another session of sex, but he must have eventually fallen into a deeper sleep than he realized, because he woke up to the sound of water cascading in the shower.

"Don't," Zoe said, when he opened the shower door. She was smiling, her eyes closed under the torrent of water. "I'm running late and I have a huge hangover."

"I have a really, really good cure for that," Josh said, stepping into the shower anyway. One hand slid over her smooth, tiny waist,

slippery with conditioner she was washing from her hair. She slapped him with alarming accuracy and turned around to put her face in the water.

This didn't deter Josh, who kept moving in.

"I'm serious!" Zoe squealed, and because it was a squeal, he took it as potential encouragement. He easily encircled her, warm water streaming into his face, one hand moving up, the other sneaking down, seeking the sweet heat of her slit...

Which is why he didn't see her reach for the faucet handle. Very suddenly, the water was ice cold, and Josh jumped backward.

"Jesus!"

Zoe turned around again, her mouth open in a wide smile. She was impervious to shockingly cold temperatures, and shocks like that one did nothing to her. "I told you," she said, rinsing herself casually in the ice-cold water, as if it were still warm. Josh shivered, and watched her with pleasure as her nipples got hard.

Zoe reached behind her and punched the faucet off. She found her towel without opening her eyes, and wiped her face first. Then she kissed him briefly on the lips, smiled, and sauntered out of the shower stall.

Josh turned the water on hot while she dried off and walked around in the bedroom.

"So, who was this old guy you went out with last night?"

There was no immediate answer. Josh worried, for a moment, that she might not have heard him, or might be choosing to pretend so, in order to avoid answering the question.

"I didn't 'go out with him,'" Zoe said, appearing suddenly in the bathroom, dressed in black pants and a green sleeveless blouse, impeccably ordered, even though she had only been immersed in the closet for seconds. Her shoulder-length hair was still wet. "Fuck!"

she whispered. "This is what I mean, I think maybe I'm still drunk."

She ripped off her blouse and threw open a drawer in one swift movement. There was a clatter as she wrenched the hairdryer from the drawer and started to plug it in.

Josh watched with amusement from behind the glass screen. It was one of those long, walk-in showers with no door. He liked to joke that it was as big as his bedroom when he was a kid.

The hairdryer went on, so there was nothing to do but watch Zoe, flipping and turning and brushing her hair in nothing but a bra and her black work pants. He dried off at the long end of the shower, where Zoe had thoughtfully hung a towel for him.

He could see she was in a flustered hurry. Common sense should have told him not to press the issue, but there were plenty of things that Josh did not employ common sense for, most of which were related to sex. So he pressed.

"So, seriously. Who was this guy?"

Zoe cursed at something in the makeup drawer and tossed it back, opening a drawer below it. "I told you," she said, a hint of annoyance in her voice. She leaned against the counter, having found what she was looking for, and began applying mascara. "It's Derek McIntyre's dad."

She had not told him it was Derek McIntyre's dad. He knew this because the words "Derek McIntyre" made his heart race, just a little. Like any ex-boyfriend would.

But his dad? That was another demon entirely.

Josh watched her stabbing at her eye with feminine precision, while he contemplated the odd mixture of arousal and jealousy that this news caused.

"You were out pretty late," he said, trying to sound like he was making casual conversation but knowing he was doing a terrible job.

"Catching up on old times?"

Zoe looked at him in the mirror, her mascara wand poised close to her eye but somehow suggesting a threat to Josh. "I don't have time for this right now," she said, exasperated. "My car is at the park n' ride and I'm going to miss the six-thirty-two. Can you... like, get me some coffee or something?"

She finished applying her mascara, and dashed back to the closet.

Josh knew better than to keep pushing, but Zoe's evasiveness was nagging at him. That, and the pause he had witnessed, downstairs, before she had come up.

He fiddled with an unusual jar of lotion on the counter as Zoe raced back in, with a new blouse on, red, yellow and black, and

evocative of Mondrian. She began to fix her hair, after casting an annoyed look at him.

"Where did you guys go?"

"Some bar."

"Where did you run into him?"

Zoe gave her hair a few furious strokes with the brush, rolling her eyes. "Axe throwing." She grabbed the jar from him, set it down, and growled

with her fists balled up. "And that is the *truth*. Also, I am an amazing axe thrower. Now will you please, please, *please* go get me some coffee in a to-go cup?"

He pushed away from the counter and headed toward the door.

"Thank you," Zoe said, smiling.

"Did you make out with him?"

He lobbed this final question at her as jokingly as possible, ducking his head back into the doorway to ask it, using his deep, goofy-sounding "joke" voice. He expected her to roll her eyes, maybe throw something at him, or purr in a sultry voice, "You bet."

Either of those two reactions would have been normal, and fine.

This was not, after all, the first time that Zoe had engaged his fantasies, so she knew what the score was with him and jealousy.

She sometimes indulged him, and sometimes she did not.

But Zoe did not react in a predictable way. Her hand froze in midair, a tube of lipstick inches from her pink mouth. Her eyes flicked to meet his in the mirror, and her lips parted, making an "o," however briefly. Something flashed through her eyes, almost like fear.

The pause was brief, but far too long.

Her hand began to move again, her eyes still on his, and then she looked at the tube of lipstick to say:

"Of course not."

Her voice was soft, quite serious, the cadence a little too quick.

She looked up at her own reflection in the mirror and watched her eyes as she dabbed the lipstick clumsily over her mouth. "Don't be ridiculous."

Josh stepped out of the doorway, and paused against the wall.

A mirror across the room reflected Zoe, looking at him, through the two mirrors, and their eyes met for a moment. Or maybe not.

Stunned, without any further comment, he looked away quickly, and headed downstairs.

CHAPTER 3

Zoe leaned her head against the window and closed her eyes.

Her throat was dry, and her head felt desiccated and liquid at the same time. She'd had way too much to drink. Spent way too long out with Randy.

Gotten way too personal.

How had it happened? It was hard to remember.

He had given his own address to the Uber driver. They had started talking and he had forgotten to ask for her address, so the car stopped in front of his house - in Jackson Heights, which was the non-family version of Jackson Park and even wealthier - a stunning, modernist home, which seemed to be made entirely of glass and black timber. Water shimmered from within, reflecting on the ceiling visible from the street.

"This is *not* my house," she laughed.

"Shit," Randy commented. "I forgot all about taking you home."

This had been followed by an uncomfortable pause.

"It's okay, I can just ask the driver to -"

"Since we're here, want to come see it?" He talked over her, was already opening the door and getting out. While she hesitated, he opened her door, and held it open for her.

"Hey buddy," Randy said, leaning in to speak to the driver, placing his hand close to her thigh, his chest very near her face, and then his mouth, and then his bicep, in a consuming, drunken mosaic of images. "You can wait here, right, a few more minutes? Then we'll take this young lady home, and you can bring me back."

"It's like two bucks a minute," the kid said, and that was when Zoe noticed that the driver appeared to be even younger than her.

So young, in fact, he didn't seem to be old enough to drive a car.

"Here, I'll pay you now for this ride, here's twenty in cash for you to wait, and then you'll have another easy ride with a good tip after that if you do."

The kid took the cash while Randy tapped his payment in.

"Sure, man," he told him, in the unconvincing tone that all gig workers seemed to have.

"I can't stay very long," she had insisted, stepping out.

And then what? From there to the room with the pool. She gushed about it. He made her another drink.

"Uh," she began, because even through her intoxication, the vague sense that something was wrong with what she was doing, even if it *technically* wasn't wrong, was beginning to creep into her thoughts. "I... won't the driver not want to wait that long?"

"It's almost a guarantee, if he got a call anywhere around here, that he took off," Randy answered, as if he had been expecting the question. "I made this super-light, you can drink it and look at the view while we wait for the next Uber."

And sure enough, when they looked out the window, the Uber was gone. So she had clinked her glass against his, and he had requested another one, which put her at ease.

He had turned off the light so that she could admire the view over the parkway at the far end of the pool room, where the house seemed to hang precipitously on a cliff. There was a balcony at that end, and they stepped into the abrasive breeze and leaned on the railing and looked out over the city. She had said something about the view, and then there was a long silence.

"Are you happy with your husband... what's his name, Josh?"

he had asked, abruptly.

It took her by surprise, and then again, it did not. When she looked over at him, he seemed really interested in the answer. And for some reason, she was really interested in giving it to him. No one had asked her that, not even herself, since she had gotten married.

"I am," she said. There was an audible snag at the end of that sentence, an implied, "it's just..."

Randy cocked his head. Zoe laughed and looked at her half-empty drink.

"No, yeah, of course, I'm happy," she said.

"Yeah," Randy said, shaking ice cubes from the bottom of his glass and crunching them once they were in his mouth. "You're young. Everything is probably fine. I'm glad you found someone."

"I did," she assured him, and maybe herself.

He was still looking at her. The drinks were empty.

Zoe shook her ice cubes. "Is that... Uber here yet?" she asked.

This made them both laugh. She pushed her hair from her face. "I feel like this conversation got really heavy," she told him, looking out at the city.

"That's my fault," he had volunteered cheerfully. "Never have drinks with a man going through a divorce."

Zoe had laughed lightheartedly, sipped what was left of her drink - mostly melted ice.

"You don't want to have a heart-to-heart about it, do you? For old times' sake."

This was a reference to the several times she had ended up talking to him about her problems with her parents, or Derek, and she remembered those conversations in a flash. He had been immensely helpful. Maybe it was that, maybe it was the drinks. But she suddenly found herself diving in.

"Okay so..."

She had wavered there, not sure if she should jump in or not.

She had laughed. "No, it's way, way too personal and I don't want you to take it the wrong way or anything..."

"Now you *have* to tell me."

She glanced at him, found sincerity in his face, and... what else? She was just very drunk. Or perhaps it had been eating at her and she had wanted to talk to someone - anyone - about it. He was, after all, a psychotherapist.

"So, Josh has this... thing. That is, like... something I totally don't get. At all. And he - it's a sexual thing - you're going to be totally professional here, right? But also, I just want your opinion, as a man, and as a psychotherapist, because... I don't know, like, he told me about it, and I don't get it, and he said, that's okay, you don't really have to do it, so we just like, I don't know, role play about it, and that's fine because... whatever, like, it wasn't my thing and I don't get it, but the role-playing, I kinda get into, so everything is fine, but it still just really *mystifies me*, do you know what I mean? Like, I don't *get* why it turns him on and it kind of seems like... wrong."

Randy was looking at her with a very psychotherapisty face. He looked as if he had become entirely sober. "In terms of... something he wants to do to you, or something he wants you to do to him?"

Very professionally, he said this. He had his calm, counseling voice on.

Which may have been why she said, as though she were in fact seeing her own psychotherapist: "That's just it. It's not... uh, it's not him doing anything to me, or me doing anything to him. That's like, what I don't get."

"Does he want to have an open relationship?"

Still a calm, reassuring voice.

"Uh... okay, so, I know this sounds crazy, but I've like, checked with him about it like twenty-seven thousand times. What he wants...

he wants me to like - okay, and right now, this is all just pretend, like I just pretend that I did it, and that's all - but he wants me to, or he says he wants me to, have sex with another man."

He was unfazed.

"That's actually a remarkably common fantasy," he said. He tried to sip what was left of his drink, but there was nothing. He cleared his throat. "I, uh..." he checked his phone. "I'm going to get one for the road, you want something?"

"Why not," she slurred, handing him the glass. "Oh my god, I can't believe I just told you that."

They went back inside, he made the drinks, and she collapsed in a chair. "So not that uncommon?" she had said suddenly. "Are you serious? What the hell is up with that?"

Randy had smiled. Handed her another drink. It tasted like water and she suspected that it was. "A lot of men have expressed a similar fantasy to me. Most of them feel ashamed of it, probably for the reasons that you've expressed: it doesn't align with the common assumptions we make about male behavior. That they should be possessive of their own mates and that usually, promiscuity is a result of their urges, and not the other way around. I think it's a sign of good mental health that he felt he could share this

fantasy with you, and that you have allowed him to indulge in it to the extent that you have. Are you concerned that your playacting is not enough?"

Zoe's mouth was hanging open slightly. "Uh... I have to say, I don't know. I don't... I'm actually blown away by this. I, um... yeah, I guess I just... don't know."

"Does the playacting make you uncomfortable?"

"Uh... no, yeah, no, not the playacting itself. Just... like... what does that *mean*? Like, that's what I worry about. What does that *mean* that he wants me to act like I had sex with another guy? You know? It just seems really...dysfunctional."

"Hmm," Randy said, sipping his own drink. He swirled it. Even though her vision was a little blurry, she could see plainly that the liquid in his glass was alcohol by the way it clung to the sides. "Let me ask you to think about other role-playing that is much more common among the general population - this would be roles of domination and submission, perhaps BDSM, or women's very common rape fantasy. Many people role play in this way. Now, you could argue that rape and physical assault and confinement are all very dysfunctional, but it's my assessment that if these

"dysfunctional" behaviors are mutually satisfying, and take place between two people who are truly consenting, then they are not in fact dysfunctional. They are, actually, in my view, a mode of functionality. The fact that your husband feels comfortable sharing his sexual fantasy with you speaks to the trust he feels in your relationship."

Zoe made a sound, her mouth still open. "Oh...kay," she said.

"But like, what if he really wants me to do it? And then I do it? Don't you just think that would end in like, total disaster?"

"It sounds to me like you don't feel comfortable doing it."

"Because it would be a disaster."

"Hmm."

Zoe glared at him. "Oh, come on. You can't tell me that people have open relationships that totally work," she scoffed.

"Well, I think you're answering a different question than the one I really meant to ask you. Perhaps that's my fault. What I meant by the question was not whether you were uncomfortable doing it because you are afraid of the consequences... it was more along the lines of, are you comfortable doing it at all?"

Zoe gave her head a sharp shake. "Isn't that... like... the same...? Oh God," she said. She laughed. "I'm too, too drunk for this conversation, Dr. McIntyre."

"Have some more of that water."

"I thought you did that. That was a really good call."

And then, fortuitously, the phone had buzzed.

"Your chariot awaits," he said. "Let's go."

She gave him a funny look, and he held up his finger. "I told you I would make sure you got home safe, and that is what I shall do.

Sorry. You're the same age as my son. Dad's are gonna dad." He said this last sentence in a hokey voice, deliberately flubbing it. It was an odd outlier to his very suave persona, and it caught Zoe by surprise.

They had climbed into the car, she had given her address, they didn't say much on the way to her house - there wasn't much time for it, anyway.

He had walked her to the door.

"It was really, really great seeing you again, Zoe Landon." He had leaned back to peer up at the building. "Seems like you landed on your feet."

"It's no Jackson Heights," she had quipped.

He had tilted his head down to look at her. "Listen," he said, producing a card from seemingly nowhere and placing it in her purse without taking his eyes off of her. "If you want to talk any more about that... thing we were discussing... give me a call. Or if you just want to keep a lonely divorced guy company some time. Bring Josh, I'd like to meet him."

"Maybe we can double-date," she had said, lamely.

"Maybe," he had answered quietly.

And kissed her on the cheek. His lips were warm, and dry. He smelled like expensive cologne, very faintly. And whiskey. And leather.

"Thanks, doct- Randy."

"Please do not call me Dr. McIntyre again, Zoe."

He was smiling when he said this. She smiled back, whispered,

"K," and stumbled into the house.

Now, on the train, Zoe slipped her hand into her purse and felt for the card.

She had figured that, now that she was sober and the sun cast a harsh light on the events of the evening, she should chalk the whole thing up to drunkenness. It was best to move on, and by that, she meant something along the lines of: don't call Randy.

But there was something tugging at her. Something that made her not want to take this most obvious course of action.

Because it was obvious, wasn't it? Obvious that she harbored *some* attraction to Randy, and therefore it would be dangerous and wrong to keep seeing him, even if it was all done in the name of some kind of professional advice-seeking.

It was obvious that she shouldn't do that, even if she could tell herself that it was psychological curiosity about Josh's desires, not her attraction to Randy, that was tempting her to call him.

It was an obviously bad choice even if Randy *was* a professional, and had behaved professionally, and was the father of her ex-boyfriend and old enough to be her father, and surely wasn't interested in her in that way.

It was still a bad choice, even if she did, on some level, think that Josh was serious about his fantasy.

She would let fate decide, she decided, even though she was not a huge believer in fate or much of anything else.

If the card hadn't fallen out, if she could find it with her fingertips without looking into her purse, then she would call him. If not, she would not.

The chances of finding anything in her huge, disorganized handbag without looking were very low, and so she assuaged her guilt about even setting up that arbitrary scenario with the thought that she had stacked the decks high in favor of the "fate" of not calling Randy.

But when her hand went into the bag, her fingers searching with hungover clumsiness and hurry, she sliced her pointer finger on a piece of hard cardboard.

She retrieved the offending object and held it up.

It was Randy's card, and if there was any doubt about "fate," a tiny red stain was seeping into the upper edge.

CHAPTER 4

"So?"

Alicia sat on Zoe's desk and leaned backward to snatch something from her pen cup.

"I need some scissors."

Zoe nodded. The screen in front of her swam with problems, and she was too tired to attempt solving any of them.

"You look pretty tired," Alicia remarked, snipping the tag from a garment she held in her hand. "Did you stay out late with your Sugar Daddy?"

"What?" Zoe said, more flustered than she meant to be.

Quickly, she tried to tone it down, but heard herself flailing as she did. "He's - that guy was just an old friend. My, well, actually my ex-boyfriend's dad. Not... no, it was nothing like that."

The corners of Alicia's mouth were turning up with every word.

"Uh-huh," she said, leaning back again to deposit the scissors in their container. Alicia shopped online and had it delivered to work, and had not, evidently, considered getting her own pair of scissors.

She held the garment up: a garish crimson blouse with what looked like small skulls embroidered on the sleeves. "He was pretty hot for an old guy. So what, you two just... stayed up drinking and catching up on old times?"

"Yes," Zoe said, moving her mouse and clicking it for good measure.

"Is he single?"

Zoe turned to Alicia, dismayed. "What would -?"

"Not for you, *princesa*. I am *asking* for myself. Do you know I think he has a Jag? I saw it in the parking lot."

"He lives in Jackson Heights, so that's possible. We took a cab home."

"Is he a lawyer?"

"Doctor."

Alicia made a very strange, sexual purr, and Zoe looked up at her and squinted, shaking her head. Alicia could, and did, always turn the most banal comment about a man into some kind of sexual allusion. Since they'd been stuck bowling at the previous five Teambuilding Tuesdays, Zoe had, by now, just about heard it all.

Alicia had doctor examination fantasies that made Zoe blanche.

"Not that kind of doctor."

"What kind?"

"Shrink."

"Is he the kind that can prescribe? Or just talking?"

"Oh my God, Alicia," Zoe said, shaking her head.

"This is a financial question," Alicia said, holding the blouse up again. "I bet he's a drug doctor. You can't make that kind of money unless you prescribe drugs."

The matter settled, Alicia stood up. "You have his number, or what?"

"I'm..." Zoe sighed. "He's just going through a divorce," she finished, in an exasperated attempt to get Alicia to lose interest. She had no idea if Alicia was serious about her gold-digging "Sugar Daddy" quest, but with Alicia, it was best to assume that if it was something outrageous, she was probably in it for real.

"Oooh, I could help him out with that," Alicia said, deadpan.

And then, she laughed, spun around, and left, which didn't mean much either.

"I don't think I even know how to get a hold of him," she called out after Alicia.

"Yeah, of course not," Alicia said, shaking her head.

Zoe had no idea what that meant. She turned back to her computer.

It was hard to concentrate. She'd decided to give the whole question of contacting Randy a few days. Maybe she would have second thoughts, maybe she would see how silly it was, maybe she should feel out Josh's

reactions to the evening before first. She knew she should probably talk to Josh.

She should probably get to work.

The situation was not so easy to get out of her mind, which was yet another indication that she was treading into deep water.

When Josh had first told her about his fantasies, it had been a confession after a wedding they'd attended. They had both had quite a bit to drink, and there had been a lot of dancing going on. Josh wasn't a big dancer, and she had really torn a rug on the dancefloor.

She later had felt a little guilty, like maybe she was flirting too much with her dancing... but to her surprise, when Josh had brought it up, he'd seemed to like it.

Since that first evening, he'd confessed his fantasy in discrete packets, gradually and over time. She had not known what to think at the beginning, but eventually she'd decided it was like her own fantasies - something she thought about, but didn't really have any interest in actually *doing*.

The thing about the fantasies of her own that she'd compared Josh's fantasy to, is that they weren't the sort of thing she would ever tell him about. They didn't involve any actual people, per se, or even Josh - they were more about acts of BDSM and vague, nebulous happenings. The person doing those things to her in those fantasies wasn't necessarily Josh, but it wasn't necessarily *not Josh*, either. It was all kind of abstract.

So, for a long time, she took his fantasies to be the same kind of thing. She didn't mind indulging him in a fantastical way, saying she'd done things she hadn't with other men, who often didn't even exist.

In reality, however, they weren't the same kind of fantasies. As time went on, she began to see a pattern to when he wanted her to play that role, and it was always after a situation when some interaction *had* really taken place between her and another man.

So then she had begun to wonder if Josh's fantasies weren't more real, more akin to whatever it was inside of her that drove her to "sort of" flirt with other men, to have the attention and desire of men who she had no intention of actually pursuing anything with.

She *liked* knowing that someone was attracted to her, pining for her, and she walked a fine line between actively encouraging and discouraging it.

Because, at the end of the day, Josh was the man she loved, and she didn't want to do anything to jeopardize that relationship.

Her attraction to other men was sort of cerebral, rather than physical.

Or something like that. She didn't quite have a handle on what it was that had made her call Randy - just that it wasn't purely innocent, and it also wasn't the intention of having an affair with the man.

But at moments like this, she did wonder how real Josh's fantasies were. If they both got very drunk, he sometimes said that they were really very real, and that he really would like her to have sex with another man. But he admitted to it with a kind of guilty shame, and she had always dismissed the confession afterward as something else... the kind of uninhibited drunken crazy-talk that at the time seems like a brilliant idea, and then in the morning, clearly wasn't.

She looked at her computer screen.

If Josh's fantasies *were* real, was she trying to get herself into a position where she could indulge them?

With Randy?

She closed her eyes and put her hands over her face as if she had just made the confession out loud.

Randy.

Her ex-boyfriend's dad.

He was like fifty-something.

That was *fucking crazy*.

A crazy thought.

Her stomach twisted. She began typing, trying to work diligently enough to put it all out of her mind.

Randy was a friend. Almost like a father-figure. He was going through a divorce.

The very best thing to do, she decided, was to do nothing.

This would all fade from her mind in a few days, and that was for the best.

CHAPTER 5

"How you feelin', slugger?"

"How did *you* beat *me* home from work?" Zoe asked, genuinely surprised.

"Oh, yes. Well, Stark, it turns out, actually has a life, and so he canceled this afternoon's meetings so *he* could do the stuff *he* needed to do. That doesn't mean I don't have to spend most of the night working, oh, no. It just means that I can do it here. So... great, right?"

"Yeah, Pete's a real gem."

There was no love lost between Pete Stark and Zoe. She'd only met him once, but Zoe was quick to suss out and be repulsed by a guy like Pete: slick millennial, always greasing things in his own favor, petty, arrogant, not nearly as talented or smart as he thought he was. But Pete possessed the kind of qualities, and lack of remorse, that made him get ahead in cutthroat businesses. And he'd been making Josh's life hell. Zoe had sized it up pretty quickly: Pete knew Josh was a better designer, and thusly a threat to what she called his "bullshit parade."

She couldn't stand him.

Zoe was always pretty, no matter what state of sleeplessness or hangover she was in, but she looked pretty beat. Very faint dark circles ringed her eyes, and she lacked her usual bounce. She collapsed onto a barstool at the kitchen island and rested her head on her hand. "Tell the truth," she said, "I'm pretty glad you have to work, because for a second I thought you'd want me to go dancing with you or something," she said, leaning her head on her arm as she stretched it out on the counter. She yawned. "Man. I think I might be getting too old for this kind of thing."

Josh set a glass of red liquid in front of her. It was his homemade hangover cure, with a list of ingredients that began as a Caesar and then got fairly revolting-sounding.

Zoe sat up and blinked at the glass. "Oh, man," she said.

"Just drink it. I also have..." he said, spinning around, Styrofoam containers suddenly in his hands, "Indian from Delhi Deli."

"Butter chicken?"

"Of course. But only if you finish your drink."

She wrinkled her nose. "Josh, it's so gross!"

"Don't drink so much. With older, attractive men. And then you won't have this problem." He nudged the glass toward her.

She picked it up, and, actually pinching her nose - not out of drama, but because if she smelled it beforehand it made her queasy

- she started to drink.

Josh studied her as she gulped it down. She hadn't responded to his last quip, not even with so much as an eye roll. And while he knew he had better leave it alone, he couldn't help himself. It was an itch, and he was helpless to stop himself from scratching it.

Zoe set the glass down, still one-quarter full. She shook her head. "That's the best I can do," she told him. "Ugh. Thank you, though."

"How much did you have to drink last night, anyway?"

"Too much."

"Where did you say you went?"

She looked at him for a moment, her lips taut. There were times when Zoe became irritated with him, and his games, and his questions designed to initiate those games. He could never really tell when she was going to tip toward that irritation, but she sort of looked that way now.

"Oh, Josh... honestly, I don't remember."

"And this was your ex-boyfriend's dad?"

"It was," she answered, her tone coy. Her attention seemed to have been captured by the container of butter chicken he had opened. She stood on the lower rungs of the barstool, tucked a foot under her leg, and leaned over to stab a piece with a fork.

" *Derek's* dad."

"I told you that," she said, her mouth open as she tried to cool the chicken off. "Jesus, that's hot."

"Spicy or-"

"Temperature."

She chewed and sat back down, her eyes flicking up to meet his gaze. "It was Derek's dad. He's an old guy, and getting divorced, and I don't know where we went because I was drunk, and then we just... ended up talking a lot, he's like, kind of a sad guy because of his divorce, and then..." she fluttered her eyelashes and made a sexy face, teasing him for a moment. "...I came home. And that is literally all that happened."

Josh was attacked by the twin prongs of relief and disappointment, as he always was whenever Zoe played his games but, in the end, revealed that it was all a joke. "Getting divorced, huh?" he said, trying again, for no good

reason other than that he was a man. "I'm pretty sure that was not an entirely platonic conversation from his point of view."

Zoe fluttered her eyes upward. "I dated his *son*. Very non-platonically." She shook her head, as if she'd made some kind of point with that remark and the matter was settled.

Zoe, who was somewhat of a tomboy, and did a lot of crazy extreme sports and was therefore often in the vicinity of many men, did not seem to have her head around the male mind as much as she ought to, Josh thought. Which was fine with him, really, but it sometimes made him wonder if she was up to something more nefarious and trying to throw him off the scent.

"I... am not sure that's the kind of thing that matters to a guy,"

Josh suggested.

"That a woman is half his age and was having adolescent sex with his son like ten years ago?"

Josh smirked and shook his head. "It's outside of my own age range, so I can't speak from experience, but... I don't know, it's kinda hot."

"Kinda weird." Zoe shook her head and stabbed at another piece of chicken, which she was transporting dangerously over the counter without a plate. She made a noise. "Gahd. Guys are so...

twisted."

"Yes," Josh said happily. "We are."

Zoe chewed, and looked at him. Swallowing in hurry, to say what she wanted to say, she furrowed her brow. "You're not... like,

you know how you're always... you wouldn't think that was hot, would you? A guy that old? With me?"

For a moment, it was as if a polar vortex had breathed all over him, and him alone, and his blood turned to ice in his veins. His stomach turned to a

block of ice, vibrating inside of him, tremors traveling to his testicles. His fork was mid-air, and it almost fell from his hand.

He looked down at the butter chicken. "I... you know... *actually*," he stammered.

For how was Zoe to know that in the darkest corners of his mind, the places she had yet to hear about or explore, the place behind the curtain he thought he would never pull back for her... that it was precisely the thing that Josh imagined when he imagined his wife with another man.

An older man. A man who would teach her to do very, very hideous things. A man with experience, a man who would patiently, carefully groom her.

And these thoughts were by far his darkest, because it was in the hands of an older man that his fantasy-Zoe became the very filthiest.

These were also the truest fantasies, and he felt as if he had just been caught indulging in them.

"Only if he's good-looking," he tried to joke.

But Zoe was already looking at him, because it had taken too much time for him to say that. Perhaps only a second too long, but it was too long nonetheless. Zoe blinked, stunned, and then, as she often did when she realized she had looked too far inside of him, she looked away.

"He's... are you *serious*? " she snorted. "He's in his *fifties*. " She had a cheerful, friendly tone, trying to lighten the conversation after that dark turn.

"Is he good-looking?" Josh quipped back, trying to salvage his pride. Maybe if he continued to "joke" about it, Zoe would actually think it was all a joke, and not see into his dark, perverted thoughts like she seemed to a moment ago.

But it was Zoe who paused too long this time. She played with the butter chicken, and shrugged, and looked up at him, and then

down again. "He's... I mean, not like... but I guess he's good-looking.

I just..." she set her fork down and gave a sigh of exasperation. "It's Derek's *dad*, " she said. "I don't know if he's good-looking. I can't...

think of him like that."

She shook her head vigorously as if to underscore the point.

"You can't tell if he's good-looking?"

"Alicia - you know Alicia, at work? She wants his number."

Josh raised his eyebrows. Zoe put some chicken in her mouth.

She waved her fork as she spoke next. "But Alicia is pretty materialistic, and she found out he drives a Jag. So that doesn't mean anything, necessarily."

She waved her hand in front of her mouth. "That's hot, spicy-hot," she said. "Can you grab me some water?"

He fetched her some water from the fridge while she formed an

"o" with her mouth and waved her hand in front of her face. She gulped it when he gave it to her. "Wow, that came out of nowhere."

For a split-second, he thought she might be talking about his comments about Randy, and he considered mentioning the evening before, the sex they'd had, which had obviously been hot for both of them. But then it occurred to him, just before he stepped in it, that she was talking about the spice of the butter chicken.

"Yeah," he agreed listlessly.

She took another sip of water. He retrieved a foil-wrapped naan from the opposite counter and set it on the table for her. She started eating it, chewing thoughtfully, and he busied himself by taking a bite of the butter chicken.

"So," she said, and then interrupted herself to take a long drink of water. "In all seriousness, Randy did give me his card. He -" she waved her hand in front of her mouth. "Wow, that is really too hot."

She ate another bite of bread.

And then she seemed to forget that she had been talking about the good-looking, rich father of her ex-boyfriend, with whom she had stayed up late drinking with, and who had "given her his card."

Josh waited.

"He...?" he prompted, after several moments went by without Zoe saying anything.

"What?" she asked, as if she really didn't have any idea what he was asking. "Oh. Yeah... Dr. McIntyre gave me his card. He said, well... I don't know, he wouldn't mind getting a coffee or something sometime."

The cool fear in Josh's chest returned, slithering through his body. "What did you say?"

Zoe looked at him, and shrugged. "Uh, nothing, I guess. I just...

I don't know. I feel sort of bad for him, and he was a really good... I don't know, kind of father-like figure to me for a long time. He's a psychiatrist. He's interesting to talk to about... I don't know. Stuff."

"So are you thinking about doing that?"

A pause. "Doing what?"

"Calling him for coffee. Or something." Josh's chest was tight and his heart was racing. He couldn't pin down whether it was the itch of jealousy, or the itch of temptation, that clawed inside him.

Zoe shrugged again. "I don't know. I thought I'd ask you how you feel about it."

This was, Josh realized, as perfect of an opening as he might ever have if he did want to open up to Zoe about the depths of his desires. It was the perfect time to take her hand and tell her that, actually, he loved the idea because he'd been keeping a part of his fantasy a secret from her. And here it was, laid at his doorstep.

But the thing about Zoe was that he could never quite tell if *she* believed he was serious or not. He could never quite bring himself to insist that he was, because he could never suss out whether she was simply indulging what she believed to be pure fantasy, or taking him more seriously.

Did he want to be taken seriously? Did he really want his wife to think that his fantasy was more than just a mental exercise to get off on when they were having sex? Because the other thing about Zoe was that if she came across a challenge, and it was dangerous and held the promise of adrenaline, she would only demur for a while.

And then, she would do it. She was that kind of girl.

It was true that this was different than skydiving or base-jumping or heli-skiing. It was not a sport, and it didn't involve the kind of dangers that those extreme sports did. But he knew that if Zoe got the idea that he really wanted it, she would perceive it as a

challenge, and she might just do it for the same reasons -

unfathomable reasons, in his opinion - that she did all the crazy things that she did.

He slid the naan toward himself and pulled apart a piece.

"Look, it's up to you, Zoe," he said.

"It's just coffee," she told him, almost as if he had accused her of something.

Josh shrugged. "Then what are you asking me for?"

Zoe, by nature of her affinity for extremes, had a lot of male friends. They didn't go for coffee, and Josh would be lying if the thought never crossed his mind that something might be going on between them. But he knew, with the same feeling of relief and disappointment, that there *was* nothing between them.

Zoe chewed thoughtfully on her naan. Then she shrugged. "I don't know. I... well, you're the one who brought it all up," she said, changing her tone to something more accusatory.

Josh swallowed, buying himself a little time to review the conversation that had just taken place. She was right, of course. She was always right.

"If you don't want me to, I won't."

"I didn't say that."

Zoe sighed, as if this exasperated her. She tossed a piece of naan back at the foil. "I'm so tired," she complained. "I think I'm making a way bigger deal out of this conversation than I need to."

She stood up, came around the island, and gave him a kiss on the cheek. "I know this is going to seem very old-lady-like, but I am going to bed."

Josh looked at the clock. "It's not even seven."

"I'm going to watch some Netflix. But seriously. I feel like crap."

He pulled her close to him. "I could probably make some time, before I get to work, if you want to Netflix and chill..."

"Hmm," Zoe said, a twinkle in her eye. She spun out of his grip and began walking out of the kitchen. "If you think you can spare the time..." she said, as she walked into the hallway.

Josh only hesitated a moment before following her, because as much as the "Randy thing" was gnawing at his mind, the way Zoe's

hips swayed suggestively sent most of those thoughts scurrying to dark corners.

Zoe had shimmied out of her work clothes and was dropping her panties to the floor by the time he reached the room. She climbed onto the bed, unfastening her bra, smiling invitingly. "Come here, workaholic husband," she said, invitingly, with the kind of smile that he didn't want to interfere with.

Sex was sweet and fun, at least in the world outside of Josh's mind. He couldn't know what Zoe was thinking, as she clutched him to her and came at the same time that he did. He always wondered, with that kind of timing, if Zoe wasn't faking it.

She smiled, and kissed him on the ear, and then rolled onto her side.

"I am *so* glad I'm not you right now," she said. It was friendly, warm, and she seemed to have forgotten all about Randy and the conversation they had just had.

He leaned over her, one arm stroking the curves of her body.

"No Netflix?" he asked her. He watched her heavy eyelids fall, and he could see she was going to fall asleep before she even answered the question.

He rested his head on his palm, propped up by his elbow, and with the scent of sex and Zoe's shampoo wafting from her body, he stared out the window and replayed their conversation, over and over and over again, trying to squeeze from it the delicious pain of Zoe maybe lying to him, or of there being something more to Randy than she was saying.

He had missed his chance. The chance to tell her about his fantasies. The sting of cowardice mixed with the pleasure of the thought of Zoe and this mysterious Randy. Randy the older man, with a Jag, who Zoe couldn't think of like "that" because she had dated his son.

Randy, who had asked her out for coffee or something.

He was getting hard again, but Zoe seemed to be actually asleep. He nuzzled her ear and stroked her breast hopefully.

She swatted at him, still half-asleep.

"Josh seriously, I'm beat. Don't you have to work?"

He made a non-committal sound.

"Go," she said, almost whining.

It was the sort of vague rejection that had a perfectly reasonable explanation, and it shouldn't have caused the dull ache in his groin or the cold pain in his chest, but it did.

And he kind of liked it.

He climbed out of bed, and slid his boxers on, giving one last look at his sleeping wife.

He really did need to get to work.

CHAPTER 6

She had practiced what she would say more times than she cared to admit. In the car, sitting in traffic. There was a balance to be reached, a careful blend of flirtatious, and not. It would have helped if she knew exactly what blend she was going for, herself.

She waited a week to call him, because that seemed like the thing to do. The fact that she had waited a week to call him stained her heart a little with guilt, because that was the kind of time frame one waited before calling a romantic interest, if you believed popular dating lore.

She assuaged this guilt by telling herself that it was the age of Fevr and hookup culture, and also by telling herself she was seeking a purely professional, fatherly conversation with Randy. Like in the old days. And she felt a little sorry for him.

She was grateful to reach his voicemail. It was a standard greeting, only his name given, and she decided to ignore the way the hairs on her neck stood up on end when she heard his voice.

"Hey, Doc. It's me, Zoe Wilson. We met the other night at the bar? I was the one with the axe. I'm fairly sure you got me home,"

she began.

It was cute. Somewhat flirtatious, but with plausible deniability -

to Randy, or Josh, or herself.

"Anyway, um, I wanted to say thanks for listening to my drunk ramblings, and uh, also... well, I have a coworker who will not leave me alone about you, so, if you need a date sometime, I can easily fix you up with a very tall and attractive woman who is only slightly crazy. So, yeah... give me a call, if you want that, or just, like a less boozy coffee or something. Okay. Well. Bye."

She ended the call with a swipe and stared at her phone, mortified by herself. Her stomach was cool and knotted, a sensation she hadn't felt for a long time. This was a warning sign, she told herself, that she was up to something she shouldn't be.

But this was all just fun, right? And it was fun that Josh had basically given her permission to have. And it was, crucially, fun she intended to keep in the realm of fun.

She put her phone away, leaving the vibration off, just to prove to herself how little she cared if and when he called her back. Her heart was pounding as she adjusted herself primly in her chair and threw herself into work.

When five-thirty rolled around, she worked a little late, and then packed up her things, letting her phone remain in her bag, nagging at her thoughts. She walked out to her car, got in, turned it on, turned on the AC, fiddled with things, put her seatbelt on, and then, pantomiming a sudden afterthought to the audience of herself, she took the phone out of her handbag.

His message appeared with only a number, because she hadn't programmed him in. Guilt washed through her on the heels of an excited flutter when she saw the message preview.

I'm free after 7 almost every night this week

Her breath was trapped in her chest, and it began to ache as she sat there, staring.

"Why are you doing this?" she whispered to herself.

It was a real question, one she'd like to know the answer to.

Was she doing it, as she told herself, because she wanted to know more about Josh's fantasy from a shrink's perspective? Because she was thinking about actually indulging Josh? Or because she wanted to flirt with Randy, and danger?

Josh, predictably, had also sent her a message, and its content came as no surprise. If anything, she could think of it as a sign.

Babe, I'm sorry, this project is falling apart and I probably won't get home until late. I'm so so so so sorry, go get some good takeout and only leave me the worst stuff.

This was a joke, because she had done that very thing once to spite him for being late so many nights in a row and asking her to

leave him takeout. She felt a pang reading their shared joke, a real pang of love for Josh, which was also followed by another vague wave of guilt.

Her eye drifted back to Randy's message. She tapped the phone, and her thumb hovered over the message bubble.

Are you free tonight? I just got stood up for dinner

She hesitated, and then, as Zoe so often did with dangerous things, she jumped in recklessly, and sent the message.

He replied almost immediately.

Yes

She stared at the screen as the dots rolled along the bottom, Randy was typing, and she was waiting with bated breath.

Not because she was going to cheat on Josh, she reminded herself. Just because she was going to flirt with danger, and have some company at dinner for once, and get to the bottom of this sexual issue...

Meet me at Meade Street Station at 7:30?

She typed, "Okay," even though she didn't know where or what Meade Street Station was, and then, with the thrill that came with recklessness, to which she was ever-so-slightly addicted, she tossed her phone back into her bag and put her car in reverse.

CHAPTER 7

Meade Street Station, it turned out, was a bar just down the street from her townhouse, which she marveled at for several moments, staring at Google Maps. She realized that she spent very little time enjoying the neighborhood she had been so insistent on moving to, mostly because Josh was always working late, and usually she went out with people from work closer to their campus in the Tech Ring, a suburbia filled with office towers and chain restaurants like Applebee's.

She stood in front of the walk-in closet and surveyed her wardrobe. Josh's clothes hung neatly on one side, shirts equidistant from each other in almost militarized precision. Josh, being a graphic designer, liked things to look nice, and she knew he despaired at her messiness. She wasn't a slob, but her shirts hung loosely from hangers or were tucked onto the bottom bar, sometimes four to a hanger, because she had been too lazy to hang them up properly.

She shouldn't be thinking about what to wear, she told herself, as she scanned her choices. She should just wear what she was wearing and make

the statement to Randy that she hadn't invested any time choosing an outfit, for one purpose or another.

She looked down at her work clothes.

She would never meet a girlfriend in these clothes. Right? She would change. And she would put on something cute, because she liked to look good. Not because she wanted to actually attract men, but because she wanted to be attractive and know that she could.

Josh approved of this. He always complimented her sexier outfits, always seemed to enjoy it when she wore them.

So there was nothing, technically, different about choosing a good outfit to go meet Randy.

Annoyed at herself for over-thinking the situation, she snagged a tight red shirt with a low neckline and a pair of jeans that made her butt look very good. It was a go-to casual outfit. She picked up some high-heeled open-toed sandals and took the whole thing out to the

bedroom, where she changed hastily and without looking in the mirror, as if doing it that way would mean that she was less invested in the result.

She put makeup on hastily, as if there were someone there to observe her and comment on how much time she took with it. Zoe had milky skin, and a smattering of freckles across her nose, and she didn't wear much makeup or need it. Lipstick, if it was anything but a gloss, often looked strange on her. But her shirt was so red, and there was a tube of orange-red that matched the color precisely...

She put it on, glanced at her mouth, liked the results very much, and so, with only a moment's hesitation - that perhaps it was too bright, or too trashy - she spun on her heel and headed back downstairs. She didn't have time to overthink it.

And overthinking it would imply that she was thinking about something other than what she wanted to believe she was thinking about, so she mostly

left in a hurry just to prove that very point to herself.

*

Randy did not hide the fact that he walked his eyes up and down her body, but he also didn't call attention to it. He was wearing a white shirt with rolled-up sleeves and jeans, looking decidedly un-doctorly. She glanced at him quickly, took in the salt-and-pepper stubble that screamed "five-o'clock shadow," and then averted her gaze to the two margaritas already on the counter.

"I took the liberty of ordering you the house specialty," he said, and she could feel him still looking at her. It seemed like heat was radiating from his stare, setting the right side of her body on fire as she settled into the stool next to him.

"Oh, boy," she said, picking up the margarita. She sipped it and set it back down. It was good, but strong - not one of those chain-restaurant margaritas made of mix and a single shot of tequila, but a real margarita, almost entirely tequila with a little bit of orange and lime juice to make it qualify as a cocktail and not a gigantic shot. "I thought this was a brewery," she said, turning to Randy, who was

looking right at her. A tremor snaked through her when she realized he looked pleased.

"You didn't bring your tall and attractive, slightly crazy friend,"

Randy said.

Zoe had the margarita back close to her mouth, and she pulled it away, making some of it slop onto her lips. She wiped them hastily, annoyed that some of her lipstick went with them, and laughed. "Oh, shoot," she joked. "I'm sorry, I didn't realize you actually wanted to meet her."

"I don't."

There was an awkward beat of silence, because he had said it with a sexually-laden intensity that made her heart skip a beat.

What the hell was she doing?

"I have all the crazy I can handle," Randy said, after letting the comment simmer a while. As if he had been joking all along.

"Occupational hazard."

"I figured," Zoe said, facing the bar and scanning the alcohol as if it had suddenly become very important to her.

"Josh is working late tonight, I take it?"

Something about him saying Josh's name felt claustrophobically intimate, and she was thrown a little off-guard. It took her a moment too long to answer. "Yeah, well. It happens."

"Frequently?"

She shrugged, wanting suddenly to defend Josh's late nights.

"He's... it's a new job, he's a freelancer, kind of, so he has to really hustle. Just for now. It won't always be this... busy," she said, lamely.

Randy looked at her for just a beat too long. "Well," he said.

"His loss, my gain. I'm glad you could come. I'm a bit too old to be sitting at a bar by myself." He leaned in confidentially. "It looks creepy."

"So I'm sort of your beard," Zoe offered.

"Something like that," Randy agreed. "I'm really just here for the fish and chips."

"You could get take-out."

He smiled at her. "Not hot by the time you eat them."

It was silly, harmless banter, she told herself.

"Okay, well, order away. I'll make sure you don't look creepy."

Randy looked her up and down again. Turning toward the bar and sliding a menu toward himself, he said, "I probably still look a little creepy. But at least I look like a successful creep."

"Huh," Zoe laugh-mumbled.

They looked at the menus in silence.

Zoe flipped hers over once she had made her decision, and then theatrically pored over the liquor. Randy was still studying the menu.

"I thought you always got fish and chips."

"I do."

She grinned and played with the tiny sword in her drink. It was tempting to fish the cherry out of the drink and bite into it, but she didn't want to do anything that Randy might take the wrong way.

Because that was *not* why she was here.

A band was setting up on a small stage at the front of the restaurant.

"I've never been in here," she told him, watching the band.

"Me either. You're kidding me. I thought all the cool kids came here."

Her mouth was open when he looked at her.

"That's why I picked it."

"I thought..."

He was shaking his head.

She felt, suddenly, very foolish. Whatever "heat" she had been picking up from Randy had evaporated, and now she was the one who felt mildly creepy. He really was just trying to have a nice time, probably *did* feel creepy going out by himself, because he was just a fifty-two year old man who was getting divorced.

"So..."

"So." Randy smiled. He gave his margarita a stir with his own stick, pulled the cherry out, and took it off, setting it on the napkin.

"Why did you call me?" he said, after a moment, during which time a knot had grown in Zoe's stomach. The question was asked in a mild tone, no emphasis on any particular word, as if she was actually meeting her shrink for a session and not her ex-boyfriend's father for a drink.

"You... I..." she stammered. Who *asked* questions like that?

Right off the bat.

Randy waited, his eyes piercing.

"I... to have a drink."

"You seem a little nervous."

Zoe found herself mortified. She started to shake her head. "I'm not, like, nervous, it -"

"The best thing to do, if you're feeling nervous," Randy said calmly, "is just to say what's making you feel that way, and then, watch, it won't seem scary anymore. Try it. You're nervous because..."

Zoe grasped her drink with both hands. "Oh my god," she muttered. She sipped. "Okay," she closed her eyes. "I'm nervous because I want to talk to you about what we talked about last time we... talked."

"I told you to call me if you wanted to do that," Randy said calmly.

She looked at him. "Yeah, I... but..."

"So that would be a silly thing to be nervous about."

She stared at him, her lips making a strange smile flutter across her features. What the hell was she supposed to say to that?

"I think maybe you're nervous about some other aspect of that topic. Maybe you're afraid of discussing it. Maybe you feel conflicted about discussing an intimate topic with another man. Maybe it's something else."

Zoe gaped. "Like... what?" she managed to say.

Randy smiled and puffed a vague laugh through his nose. "This is where I say, 'what do you think it is?'"

"What do you guys spend so much time doing in school?" Zoe said, jumping on the chance to escape actually discussing the topic at hand. "That's all you really ever say."

"Well. I don't know what psychologists do, but I had to learn CPR."

"Funny."

"Are you avoiding the question?"

"Yes."

He raised his glass. "Then I would say this is a very average session. Welcome to my life."

"How much do you get to charge for this sort of thing?"

"A lot more if you never answer."

"And just keep coming back."

"You get the idea," he said, winking. She clinked her glass gently against his.

"So, do you want to talk about what we talked about last time?"

Zoe looked around. "Honestly, not right here," she said. There were almost ten people within earshot.

"How about a booth? Pretty soon the band will be playing and no one will be able to hear you, not even me."

So they moved. Settled in to a small booth, with high backs that did seem to afford some type of insulation from the people around them.

She finished her drink quickly and ordered another one from the promptly appearing waitress. Randy followed suit, although his glass was still half-full.

"So," he said, leaning on his elbows and folding his hands in front of his chin. "What's making you nervous?"

Zoe looked to the side and rolled her eyes. She took a deep breath, and then the urge to jump into things grabbed her again. She inhaled and looked back at Randy. "I'm nervous because I want to talk to you about this topic and I don't want you to get the wrong idea about anything, like, you know..."

"What would the wrong idea be?"

Zoe's breath left in a huff.

What, indeed?

"That, you know, I don't know, I'm looking to have an affair or something."

Randy leaned back. "An affair with me? Or just an affair in general?"

"What?"

"Which one of these things would be the wrong idea?"

The waitress came back with their drinks. Zoe rubbed her forehead. "Uh... in general. Both. Either one." Her palms were sweating.

"I see. There. Now you've told me why you're nervous. I understand, going forward, that you are not trying to have an affair of any kind."

Zoe stirred her drink. "I don't feel better," she told him sullenly.

He discarded his cherry again, neatly, on the side of the napkin.

"I suspect that's because you haven't told me why you're really nervous."

Zoe lifted her eyes and met his.

"You know, you sound a lot like Hannibal Lecter."

"Wonderful. I've been working on that for a long time."

Zoe looked up at the ceiling and made a noise of frustration.

"So what do you think I'm nervous about?" she challenged. "I'm not paying you for this, so you might as well cut to the chase."

He cocked his head. Played with his plastic sword. Leaned forward. "Okay, Zoe. I think you're nervous because you are considering having an affair, and having a difficult time admitting that to yourself."

A wave of heat, reminiscent of humiliation and arousal and pressure, all at the same time, washed over her. She was certain that her skin had turned bright pink, and she was left speechless.

Beads of sweat developed almost instantaneously at her neck and along her hairline.

Randy leaned back and sipped his margarita as if he had just repeated the weather forecast.

There were many things that occurred to Zoe all at once, and her mouth moved senselessly, forming the beginnings of each and every one of these thoughts. Sweat trickled from her neck, between her shoulder blades, and along her spine, creeping slowly, stone-cold.

"I didn't mean," Randy said, in a gentle tone, reaching across the table to pat her hand, which was resting helplessly on the base of her margarita goblet, "that you wanted to have an affair with *me*."

Just that, you seem to be toying with the idea of doing it, and you seem to want someone besides your husband to give you the green light."

Zoe sank back into the booth, relieved that he had said this, because she was beginning to suspect two things: that he was right

about her desire to have someone tell her it was okay, but also, that she was contemplating - even if she had no intention of *doing* it -

having that affair with Randy.

"I'm really... I'm really *not*, " she said, after a lengthy pause. "It's not that I'm thinking of having an affair, or anything... not like, I would really do it. And anyway, an affair isn't really what he wants me to have. It's just... I *am* thinking about it like, I am thinking about it. You know? It's in my thoughts. That's all." She sipped her drink.

"Because it seems weird to me," she added.

Randy was ready with the next question, composed and calm.

"What is it about it that 'seems weird' to you?"

She made her eyes bulge and shook her head. "It doesn't seem weird to you?" she asked, in mock exasperation.

Randy returned a calm stare. "I've heard it all. So, no. Not exactly. Like I told you, it's a common fantasy."

"How many people actually do it, though?" she demanded, folding her arms. She felt adolescent, like the time they had discussed a political topic one night when Randy and Cherie had come home from a dinner party drunk, and Zoe and Derek had already siphoned a great deal of booze from the liquor cabinet. In the end, she and Randy had stayed up discussing

things, Cherie had gone to bed, and Derek had fallen asleep at the kitchen table.

"I have no way of knowing that," Randy said calmly. "But plenty of people do it. There are entire apps dedicated to people who do this -"

"You're talking like, swingers, though," she interjected. "This is different - this is, he wants me to have sex with another guy. While he watches. Ideally. And not the other way around. So not *swingers*."

"Hotwife."

"Wha?"

"You're talking about hotwifing. Or cuckolding. Just depending on how it happens."

"You're making that word up."

Randy pulled out his phone, swept his fingers over the screen, typed something in, and turned the phone toward her.

A Google search had revealed thousands of results for this word, and, based on the previews of the content, it did in fact mean

what he said it meant.

"That's..." she said, shaking her head. She clicked on a link and an explicit photo of a woman sucking a man's cock, looking directly at the photographer, off to the side, filled the screen. She minimized it with a reflexive action, but not before reading the caption: "My hotwife sucks big cocks."

She turned the phone face-down to pass it over to him. "Jesus,"

she muttered. "You should really use some filters."

Randy tucked the phone in his pocket. "I like to know what's really out there," he said, without missing a beat. "The point is just that, as you can

see, this is a common enough fantasy to have its own lingo, and communities on the internet. So if your concern is that it seems like a really... unusual fantasy, which might make you think it's dysfunctional... you can see that it isn't all that unusual."

Zoe shook her head again. She wasn't sure why she wanted to argue with him: it was, after all, good news in a way. It meant that Josh wasn't totally bonkers, and that maybe there were people who did this sort of thing.

"The thing is," she said. "I just can't believe that people do this and don't have any problems because of it. Like... I just *don't get* what it is that, like, he could possibly want out of this."

"Is this because you are imagining how you would feel if you watched Josh have sex with another woman?"

Zoe hugged herself again. Then she rolled her eyes skyward.

"You just think you're so fucking smart," she complained. "Yeah, I mean... yeah. I wouldn't like that. I would be pissed. The idea of doing that... like, watching, or having him, like, tell me details about it, or even pretend like he did it, it's just... gross."

"So you have tried empathizing with him and found that you don't."

"Well..."

"Have you tried just asking him?"

"Asking him what?"

"Asking him what he likes about it."

"I told you, I already indulge in his fantasies sometimes, so, I mean, of course I've talked to him about it."

"So, think very hard about this question Zoe. Have you ever, in a very non-confrontational way, asked Josh what he likes about it?"

"Don't be stupid. He told me about this, and I was like: 'why?'"

That's the first thing I asked."

"Did you say it like that?"

She glared at him.

He put his fingers together and then to his lips. "Have you ever asked him, perhaps employing an approach in which you stress that you want to *understand* him, asked him? Because when you ask

'why?' and sound incredulous, I assume that he may feel threatened or become defensive. But if you were to ask him, starting out by saying, 'I really want to understand your fantasy, and I've tried, and I just don't. Can you help me understand it better so I can be more comfortable with it?' then you might get a more complete and honest answer."

Zoe was silent.

The waitress came back. Zoe ordered another drink, somewhat dismayed that she had already finished off this second margarita.

Randy gave her a look, but didn't tell her not to order it. He ordered some appetizers instead, while Zoe half-fumed and half-marveled at him.

The band began playing, and as Randy had anticipated, they were very loud. Zoe polished off her drink, some nachos arrived with the next one, and they began eating, neither one attempting to talk.

Randy leaned over to yell next to her ear. "You wanna get out of here?"

Zoe laughed. "Not if you're going to Hannibal Lecter me some more."

"Promise. Clean slate when we get out the door. If you've talked all you want to about it."

Zoe fell back to her seat without answering his question and smiled.

Say whatever you wanted about Dr. McIntyre, he was good at changing the mood when it went south.

*

Once they were outside, the pressure that had been building in the restaurant, between the band and the hot air and the intense conversation, blew away like a disappearing fog. It was cooler outside than Zoe had expected, and the chilled air brought with it a sudden sobriety.

"You look like you could use a coffee and an escort home,"

Randy said.

He said it in such a way that she couldn't argue with it, and she also didn't get ruffled by it. His tone was *professional*. He was just dispensing very good advice, and he had the sort of look and calm demeanor about him that exuded his clinical detachment from it. Of course he would, she thought, and the thought was as clear as day to her. Of course he would have heard all kinds of intimate details from people in his line of work, and of course he would give her solid advice in a professional way, because he had always been a caring, fatherly figure in her life.

He ordered the coffee to go - one for him, and a green tea latte for her, because she wanted to get a good sleep. He walked her home commenting on how the field of psychiatry had changed in the past ten years, something about billing, and she listened enough to sound like she was, but her thoughts were elsewhere.

She was feeling very silly about some of those thoughts by the time they came to a stop in front of her house. So silly that there wasn't even a question of how they would part. "Well," Randy said, before she could offer her own milquetoast ending. "Thanks for being my beard so I could finally check out the infamous Meade Street Station."

"Yeah, same," Zoe said. "It's a good place, I never knew it was there."

Following this exchange, she fully expected a series of "well, goodbye," and "goodnight" and "let's do it again sometime," which was likely never to be followed up on. But Randy swung at her from out of nowhere.

"Are you going to talk to Josh?"

She was stunned, so she froze in place. "Uh..."

"I think you should. That's my honest advice. As a shrink, and as a friend. And as a man who has made mistakes in his own marriage."

Zoe recovered from her shocked state with a slow blink.

"That's... a lot of qualifications."

Randy shrugged. As he did, his face took on the expression and the exact embodiment of all three of those things.

He leaned in, and kissed her on the cheek.

It was a platonic, friend-to-friend kiss. A hint of paternal condescension in it. His stubble, always present in the evening, grazed her cheek and that might as well have been her inner thigh, because the sensation traveled through her and made her slit warm and wet before he had even pulled back. His hands were in his pockets. The place on her cheek, so close to her mouth, where his lips had touched her, was still tingling with the phantom of his dry, warm lips.

He stepped backward, smiling, hands still in pockets. "Let me know how it goes, if you want."

He turned, lifting a hand up to wave goodbye to her, and walked away, leaving Zoe standing for a few seconds, unsure of what to do or say.

And then too much time had passed, so she fished into her purse, found her keys, and looked at them as she walked up the steps.

Her knees were slightly wobbly.

CHAPTER 8

"Can I talk to you about something?"

Josh felt his stomach drop. It was never good when someone started a conversation like this, out of the blue. He'd had enough conversations that began with this exact phrase in the past few weeks to know. He was pretty sure he was close to the edge.

He dropped his pencil and pushed back from the table. He sighed loudly and put his hands behind his head. "Zoe, yeah, of course. Of course you can talk to me about something, but honestly, if this is something about the way I stack the dishes, or left something in the fridge, I can't - I just can't - deal with it right now.

Honestly."

Zoe had folded her hands together and was looking at the floor.

"It isn't..." she said quietly.

Josh's heart felt immediately pulverized. He pushed away from the desk and rolled out, turning toward her. "Zoe, here, come here.

I'm sorry. I'm just really..." he sighed again, running his fingers through his hair. "I'm - it's just work. Please, don't... forget I said that.

Talk to me about whatever you want to talk to me about. Okay?"

Zoe looked at him. His arms were stretched out, and so she walked over to him, and sat on his knee, because that's what he wanted her to do. "Look, maybe this isn't a good time," she began.

Josh quashed an impatience that started to build up in his chest. "Zoe, no, it's the right time. Whatever it is. Okay? So shoot."

She played with the buttons on his shirt, starting a flutter of arousal in his chest. Zoe had that power over him: this was all she had to do to get him going.

"Okay, so, it's... um, sort of hard to know how to start. I just, uh... I've been wanting to talk to you about it for a while, but, um, I don't know how to...you know, start. So," she exhaled quickly. "Here goes. I've been thinking a lot lately about... our, you know, the game we, uh, play. In bed, and the time that you told me about your, uh,

fantasy. And," she stopped to clear her throat and look around the room.

Josh was frozen, a cool blend of arousal and fear gripping him.

Every muscle in his body was now rigid, and he didn't dare breathe.

He had absolutely no idea what Zoe was going to say next. At all.

"So, I talked to someone, I guess, about it, because, I don't know. I think I try to understand it and I really don't, and it's just like, occupying this big part of my mind. Sometimes. And h - she - said, maybe I should tell you, I've tried to understand it, I *want* to understand it, but I just need you to explain it to me. Better.

Because... I don't know. Like, if it's important to you, and you really want to make it happen, I guess, I'm sort of... I don't know. Thinking about doing it. If I understand it." She crinkled her nose and squeezed her eyes shut. "Did that make *any sense*? "

He didn't know. His mouth had gone dry and his cock was throbbing, and he was half-convinced this was a hallucination.

"You're thinking about...it," he repeated.

Zoe stood up. "See, this is the thing," she said, running her hand through his hair. "I'm like, I don't even want to say that to you, because I'm worried this is all, like, something you're not actually into, and so if I do something...

you know... *real*, then you'll actually be mad. Because I don't get it. If I think about our roles being reversed, I would just be mad."

"But... but, I'm not... that isn't what I want."

"I know. But I'm just saying, like... I can't understand why you like this. I can't understand why you want to see this. And because I can't, I can't believe that it's real. You know? Like, I just worry that it's fake or maybe you think you want it, but you don't, or... I don't know."

Josh stared at her. She had walked over to the window and was looking out of it while she talked to him. She turned around, and her lovely figure was silhouetted in the window. "So... to help me, I want you to, like, make me understand."

Josh was struck silent again.

Zoe held up a hand. "It doesn't have to... I know I'm springing this on you, but it doesn't have to be right now, you know. Just...

because I know you have to think on it, or whatever. But I want to understand it better."

"I don't know," Josh said, as Zoe started to walk out. "I really... I wish I could tell you what it is, Zoe, you know, because it doesn't really make any sense to me either. I actually feel... pretty bad about it. But there's like..."

"Just think about it, Josh. Okay. Like, try to help me understand it. Because if it's... you know, if it's something you want, then I don't know, I maybe, if I can understand it, I might be okay with it."

His heart began to beat erratically. "Do you have a... is there a reason that you're -"

Zoe shook her head. "I don't *have* anyone..." she told him. "In mind, I mean."

But the conviction was all but absent from her voice, and her face fell as though she were disappointed in herself.

He wanted, desperately, to venture to ask her if the person she had spoken to was Randy. And he wanted, even more desperately, to hear that Randy was the person she had chosen.

But he was getting ahead of himself. Way ahead of himself.

She was asking to *understand*.

But she had said that she was thinking about doing it, right?

That was the only sentence that remained in his head, intact, repeating itself endlessly: *I guess, I'm sort of... I don't know. Thinking about doing it.*

How much time had he spent on internet forums, reading the stories and advice of men who had actually managed to talk their wives into a real hotwife relationship? Surely it had been thousands of hours. How much time had he spent, lending himself to this fantasy, daydreaming, mentally preparing himself for a moment like this and *what he should say if it ever came?*

But all of that, all of it, flew out of his head at that moment.

Everything had flown out of his mind, in fact. Including what Zoe had just said, and what he should be saying. He rolled his knuckles against his head.

"Look, I'm sort of throwing this at you," she said. "I just... this person I talked to about thinks that I should just talk to you about it -"

"Randy?" he said, his mouth dry. "Did you talk to Randy about it?"

Zoe blinked. She looked at the ground. "Okay, yeah, I talked to Randy about it. He's like... a shrink, you know. It just came out. I don't know how. It was kind of just a natural thing in the conversation

."

"With Randy?"

Zoe looked at him.

"Your ex-boyfriend's dad? You just started talking about your sex life with him?"

He sounded indignant, and he felt indignant, but even as he listened to himself, he wasn't quite sure why he was acting that way.

This was, after all, exactly what he wanted. More or less. Wasn't it?

Zoe was getting defensive. She folded her arms across her chest. "Look," she said. "I just... this is kind of a big thing. You have this like, fantasy, and it doesn't make any sense to me, okay? So I am just trying to be... understanding. I am trying to understand it better. Is all. Jesus."

She picked up a shirt and shook it out to fold it, with a snap. Her face was getting red.

Josh put his hand to his head. He sighed. "Shit. Zoe, look, I'm sorry." He ran his fingers through his hair. "I'm... it's just work is crazy, okay? Pete is crazy. My head is all filled with all this... petty bullshit he puts me through every day. And then this was like... the absolute last thing I expected to be talking about today."

Zoe was softening. The shirt, which she had been jerking into hard-edged lines with a vengeance that had him worried she would shred it, began to fold softly in her hands. She tossed it on the bed, still looking down. "I'm sorry," she said, and when she looked up at him her eyes were wet. "I'm just trying to... I don't know. I feel like ever since you started working with that guy, I don't see you, and when I do, you're like, completely preoccupied. I don't know how this came up, honestly. But I think... I thought it was good advice, you know? And since he was like, 'go do this crazy thing...'"

"You were like, 'okay, wheeeee!'" Josh finished for her.

This at least made her smile. He pulled her toward him, and held her close. She was tiny, easily huggable, and he could kiss the top of her head in this embrace, without moving his own head. They were made for each other.

He held her for a long time. Her ear was to his chest, so he knew that she could hear his heart beating - thudding, would be a better word - against his ribcage. Zoe knew him so well, she would know what that meant, that he was struggling to find the way to say something. To get the balls to do something.

And what was he afraid of? Zoe had actually laid everything at his feet. *Everything*. The door was open to tell her the truth, to tell her that this fantasy was really real, and not only that, that the very person she had run into fit the bill almost to a "T."

And he could sense that there was more to Randy than Zoe was letting on. He was *sure* of it. Some kind of... something. So why couldn't he just *tell* her that?

"Are you nervous?" Zoe said. "About telling me?"

Josh treated her to a half-laugh and squeezed her tightly.

"The best thing to do is just say why you're nervous. Then it won't be scary anymore. Like, say, 'I'm afraid of telling you the truth because...'"

"I'm afraid of telling you the truth because..." Josh repeated.

She lifted her palm from his chest to slap him, very gently. "You have to finish the sentence, dummy."

Josh tilted his head back and sighed. He brought his lips back to the top of Zoe's head.

"I'm afraid of telling you the truth because I'm afraid... that... if you, if I... if I explain it, you're going to think I don't love you or, I don't know, think I'm some kind of freak."

"But I'm asking you about it."

"I know."

"I just want to understand it, that's all."

Josh laughed. "You and me both."

Zoe tipped her head back to look up at him. In spite of the terror he felt at the conversation, at the prospect of explaining his dark fantasy to her, he was aroused, and surely she felt it. "Just explain it to me. Because... if it's something that you can make me understand, if I can just, I don't know, get my head around it, why you want it, what you see in it... then maybe... I don't know. Maybe I could do it, if it would make you happy."

Josh took a few shallow breaths. He actually had no idea what to say.

"It turns you on," Zoe said, with an inviting smile. Her hand slid down to his crotch, barely caressing him through his pants. "Why?"

"God. Zoe," he breathed. "I wish I knew... how to explain that. I really - right now, I really do. I just, uh, I never imagined you'd ask me this question. So, I don't... really know... what to say."

"Just try. Like, say... if I had sex with... I don't know...?"

There was a tinny ring in the air instead of silence. Her lips were parted, smiling, and her fingers were moving slowly around the bunched shape of his cock in his pants.

"Randy," he managed to say.

"Randy," Zoe said, even before he had finished the last syllable of his name. "So if I had sex with... Randy... what would you, like, what would you feel, if I did that?"

His cock, which had quickly robbed the rest of his body of most of the blood he needed to function, was the only part of him that was able to answer. It stiffened with such violence that it made his gut hurt. "Jesus," he said quietly. "Zoe... you would do that?"

She bit her lip and dropped her eyes from his to his lips. It was there that they were focused when she said, quietly, "Tell me why you want me to."

A recollection zagged through Josh's mind, like a lightning streak: the memory of a presentation to a potential client when he had been put on the spot for creating a solution to a problem that had been generated out of thin air. He had been standing in front of a room of twenty people, and everything had been riding on this question.

And just as quickly as that memory flashed and left its green-pink image burned into his mind, he thought of an answer for Zoe, because everything, in a way, was riding on that now.

"I want to know that you can be with someone else, do something wild with someone else, and then come back to me. I don't really know how else to say it. I think about it all the time and it turns me on, but it turns me on to think about you coming back to me, after like, some intense physical... thing... with someone else.

You know. I guess it, proves something or something. I don't know if that makes any sense."

The words were at least mostly true, he realized. That was part of it. It was the part that Zoe needed to hear. He could leave out the other parts, the things that he knew were lurking around in there: some desire to see her defiled, some ability to not be able to do it to her himself, the dark and raunchy ideas that he wanted to put into action, but could not. The danger of it all. None of that meant that what he'd said wasn't true as well. It was just incomplete.

Zoe's head was tilted down a little now, her eyes on his chest.

She was thinking.

"So if I were to do it," she said quietly, and Josh was grateful that his cock was already so tightly confined, so taut, that she couldn't feel the jolt her words sent through him, "then I think it would have to be someone I already know. I think it would have to be someone like... Randy."

Josh wasn't able to give much of an answer, besides exhaling, a high-pitched sound trailing behind his breath. The cold liquid of an adrenaline-

fueled arousal was spilling into his veins. He could barely think, and he needed to say something, he really did.

"Randy," he said quietly. He *knew it*. He knew she had a thing for him.

But it was what he wanted, wasn't it?

Zoe looked up at him. "I mean, if I get brave enough to do it ever, if that's really what you want. I guess..."

She put her hand up to her forehead. "Jesus. If Randy would even be into it."

Oh, Zoe. Sweet, dear Zoe. She actually meant that.

"I think Randy would probably be okay with it," Josh said, doing his best not to sound like he was making fun of her, because Zoe took poorly to any hint that she might be naive about some things, even when that was often the case.

Zoe shook her head, as if he were speaking nonsense. "You think...?"

"Zoe," he said. " *Any man* would be into it."

Her eyes went wide, and she blinked slowly. Then a smile crept onto her lips and exploded in a shy giggle. "I can't believe we're

talking about this."

Josh felt like a deer caught in the headlights. Here it was, his fantasy playing out. Maybe not exactly as he'd imagined it, but then, he never really believed it would play out in real life at all. He was struck dumb by the competing instincts inside of him: to stop what he had set in motion, to forge ahead and see where it would take him, and a desire to just lay low and not frighten Zoe away when she was circling so close to his darkest and most feverish desires.

His choice, if it could be called that, was to put it in Zoe's hands.

After all, if Zoe decided this was what she wanted, so much the better.

He kissed her forehead. "Zoe," he said, breathing her name on her forehead. He was pleased when he saw a ripple of goosebumps travel over her neck on shoulder. "I want you to do what you're comfortable with."

Her hand was moving over his pants, up to the button, working her way inside.

"If I'm brave enough," she whispered. "And if Randy's into it..."

That was the last thing she said. A silence, liquid and hot, hung heavy in the air between them, before Josh took her face in his hands, and they began peeling away their clothes.

Their sex was feverish, reckless, like when they had first started dating. Zoe had been a little reluctant, teasing him for several dates, making out with him in the car when he dropped her off. On the third

"date" she had driven to his house after work and stayed late watching a movie. She drove him wild, and then said she had better go home, with that confounding certainty that so many young women seem to have, combined with a sort of heartless lack of empathy for how much they've driven a man crazy. He had walked her out to her car, and she had let him kiss her some more. It was late, a light drizzle was falling. He had kept trying, and then they had both lost control, and Josh had climbed on top of her while she was in the driver's seat and that had been their first time - a sweaty, confined, wild fuck in the car. Afterward Zoe had laughed, and they had looked around the dim parking lot with their heads spinning wildly, wondering who had seen them.

Then he had taken her by the hand, and led her back to his apartment, and she had stayed with him, ever since.

It was like that time in the car - dirty, and quick, and pulsing with the *need* he hadn't felt within Zoe for a long time. Somewhere in the middle of it, everything on the desk, including his laptop, had fallen to the floor.

Lying on their backs, Zoe smiling devilishly in much the same way she had that first night in her car, Josh hoped that this was like a new beginning, but with a similar ending: where Zoe would come back with him.

The thought twisted like a knife in his gut.

CHAPTER 9

"You seem nervous."

Randy was seated on the other side of a small table at Don's Mixed Drinks, a hipster bar made up to feel like a dive - an illusion that did not extend to the price of the drinks. He was there at Zoe's invitation, which she had recklessly extended only one day after talking to Josh.

Zoe liked to get things done once she decided to do them, and sometimes before she fully decided, because in her experience, too much thinking usually led to inaction.

Zoe's fingers stopped the rapid tap-dance they had been performing along the edge of her glass, but she didn't stop fidgeting entirely. Her eyes darted all around, and then she pushed her hair from her face, took both of her hands and placed them palms-down, closing her eyes.

"Okay," she breathed, like she was about to jump out of an airplane. "I am... about to tell you something... and it has the potential to be super, duper, horribly, embarrassing."

She waited, eyes still closed.

There was still time, she was thinking, to do nothing at all.

Instead, she felt the excitement, almost as if it had turned into wind and was grazing her face, just before she pushed herself out the door of a plane.

She opened her eyes and stared at her drink.

Randy was looking at her with the same impenetrable doctor's expression. She cleared her throat and shifted in her seat, noticed that her fingers had

started tapping again, and then placed them under her butt, rolling from side to side to get each hand beneath her.

"So. You gave me some advice to talk to Josh about his... you know, the thing we talked about."

She looked up at him and could see that he was about to tell her that she needed to say it, so she plunged. "About sleeping with

other men. Me. Sleeping with other men."

Randy's face did not change.

"And..." she pulled her right hand out from under her to flick at the corner of her coaster. "He, uh... well, he explained to me that he is, he thinks he is, actually, very serious. About it. And so, that's...whatever, you know. But, um, I kind of... in light of that, and the fact that he's having a very hard time at work lately, and just..."

"Let me interrupt you for a moment, Zoe. Josh has convinced you that *he* is serious about his fantasy. And you believe him?"

"I'd rather not, like, get into the details about -"

"Of course not, I'm just confirming that you take him to be serious. For whatever reason. But you jumped right over something very important: how do *you* feel about it?"

Zoe put her hand under her butt again, because she was getting fidgety with her fingers. She pressed her lips together and looked at the coaster. A smile turned up the corners of her mouth.

"That's, uh... well, I think... so, now that he explained it to me, I guess, I feel like... so this is what I'm trying to say. I'm thinking about it. About doing it."

There was silence from the other side of the table, and she had to steel herself to look up at Randy. She had half been expecting to see a look of

fatherly disappointment on his face, and she had pretty much decided that if she saw that, she would back out of the whole thing. Entirely.

Instead, he looked stunned. Temporarily stunned: the expression lingered on his face for a flash and he quickly recovered.

"Uh... okay. Do you feel... good about that decision?"

"Nervous."

Silence.

"So... what are you going to do?"

"Well," she said, taking a deep breath. "That's the thing. I, um..."

I, for one, don't think I could do it with like, some total stranger. Josh says some people do that and that is just like..." she retrieved a hand to make it sail in the air like an airplane and then dip and crash.

"Recipe for disaster."

"Hmm," Randy said. "That's interesting."

"What?" she said, looking at him with alarm, hand still hanging in the air.

Randy shrugged. "I would just think... well, tell me what you're thinking, with that."

" *You tell me* what you're thinking," Zoe insisted. She laughed a little at the end.

Randy appeared to be thinking, the way a shrink might, of the most professional way to phrase whatever he was about to say. He looked up, and then back at her.

"You know, I maybe have a preconceived idea based on a very small sample size, in which the people I've known who have actually embarked on this kind of relationship have wanted to include *only* strangers. I realize that's

just a handful of people, and so I actually shouldn't be assuming anything about your thoughts at all."

Zoe's eyes flashed a little. "That was... extremely academic-sounding," she said. She closed her eyes again and took a deep breath. "So... I don't actually think that's a good idea. I would definitely want to know the person."

"Okay," Randy said.

She looked at him. "And... oh God." She took a gulp of her beer.

"And I know who it is."

There was a cool silence from Randy that made her look up.

When she did, she found that his expression had changed: how, exactly, she couldn't be sure. But he was no longer detached from the conversation, purely clinical.

"Oh God," she repeated, and picked up her glass. She took a sip and started talking immediately. "So, please don't freak out or anything, and if this is way, way, out of line, then... you know, whatever." She flicked her eyelids up, and looked at him. "I sort of want it to be you."

When she had tried to picture his reaction, she had never really managed to. If she could have been a little more honest with herself, she was realizing at that moment, the very fact that she *couldn't* picture Randy's reaction was probably what had, in the end, convinced her to go through with asking him.

Like jumping out of a plane, it was something you just couldn't really *picture*.

He leaned back, silent. She had no way to interpret the expression on his face.

The silence dragged on, dishes clattering in the now-faraway sounding background. Somewhere, a dish dropped and shattered, and a woman

laughed.

" *Don't*, " Zoe said, to break up the silence, "whatever you do, don't say, 'I'm flattered that you asked me, but...'" Zoe hated flattery.

She hated the word and she generally thought flattery was a passive-aggressive way of being a jerk in most cases.

"I wasn't going to say that."

He was still looking at her, but still he said nothing, so Zoe picked up her beer and started to half-theatrically chug it, looking at the wall.

When she set it down, she looked at him. "Okay," she began, smoothing a napkin across her lap that she couldn't remember having put there. "I'm just _"

"Can I have some time to think about it?"

"Yes. Yeah. Of course. No, because... it's, I realize, a big thing, sort of weird. In fact, it's really weird. You can always just act like I never suggested it."

Randy was still looking at her with the same odd expression, without looking away or revealing what he was thinking behind his intense eyes. At last he said, "I can't, really."

"No," Zoe half-whispered, picking up her beer again.

Randy now seemed, for the first time she had ever seen him this way, distracted. He looked out into the restaurant.

"Do you... want to cancel our order?" Zoe asked.

Randy took a moment to answer. "I..." he cleared his throat.

"No, not... maybe."

But it was already coming, in the hands of a waitress in good cheer. "Y'all hear that crash? That was your burger, but I hit the button on this new machine twice and so... you already had another one ready to go. Ain't that somethin'? Get you anything else?"

Zoe shook her head, and the waitress looked from her to Randy, opened her mouth, and then pressed her lips together. "Just let me know," she said, before turning away.

Zoe took a French fry and bit into it, looking out at the restaurant to avoid Randy's gaze.

His hand was on hers suddenly, warm, heavy. She looked down at it as he spoke.

"Zoe, don't take this... in any particular way. But I think, I, uh...

I'm going to go now. It's... I need to clear my head."

She looked up at him, only to find in his expression traces of something almost frantic, distraction, tenderness, and, confusingly, what looked like mild illness. She stopped chewing, half of the fry in her fingers. "Uh... yeah. Okay. Sorry. I -"

"Don't be sorry. I just, um... I'll get a hold of you soon. I promise."

"Yeah...?" she said, but Randy was already getting up, walking out. She watched him, he made it halfway out the exit before turning around suddenly. A flutter of hope careened through her chest, but he was only returning to the cash register to pay. He pointed at their table without meeting Zoe's eyes, and dispensed several bills, before holding his hand up vaguely in her direction, and stumbling out of the door in what seemed like a fugue state.

Zoe pushed the rest of her fry into her mouth.

Well, that was what you got when you did something dangerous and unknown:

Danger.

And the unknown.

CHAPTER 10

Randy didn't call her back during the next week, and Josh was working late almost every night, his stress building and his mind -

and she was almost grateful for this - distracted. She was grateful for this - in fact, the more time dragged on, the more grateful she was, because it

seemed, unbelievably, that Randy had rejected her offer.

Which was utterly humiliating.

So when Josh finally brought the topic up, one night in bed after they'd made slightly tired and perfunctory love, Zoe found herself telling a lie. Telling a lie with Josh's fingers on her lips.

"Have you seen Randy lately?"

Zoe held his eyes, and she hoped she gave the impression of honesty by doing so. "Josh," she said softly. "About that... I sort of...

chickened out." Her heart dropped as she said this, and her eyes followed it, squeezing a surprise tear from her eye. "I decided I couldn't go through with it."

She was surprised by her own reaction, surprised that she was letting Randy get to her so much.

"Zoe, hey," Josh said, pulling her closer to him, putting his forehead against hers. The sincerity in his voice only made her feel worse. "I don't want you to do anything you don't want to do. I'm sorry, okay? Please, don't cry. Don't feel bad about it. It's fine. No worries. It's totally fine."

His every word sliced through her. His concern was so genuine, and now she wanted to take it back and tell him the truth: she hadn't chickened out, she'd been rejected. She was letting him feel bad, letting him believe that she was disappointed in herself for letting him down, when in fact she was disappointed in Randy for letting *her* down.

Which also made her feel terrible. Fuck. It had all gotten so complicated.

"Hey," Josh continued, wiping her tears into her cheeks with a stroke of his thumb. "It's... okay. Okay? I'm sorry I even suggested it."

Zoe, please don't cry. Don't worry. It was just an idea. We don't have to... you don't have to do it, okay?"

This really only served to make her feel like crying more. She did her best to choke back her tears, but a lump developed in her throat and made her unable to speak.

Josh, dutiful husband as ever, held her close and tried to comfort her, every passing moment making her feel worse, making it harder to speak the truth.

He fell asleep long before she did, and when she heard the low snore of his slumber her tears overflowed onto the pillow.

When she had cried as much as she could, silently, without waking him up, she went to sleep, concluding that maybe things had worked out for the best. There would never be a good time to tell Josh the secret truth, and maybe that was for the best, anyway.

After all, it wouldn't change the outcome.

She fell into a fitful sleep.

CHAPTER 11

Weeks went by, and life returned to normal, as if the flirtation with this new dimension of their marriage had never even happened.

Zoe did her best to put it out of her mind, which was something she was generally very good at doing. It still stung, when she thought about it. The memory of her last conversation with Randy would surface in her mind, and on its heels came the memory of that very dishonest conversation with Josh, and her heart would sink. She could never be sure which of those two memories was making it sink, or if it was both things, which one weighed more heavily on her mind.

But as more and more days piled up between those events and the present, she thought of it less and less, and pretty soon she was barely thinking about it at all.

She remembered that breaking up with Derek had felt much the same way. They had been young, and their relationship had been frivolous and

passionate in high school, but ill-suited for either of them as they diverged after graduation. But it had dragged on, and years after she had broken up with him it was hard to say why she had let it drag on. Or why Derek had let it drag on. She didn't like to think about it: she knew he had probably done it because it was convenient for him to have a girlfriend, and steady sex. That was understandable, she supposed. Why *she* had let it drag on was more of a mystery, even to her older self.

When they had finally broken up, she had felt terrible. It had been the sort of anti-climactic, dual-sided agreement that young couples seemed to always come to. She couldn't even remember now if she or Derek had been the one to say, "Well, maybe we should just break up, then." Or if it had been her or Derek who had nodded glumly and agreed, because whoever had said it and whoever had agreed to it, they both knew it was true. Still, her heart sank when she thought about it for weeks, and then less so for months, and then maybe even for years she had the occasional

thought about it that made her chest cool with pain for a brief moment. Eventually, though, a day passed, and then a week, and then a month, and then a year, when she didn't give Derek any thought at all.

And then she had met Josh, and she had known that she loved him and that they were going to live their lives together. She had figured that had been the end of ever feeling this way again.

Until now.

She always managed to push her feelings away, however, by remembering that time indeed heals all wounds.

So when she received a message from Randy, weeks later, when the cool of fall was already working its way down from the mountains by the end of the day, her heart surprised her by feeling as though it had come to a sudden stop.

She was at lunch with Alicia and Gina, which was something they often did on Teambuilding Tuesdays. It had become a kind of ritual: having a drink with lunch, complaining loudly about having to spend the evening

pretending to have fun and then figure out how to get their cars later on, because they would inevitably drink too much.

She hadn't thought about Randy in days.

"I mean, laser tag?" Gina was whining. "Again?"

"Just get out there and get tagged right off the bat and you can go to the bar," Alicia drawled. "Sometimes there are cute guys there."

"That only works if we split everybody up so the people who actually play aren't all on one team. Remember, we had to play like seventeen times that one -?"

"I saw the team lists," Zoe interjected. "He's on to us. He put us all on the same team."

Alicia snorted and rolled her eyes. She didn't care, because she seemed to be impervious to and immune from their boss's

"disappointment" if she didn't participate.

"He did not," Gina whined.

"I knew you wouldn't believe me," Zoe said, smiling, reaching into her purse for her phone. She had to suck some wing sauce off the fingers of her right hand to touch her screen. "So I took -"

The message was there in her notifications. Just the first bit of it, floating below "Dr. McIntyre," and the words struck her dumb for a moment.

Zoe. I'm sorry about the way I reacted and tha...

"... a picture," Zoe finished, when she realized she hadn't been speaking.

Alicia was looking at her with interest when Zoe looked up, but Alicia was a cool customer, and said nothing. She swirled her straw in her drink, like a cat twitching her tail.

Zoe quickly swept the message notifications off her screen and fumbled to pull up the picture. "Here," she heard herself say, and from the place in her mind she had gone to, she felt herself handing the phone to Gina. She heard Gina muttering a complaint, saw Alicia drop her eyes to the screen and then roll them, and felt the weight of the phone as it was dropped back into her waiting hand.

She heard herself making a joke about the topic, saw her coworkers smile at whatever it was that she said. She watched herself, as if from outside her own body, as she paid the bill and went to the restroom and washed her hands. She had driven, and Gina was in the passenger's seat. They had gone to a place two exits down from their own on the freeway, and Gina and Alicia were talking about something.

Gina's voice came through the fog in her head only after the third time.

"Oh, you missed the exit. Take Santa Fe and turn back around."

"Zoe, that's... you have to get over and get off on Santa Fe. You missed the exit."

"Zoe, are you listening? You're... we're going to miss Santa Fe."

Alicia snapped her finger next to Zoe's ear. "Hey. *Bella Durmiente*. Snap out of it or we are all gonna be in hot shit."

The broad green sign for the Santa Fe exit was already sailing over their heads, and the exit ramp had already begun to peel away from the freeway. "Shit," she said, turning her head to check behind her. She then crossed the flat divider and screeched into the off-ramp, already well into the wedge-shaped area of yellow-striped

concrete that ended in black and orange barrels of sand before a concrete pillar.

"Oh my God," Gina said.

Alicia was saying something in Spanish under her breath with the cadence of the Lord's Prayer, though Zoe was pretty sure she heard the words *cabrón* and *puta* in there somewhere.

"Sorry. God. Sorry, guys." Zoe waved her fingers over the steering wheel like she wanted to erase it all. Generally, everyone called upon her to drive because she was, all sexism intended, the best female driver in the office. Years of driving to ski on days when the roads were closed, and work was canceled, had made her reliable on the rare occasions when ice slicked the city.

"What the fuck, Zoe?" Alicia said, and rolled down the window.

"Oh man, Alicia, don't smoke in my car."

Zoe heard the flick of a lighter. "Don't try to kill me and I won't need to."

The cloud of tobacco smoke drifted to the front of the car when they came to a stop at the intersection at the end of the off-ramp.

Zoe looked back at Alicia in the rear-view mirror, and decided to drop it. It had been some pretty crazy driving. Now that she had some time to think about it, they had been pretty close to those sand barrels.

She turned left, waited in the left-turn lane to get back on the ramp, and drove back to the preceding exit, all without any comment from either coworker. They pulled into the parking lot and Gina got out in a hurry, saying, "Well. That was a gas."

"So what are you so deep in thought about, *muñeca*?"

Alicia flicked her cigarette butt with incredible skill, making it land right next to the wheel of Mike Esper's car. It was a deliberate choice, because Mike complained about cigarette butts all the time, so Alicia went out of her way to flick them at his car. She blew a long trail of smoke out the window and rolled it up, all three of these things happening as part of one fluid movement.

"I'm so sorry about that," Zoe said, wiping her brow. She wasn't sweating, but she felt like she should be. "I don't... have any idea what happened."

Alicia opened the door without commenting on Zoe's answer.

As she stepped out of the car, she stretched. "Well, let's go knock out this day so we can knock out this evening." She pulled her tight skirt down to make it all tidy. Zoe had her own door open and was stepping out of the car. Alicia smiled down at her. "I have a new guy and he is..." she kissed her fingers in what Zoe had always taken for a very Italian gesture. Then she headed from the parking lot down the short set of steps to the back door entrance to the office.

Zoe turned back to the car, making much more of a show of having forgotten something than was probably necessary. She patted her suit, which had no pockets, and then spun around to drop back into the car. For good measure she flipped her sun-visors down and leaned over to pretend to be looking for... something... until a flash of reflected sunlight confirmed that the back door was swinging open, and Gina and Alicia were going inside.

When the door closed behind them, Zoe fished for her phone.

Her heart was pounding as she pulled up the message from Randy.

Zoe. I'm sorry about the way I reacted and that I haven't been in touch like I promised. I'm an old man and I can hardly handle the shock of my bank changing their website around. Can I beg your forgiveness and humbly request that you allow me the chance to have a more dignified, but no less genuine, response to your request? I will buy you everything you desire from the menu of the most expensive restaurant in town.

Zoe stared at the somewhat archaic text for several minutes.

She heard the wheels of another car scraping over the sand that remained in the lot from the previous late spring blizzard, and swept the message away. She dropped the phone into her purse and looked out the windshield, Randy's message burned into her cornea.

And just like that, the twisting, aching, cold burn in her abdomen was back.

CHAPTER 12

The sequence of events from that moment, to the moment that she sat down in a secluded booth at Port House, as promised perhaps one of the most expensive restaurants in town, bled into each other like a montage from an arthouse thriller.

She typed him a message. He wrote her back. She rubbed a too-light foundation from the winter months onto her cleaned face in the bathroom, hiding in a stall. She stood in Neil's office and constricted her throat to create a sinussy rasp, and told him she was coming down with something. Alicia's eyes, visible just above the cubicle wall that hid an unknown expression on her mouth, followed her, dark and knowing, as she left the building through the back door at 4:00. There was no memory of driving home. A cloud of clothing leaped from her drawers and fell to the floor of the closet. Her hand very carefully scraped a razor over the tiny bristles that had begun to sprout around the carefully trimmed shape of her landing strip. She thought of Moira, her waxing specialist, and how annoyed she would be. She looked at herself in a red dress, in a green one, in a black one, and then again in red. She jumped when she thought she heard the front door open. She put black mascara on her eyes and then took it off because it looked too vampy, and then reapplied it because the brown looked too plain. She watched a video about how to apply a red lip and copied it.

And then she was following a very formal, stern waiter at a steady clip through the dim restaurant. White tablecloths and aprons gleamed everywhere, and empty glasses were arranged, gleaming, at every place setting. The waiter called her madame and told her that Dr. McIntyre had suggested an aperitif to start the evening, but had also made it quite clear that she should be allowed to veto the choice.

"I... no, that's fine."

"He's called ahead to apologize that he will be about ten minutes late. I'll bring you a menu and your aperitif. "

Both arrived in short order. It was the kind of place with no prices on the menu, and a list of courses, with no set menu at all, because it specialized in seafood. It was the sort of oft-repeated local fact that Port House flew their fish in from both coasts each morning, and that whatever could be kept alive until the moment before dinner was served, was.

She held the menu carefully and eyed the several oyster appetizers, trying to remember what each type of dish entailed, because this was also the sort of restaurant that did not feel they owed you much of an explanation.

"You look radiant."

Randy had approached soundlessly and was already sitting down by the time Zoe looked up and smiled. She was grateful that the menu was framed by a heavy leather book, because had it not been, he might have seen the tremor that overtook her hands.

Randy was wearing an expensive-looking suit, and he looked quite radiant himself. Zoe almost said this but realized, just as she opened her mouth, that calling a man "radiant" was strange. The formality of Randy's messages and the restaurant stifled her next instinct, which was to say, "you don't look so bad yourself."

She said, "Thank you," instead.

"I see you went for the Campari," he said.

"What? Oh, the drink. Yeah, I, um... feel like I should just go with the flow here."

Randy smiled. He leaned over at her. "It's a little stuffy, huh?

But I made a promise and now you shall have all the lobster you want."

Zoe laughed, shook her head, and buried her eyes in the menu.

The waiter appeared and the two men spoke utter gibberish to each other, evidently ordering something very complicated. When the waiter left, Zoe

looked at Randy, and he leaned close again. "I realize that girls your age probably don't like men ordering for them, but I thought it -"

"Don't worry about it," Zoe said, waving her hand dismissively.

"I'm actually, uh, a little out of my element here."

"Everyone is. We aren't British."

"What did you order?"

"Oysters, artichokes, expensive booze. All the aphrodisiacs."

Zoe raised her eyebrows. It was a sudden, serious admission, but instead of making her nervous, the anxiety she had felt just moments before was melting away. "Huh," she said.

Randy shook out his napkin with a snap and placed it on his lap. "Well. I am trying to seduce you. In a way. We might as well get that out on the table."

He was looking at Zoe in a way that defied an easy definition.

She couldn't tell, from his expression or his tone of voice, if this was a joke that would be soon laughed away, or a very serious statement of intent. Her skin boiled above the icy sensation in her core, and an almost-nauseous feeling swam within her. "I..." she said, but found no words to finish the thought.

Randy's inexplicable expression turned, very slowly, into a warm smile. He moved his hand across the table to where hers was lying, paralyzed, next to her drink. It was reminiscent of that evening so long ago, at the Meade Street Station, and sent a shiver along her arm. "Not tonight, of course. I realize this all might be coming as a bit of a shock to you. I just wanted to get everything out in the open."

Seconds ticked away while Zoe tried to understand this latest twist. "Okay," she finally managed to say. She moved her head to get her hair to fall behind her shoulder, but it was just a smidge too short to stay there, and it

fell forward again almost immediately. "What does... uh... so what does that mean, exactly?"

Randy smiled with compressed lips. For a brief moment, he looked as though he were about to deliver a confession, or bad news. His eyes fell to look at their hands, not really clasped, just touching in a strange embrace that Zoe had no part in. "The reason I was so... long in getting back to you is because, well... I really didn't know what to say. You have to understand that for a man of my age to receive an offer like yours, it's... well... hard to describe."

"I'm sorry, Randy," Zoe said, sliding her hand away without being really sure why she had done it. She placed it next to her other hand in her lap. "I shouldn't have asked you about that -"

"No, no. No, that isn't what I meant by that," he said. He had a way of smiling at peculiar moments that reminded her of George

Clooney. "I meant by that... it's, um, I had some conflict. About your age. About my profession, our relationship, the fact that..."

A silence lingered.

"You don't have to say anything else," Zoe said. "It was, um, silly. Of me."

She looked up at him, because somehow in the previous moments her eyes had dropped to the table, and her lap.

He was staring right at her. "Oh no, I don't think it was silly at all, Zoe," he said, very seriously. "I'm here to ask you if the offer is still on the table."

Zoe opened her mouth, and then blushed. It was a heated wave that she could feel in her face. She glanced out into the restaurant. "I don't..." she began, but again found nothing else to say.

"Let's try something," Randy said.

She looked back at him, still unable to put into words the effect his statement was having on her.

"Starting over. Like this awkward interlude didn't happen. Let's have dinner, and you can go home, and then we'll just see... where that takes us. You're here, after all. You can't blame a man for getting his hopes up."

"I told Josh that I chickened out," she blurted. The words left her mouth so unexpectedly that she experienced a disorienting moment of feeling like someone else had said them.

This was, Zoe knew, like having jumped. Off a cliff, out of a plane, past the point of no return. She put her hand back up on the table, next to her glass, not touching Randy's hand, which remained where it had been when she withdrew it. She twisted the stem of the drink in her hand and looked at it as she spoke. "I was, uh... well, really devastated. About... you know, how that last conversation ended, it seemed like a rejection. So..." She looked up at Randy. "It kind of made me understand why guys get so worried about rejection," she confided, with a smile. Then she swiped at her long bangs and stopped herself before tucking them behind her ear, which seemed inelegant at a place like this. "I told him, you know, because he asked, and I just couldn't explain what had happened, so then he was like, 'okay, that's totally fine,' and really, I don't

know... I gave him the impression that I don't want to do this after all."

She rattled all of this off very quickly, with an unnerving tremor in her voice that she hoped Randy couldn't hear.

She stared at her fingers. Randy's moved over in a gentle, easy motion to stroke hers, and the heat of his touch traveled through her, once again straight to her lower abdomen.

"Is that true?" he asked.

Zoe exhaled and picked up her glass. Then, before taking a sip, she shook her head. And as she slammed the rest of the cocktail, she looked upward at the ceiling.

She supposed that now she was in for a ride.

Adrenaline was no stranger to her bloodstream, and she could feel it seeping into her arteries. The thing that Zoe knew would happen next was just moments away: the rush, the tunnel vision, and then herself, performing with an innate excellence that could be applied to sports and emergencies and presentations in front of thousands.

And the thing that Zoe knew about herself, even if she couldn't consciously articulate it, is that she *loved* that kind of power. And that kind of rush.

She set her glass down.

"So," she said. "I really don't know that you need to drop all this cash on oysters."

Randy sat back in the booth and looked at her with another expression she couldn't read.

"I already ordered them," he said, with a shrug. And as if he were an extra in a movie, waiting off-camera for his cue, the waiter appeared with a tray of oysters suspended above his shoulder.

*

Zoe got very drunk, and Randy did not. The food was magnificent, but that was all she could recall about it. At some point in the evening she confided that she had called in sick to the dreaded team-building activity, so Josh wasn't expecting her until later, but not that much later.

Randy folded his napkin across one thigh, after dabbing at his lips in a gesture that seemed to also come out of a movie. "I think maybe it's better," he said quietly, "if you give this a little thought. I want to feel like you had time to make a good decision."

Zoe leaned her elbow on the table and rested her hand in her palm. "You aren't serious."

"I am."

She gave him the kind of look you give to someone when you are sure they are joking, and smiled. But Randy's face was impassive: he was serious.

"Okay," she said. "Uh... and then...?"

"And then, hopefully, you call me up. I'm very hopeful about that. But I don't want anyone making a decision they haven't thought carefully about. I don't want you to regret not having time to talk to Josh about it. I seem to remember you as being a rather impulsive young lady."

This had an almost paternalistic ring to it, and Zoe was surprised that instead of infuriating her, as such a comment normally would have, it only plucked at that inner string that vibrated through her core, from her lips, through her chest, and down to the moist slit between her legs.

"I'm not like that anymore."

"Good."

"So, what, we're just going to... agree to have an affair... or whatever this is called, and then you're going to pay the bill, and take me home?"

"Yep."

Zoe laughed quietly. She had no way of knowing that her eyes were shining, that her lips, stained by a red wine, were provocative and almost surly, that she was driving him wild. But she could see something in his eyes. "And then what?" she said, in a low voice that even she thought was incredibly sexy.

"And then..." Randy said. There was a long pause, while the air almost shimmered in the heat between them, and Zoe's chest tightened. "...you come to me when you're ready to have a real man fuck you like you've never been fucked before."

It was the kind of comment that Zoe might have laughed at from anyone else. Many a guy, in fact, had said something similar to her at some late time in the evening, or crassly at a party, or just to get under her skin, or to

thump his chest in front of his male friends. So she was stunned when instead of making her laugh, it made the smile fade quietly from her mouth, and her pussy well up with hot liquid that she could feel slick between her thighs. She tucked her hair behind her ear, forgetting that it was a habit she wanted desperately to break, and looked at the table.

"Well, okay then," she said quietly.

*

Randy drove her home, and they didn't say much from that moment at the table, walking to his car, or during the drive. When he pulled up at her house, the lights were off and there was no sign of Josh's car.

Randy put the car in neutral and pulled the emergency brake.

Zoe cleared her throat, put her hand on the door handle, and then turned to him. "Well," she said. "Thanks for... dinner."

Randy was looking straight ahead. He almost looked angry, which confused her for a brief moment, until her eyes strayed to his crotch, where a definitive erection was bulging in his suit. When she looked at his face, she saw a pulse at his jaw, and it occurred to her that he was just a man trying hard to control himself.

It had been a long time since she had been in that position: being dropped off, sitting so close to someone she hadn't fucked but maybe would. It was exciting, she had to say that. And she was drunk.

She looked up at the house. Back at Randy. "You know, Josh isn't home yet..."

Another twitch in his jaw was all she got from Randy for a moment. She kept looking at him, because she knew that was all she needed to do, that eventually he would have to break.

The moment seemed to go on for hours, or at least that's how it felt. She unbuckled her seatbelt and turned slightly toward him.

Randy kept looking straight ahead. Just before he turned to her, it

occurred to her that what she was doing was very, very wrong, that she was baiting him, and she hadn't even re-cleared this with Josh, and she was getting caught up in a really bad thing *in front of her house*, the house to which her husband could return at any moment.

A feeling of trashy sluttiness hit her like a wave, but by the time she felt it, Randy had turned toward her, put a hand into her hair, pulled her face towards him, and his lips were covering hers.

His jaw was covered with a wiry stubble, and it ignited her. He moved with a confidence and a power that was definitely the product of years of experience, his other hand slipping between her thighs and finding her clit as quickly as she would have with her own fingers. He rubbed it over her panties, which were soaked through.

Zoe tried to gasp, but her mouth was imprisoned by his.

His fingers gripped her hair and that was how he pulled her face from his, biting gently into her lower lip as he did. The look in his eyes made it frighteningly, and arousingly, clear that Zoe was not in control of anything that was going to happen. She hadn't quite meant to take that step yet, but she also didn't feel any power within her to do anything about it.

"Go home, Zoe."

His eyes dropped to her mouth, a look of pure possessive hunger in them, and then he let go of her hair, and sat back in his seat, his left hand slipping from between her thighs. His right hand put the car in gear.

Zoe touched her lips.

"Now."

She moved in a stunned haze. The thought that she had kissed a man who wasn't her husband kept running through her mind, like a ticker tape, but the

kiss had turned her muscles to jelly and she had to think hard about how to move her limbs and fingers to extract herself from the car.

She wobbled when she stepped on the sidewalk. Her heels were higher than normal, and she had to hold onto the door to steady herself.

Randy leaned over slightly as she started to close the door. "I'll make sure you get inside," he told her.

She shut the door, staring at him as if he were from another planet, because she actually couldn't believe what she had just done. And then she walked up the path, looking surreptitiously around to see if any of her neighbors - whom she barely knew - were peeking from their windows at the absolute spectacle she had just been a part of.

Of course they weren't, but it didn't stop her heart from pounding as though they were.

The keys shook as she unlocked the door, and she turned to look back at Randy's car. But headlights blinded her to what he looked like inside it, and so she waved a hand and gave him a limp wave, then stepped into the darkness and closed the door, before falling against it and sinking to the floor.

*

When Josh got home, he was relieved to see Zoe's car parked in the driveway, even if a pang of disappointment bounced around inside of him. After Zoe had confessed that she didn't really want to go through with his fantasy, he still harbored a little fantasy that she might do it anyway. It appeared to him as a daydream, or a thought that he entertained while he drove, and it packed a healthy punch to the gut that he perversely enjoyed.

Driving through the one-way streets of their neighborhood, crammed on both sides with parked cars, he entertained the fantasy that her car wouldn't be there, and that she would be out late like the last team-building session, while he sat in the dark house expecting her with this cold unease building in his groin.

The house was dark: only a feeble light from the master suite lit the upstairs hallway. He could hear water running upstairs: it trickled through the pipes in the kitchen in a way that he found vaguely disturbing in a new house, though he didn't know enough about building or construction to know whether his dismay was warranted.

He closed the door very gently behind himself and stood in the darkness, listening to the water run. The initial relief of seeing Zoe's car in the driveway began to wear off. Something felt off about the state of the house, the darkened rooms. He couldn't put his finger on

it, except to think that it was odd. Zoe was one to turn on all the lights in the house the minute she walked into it.

But what did that mean, even if it was unusual?

He moved through the house quietly, not entirely sure why he was doing it. Was it to entertain his fantasy, to pretend to himself that his wife was up to something when he knew that she really wasn't?

Or was he serious in his unease? He didn't know.

Her purse was on a small table in a tiny room that served no clear purpose. It was too small to be a dining room, but open to the kitchen as if it should have been some kind of eating place. They had placed a tiny table and chairs there, which was cute to look at, but only Zoe could actually sit there, because she was small enough to fit her knees under the table. He stared at it in the dim light coming through the windows from the street, as his stomach twisted and his heart pounded.

The water was still trickling through the pipes. It gave him a sense of confidence: if he *were* to rifle through Zoe's things, which was a terrible and mistrusting thing to do, then he would have ample warning of when to stop.

He stared at her purse.

What did he think he was going to find in there, anyway?

Or better yet: what did he *want* to find in there?

Seconds ticked by while he pondered all the angles. Why was he even thinking of sneaking around, looking through his wife's things? He didn't - he really didn't - expect to find anything there, no evidence of anything at all. What was terrible to him was not so much that he was considering violating Zoe's trust like that, but the fact that he sort of *wanted* to find something incriminating, deliciously suggestive, or otherwise awful. He was resisting the idea not because he was thinking of trust, but because he wanted to savor the fantasy that might, and almost definitely would, come unraveled if he were to look into her purse and find nothing incriminating at all.

If he were to look at her phone and find nothing incriminating at all.

He took a step toward the purse. He knew Zoe's phone code: he was the one who had created it, because Zoe didn't like thinking about things like that. He managed her phone bill and set everything

up. She'd had to ask him a hundred times for her voicemail password.

The water continued to pour through the pipes.

It was an awfully long shower. And one that she evidently felt like she had to take *immediately* after getting home.

He slipped his hand into the purse, and almost like it was a fated event, his fingers immediately found the slender rectangle of her phone. Heart beating hard, palms sweating, he listened to the water for a moment, training his ears on the sound, and pulled the phone from her purse.

The glow of the screen-saver filled the room with blue light. The water trickled on. Hastily, he keyed in her password.

He was rejected, so he tried again, hands shaking. He must have been over-excited. He entered the numbers confidently, carefully: it was an old PIN from one of his bank cards, he knew the number.

The phone vibrated its rejection in his hands.

Wrong PIN.

In a state of disbelief, he closed his eyes and thought for a moment. But there was no thinking to be done: he keyed the numbers carefully, watching each one appear before turning into a dot. He had it right.

But again, and then again, he was rejected, until he was locked out for ten minutes.

A silence slapped him in the face: the water had stopped running through the pipes.

He slipped the phone back into her purse with shaky hands, and stepped back from the table, looking from side to side as if someone might catch him.

The light from the master suite grew brighter, and he heard Zoe's footsteps in the corridor. The soft *phlump* of her footsteps as she came down the stairs. He stood there, unsure of what to do, and for some reason, paralyzed.

"Jesus!" Zoe said, slapping the light switch next to her at the foot of the stairs. She had one hand to her heart and looked genuinely terrified. Her skin had paled, but her expression was

quickly changing from one of terror to one of fury. "What the fuck are you doing?!"

Zoe yelled when she was frightened like this, and she developed quite the potty-mouth.

Josh pivoted to look at her. She was wrapped in a towel, her hair was wet, and, to what would ordinarily have been his chagrin, and not something Zoe would do, water was streaking down her legs and from her hair to the floor, where it was spreading in a tiny, but ever-widening puddle.

Zoe was starting to recuperate, but she was still peeved, because she didn't like being scared by this type of situation. She crossed the space between

them quickly, her arm reaching toward the table.

"When did you get home?" she almost snapped. "And why the hell are you standing here in the dark?"

And then her eyes left his, in a quick, sneaky shift, to look at her purse, and then quickly back at him. She grabbed her purse. "I need something out of here," she explained, without him asking. She stepped back and looked him up and down.

Her face softened. She smiled. "So? Why so creepy?"

Seriously?"

Josh didn't have an answer. Zoe was trying to be funny now, and he supposed that was normal. But the purse she cradled under her arm, and the phone with its suspicious new password, were burning a hole through his thoughts.

"Don't tell me you're trying to do one of those Tik-Tok pranks.

Or... whatever they're called."

She turned and headed for the stairs again. "I'll be right back down, I just needed to grab my..."

She was rifling through the purse, and didn't finish her sentence, and only paused to look back when she was halfway up the stairs. "You okay?"

"Of course," Josh said, and he sounded lame to himself, even though it was a short sentence that no one would be able to read into much.

Zoe furrowed her brow. "Sorry I snapped like that," she said. "I just... you really freaked me out. Standing around in the dark."

"It was a lame joke," he said, tonelessly.

Zoe looked at him, and then shook her head. "Okay," she said, unconvincingly. "Well..."

She went back up the stairs. He could tell, now, that she was really quite tipsy.

Had she driven home drunk, and that was the reason for her strange behavior? It wasn't like Zoe to do that. She was always very careful because her job required her to have a clean driving record for reasons that were not entirely clear in her case.

He sighed. But what was it in Zoe's purse that she needed to come and get so desperately that she hadn't toweled off entirely?

And he wasn't crazy: the look she had given to the purse had been one she hadn't wanted him to see. And it *was* weird that she had come home and taken a shower so immediately.

He stood there thinking about it, and not much time passed before Zoe was plodding down the hall again. She appeared at the top of the stairs in a skimpy nightshirt, one she hadn't worn for a long time, silky and almost transparent. She slinked down the stairs.

"So?" she purred. "Why *are* you standing here in the dark *now*?"

"I don't... really know," Josh said. "I guess just work is... you know. Making me scatterbrained."

"Hmm," Zoe said sexily. She was at the bottom of the stairs now, and she was coming toward him. "I think you should take your mind off work for a little bit."

And then she reached for the waist of his pants, and slipped her fingers into the waistband, pulling him toward her. Surprised, he stepped with her tug awkwardly, almost losing his balance.

Her skin was still hot from the shower, slightly damp, giving off the scent of an expensive soap that smelled like jasmine. Her eyes were on his, and she had a lusty look in them that he hadn't seen for a long, long time.

What was a man supposed to do? She grinned at him and deftly unbuckled his belt, then unbuttoned his pants, while he stood there staring at her, his cock already stiff and twitching to a full erection. She took his pants and boxers with her as she lowered herself to her knees. His cock sprang in front of him, and her hand

closed around it, squeezing him at the base. Her fingernails curled around and grazed his balls. He sucked in his breath.

The trail of breadcrumbs to his fantasy: the changed password, the strange shower - nothing, really - lead him nonetheless to the seasickness in his chest that he loved and hated, just as Zoe opened her mouth.

She wasn't one to fall on her knees, at nine-thirty on a Tuesday, to give him a blowjob. Not anymore, not since the very, very early days of their dating life. In fact, he was almost sure he could say never.

He added this strange occurrence to the breadcrumb trail, but wasn't able to give it much more thought, because Zoe was looking up at him, while feeding his cock into her mouth.

He inhaled sharply as her lips went further and further down his shaft, the hot wetness of her mouth and busy tongue sending him hurtling toward orgasm.

"Zoe," he croaked, and put a hand in her hair. Her eyes were on his, burning into him, and now his cock was deep inside her, bumping against her soft palate. He felt a convulsion in her throat as she gagged, watched her blink slowly, excreting a tiny tear from the corner of her right eye.

And then she kept going, all the way to the very base of his cock, managing, the whole time, to maintain eye contact with him.

And then, she started to suck him, actually sucking as she withdrew toward the tip of his dick. Back down, gagging again, and then back up, sucking hard.

The kind of blowjob Zoe had never, ever given him before.

"Oh fuck," he said, as she went back down. "Zoe, I... oh fuck that feels good... I'm going to, Zoe, I'm going to come, fuck..."

Zoe moved slowly back up the length of him, not sucking this time. He was close, so close, but she placed her hand on his shaft and squeezed tightly, slowing the rush of cum that was threatening to explode.

She smiled, and his cock throbbed in her hand. "I want you to come in my mouth," she said.

She didn't give him time to respond, only fed him back into her throat and dropped her hand so that her lips could get all the way to

the base of his cock. Josh stared at her. "I.. Zoe... I'm going to come, oh fuck!"

The squirts splashed into the back of her throat, and only then did she close her eyes. He felt the convulsion of her throat as she gagged, and a second spurt filled her mouth, making her squeeze her eyes shut tight. Zoe had *never*; ever let him do this before.

He was expecting her to push him away, which is what she had done on the few occasions he had failed to hold off until he was out of her mouth.

Instead, her eyes opened again, and he felt a little purr when the third spurt exploded deep inside her throat.

Her tongue swirled around his shaft as she released him, and he shuddered. She swallowed, the bitterness registering in her expression momentarily, then brought a finger to the corner of her mouth and wiped away a glob of pearly liquid that had escaped her lips.

"What was *that*? " Josh said, shuddering again.

Zoe smiled. A mysterious smile. She rolled up slowly from her kneeling position, like she was doing something in a yoga class.

Cheerfully, she shrugged. "Just trying something new," she said. "I, um... sort of expected it to last a little longer, but no biggie."

For a moment, a look of horror flashed across her face. "Not like, I mean, I just meant that like, not as an insult or anything, I was just hoping for... you know."

Josh was staring at her. She was acting *very* strangely, and it was turning him on. His cock was still pretty stiff, and he could feel a new erection rearing its head. He reached for the thin strap of her nightie and slid it from her shoulder.

"Seems like a waste of this sexy nightie," he said.

He slipped the other strap off, and the material rolled down, sliding over her skin to expose one hard nipple. He tugged at the other side, pulling the nightie down to her midriff. His first, perverse instinct was to scan her breasts for signs of having been suckled, and just the thought of it made his dick rock-hard again. He brushed his thumbs over the peaks of her breasts and looked back up at her face.

Her eyes were glistening, pupils large, heartbeat wild. Zoe had a very strange and unique feature on her face where, if she was doing something wildly aerobic or stimulating, the tiny pulse of some sinus artery became very faintly visible on the right side of the bridge of her nose. It was pulsing away now, with her wild heart rate.

Josh put his hand on her collarbone and pulled her toward him, covering her mouth with his. He could taste the remnant of his own bitter cum in her mouth, just a slight aftertaste, and when he let himself imagine that it was some other man's, his cock filled to a painful hardness that punched him in the gut.

Impatiently, he pushed her into the living room, turned her around, and bent her over the sofa table and the back of the sofa. A lamp teetered and fell to the floor with a crash. Zoe said nothing, letting herself be bent over and positioned to Josh's will. Her hair fell down and over her face and she let him handle her like that. He shoved her nightie over her backside; she wasn't wearing any panties. Her slit was swollen and glistening, and when he felt it, hot and slick as if she had just come.

His cock was hard enough to guide himself into her without using his hands. The velvety heat of her pussy quivered around his cock, gobbling him up, enveloping him in her soaked heat.

Zoe mewled as he fucked her slowly. She pushed against him, her pussy clenching around his cock. "Oh, oh, oh!" she screeched, trying to fuck him faster. He pushed on her lower back to hold her in place, continuing with his slow strokes.

And only when she finally came, her pussy spasming and spurting as she kicked at the floor and howled like a wild animal, did he allow himself to pound at her with deep, satisfying thrusts. When he thought, however briefly, of her pussy being so slick with the load of another man - with Randy's load - he came violently, ramming so deep inside of her that her pussy wrapped around his balls like the lips of a second mouth.

*

"What was *that*?"

Josh's voice pierced the near-sleep that had begun to take over Zoe's mind. It was the second time he'd asked the question, but the first time they'd spoken after climbing haphazardly over the couch and stretching out, head-to-toe, on the large sofa, Zoe snuggled in the interior side. They had exchanged smiles that were almost shy and settled in on the couch, Josh stroking her feet. He pulled the throw blanket over them, and in no time she was warm from his body and the blanket. She had begun to doze off.

But his voice sent a jolt through her: the pleasant slumber she had been drifting away to crashed around her and her heart was seized by something akin to panic. She left her eyes closed, but beneath her skin her pulse raced and she felt the heat of guilt boiling up from deep inside her.

She forced herself to smile demurely while her mind raced to find something to say. Something that would not be a lie, but something that would also not be the complete truth.

Because the truth, in which "that" had been the result of her dinner with Randy, the tension that had built on the way home, the fire that had started when he kissed her, and the state of arousal her imagination had ignited in the shower just before Josh got home.

"That" had been her thinking about fucking another man while her husband fucked her.

She felt Josh's lips on the side of her foot, near her big toe. He kissed her skin, sending a tremor through her, and left his mouth close to her foot as he spoke.

"That was incredibly hot," he murmured. His warm breath traveled over her toe, along the flat of her foot, sending a pulse of arousal along the inside of her leg and straight to her pussy. And then:

"Maybe we just needed to mix things up a little bit." He moved her foot to put his mouth on the flat of it, just beneath her arch. He teased her by licking her foot, and she jerked involuntarily and squealed, because she was incredibly ticklish. Josh held on to her foot firmly, and pulled it back toward his mouth.

Her eyes flew open. "Josh!" she shrieked. She tried to squirm away, but he was playful now, flicking his tongue at the bottom of her

foot. "Stop! I can't stand it!" She was laughing. Josh sat up and released her foot, climbing on top of her, smiling.

He pushed her hair from her face. Then he kissed her forehead.

It was a warm, possessive, comforting kiss. The weight of his body sank onto her, reassuring and strong. Looking into her eyes for a moment, he smiled at her. "Maybe it's for the best."

She knew what he was referring to, of course. A finger of cold shot through her, but she smiled back at him. "What's for the best?"

she whispered, afraid of the answer.

Josh, one hand still on her forehead, rolling to the side slightly, gave an approximation of a shrug. His weight sank into her for a moment, knocking the wind from her chest. He settled on the side of her, teetering precariously on the couch. He rested his head in the hand that had been on her forehead and used his other hand to pull the blanket away from her breasts and down to her navel. He stroked her like someone would pet a cat. "That whole thing with Randy. Maybe we don't need that, maybe it was better as a fantasy.

It seems to have done the trick."

Zoe was rendered speechless.

Her intention before he said all of this, had been to tell him about Randy as soon as possible. She just needed to figure out how to explain to him what had happened, how to confess to the lie she had told him when she'd thought that Randy had turned her down. It was hard coming up with the right words for admitting something like that - that she had been humiliated enough, by the thought that Randy had turned her down, to lie to her husband.

And then it was going to be hard to find the right way to explain to him that things had changed, and that she was going to go through with it, after all. When he had come home early, she had lost control of herself and her plan, and the reason for that had been Randy.

And now this.

Her heart felt as though it were flinging itself around in her chest. The effect was the same as so many other things had been lately: she was cold to the bone and hot all at once, paralyzed both in thought and physical motion. When she opened her mouth to speak, she found that her breath had left her lungs long ago and she

hadn't taken a new breath since. She inhaled, and it sounded like a gasp to her ears.

Josh didn't seem to notice. His eyes were watching his hand as he moved it up and down the length of her body.

"I'm sort of glad about this," he said quietly. Then he looked at her and kissed her. She couldn't be sure, but he seemed to be looking for something in her eyes. Like he was trying to read something there.

Another kiss, and Zoe tried her best to make her astonished face contort into a smile, with no traces of worry clouding her eyes. It seemed to work. Josh hopped up from the couch and fished for his boxers, which had come off somewhere in the awkward tumble over the back of the couch, from the crack in the couch. He put them on, hopping from one foot to the other and moving, at the same time, toward the kitchen. He let the elastic waistband snap as he walked away. "I'm starving. Did you eat already?"

Zoe stared at the dark ceiling, her head spinning.

"Zoe?" Josh said after a while. "You hungry? Or did you eat at your team-building thing?"

"I ate already," she said quickly, more to get him to stop talking than anything else.

She sat up and put her head between her hands, elbows on knees.

Josh was behaving oddly. She was sure of it.

Or was he not, and she was only seeing it that way because she felt guilty about going out with Randy?

Why had she gone out with Randy without clearing it with Josh first? Now, she felt like she had done something wrong, and really, she knew that Josh would have told her to go ahead with it, if she'd spoken to him. But for some reason she had wanted to talk to Randy first, to somehow confirm that he hadn't turned her down.

Or was there more to it than that? Did she *like*, in some perverse way, keeping Randy a secret from Josh?

It didn't matter if she did or she didn't: she had to tell him. She needed to clear things up right now.

"Where'd you go this time?"

Josh was standing in the kitchen doorway, leaning against the frame, chugging carbonated water from a Soda Stream bottle, which was something that drove her crazy.

"What?" she asked, her voice absent-minded.

Josh took another gulp, and screwed the cap back on. Was it her imagination, or was he looking at her pointedly? "For the team-building thingy," he said. "What'd you guys do?"

The microwave beeped. Josh didn't move. His fingers were still on the cap, his eyes locked on Zoe's face.

She was unable to stop herself from looking away. Her eyes veered sharply down and to the right, looking at her foot. This was the moment. She was cornered and she would have to either start talking about what she'd done, and admit to all the lies - most of which had been made for reasons that were embarrassing - or she would have to tell another fib.

Queasiness grew in her stomach and spread through her chest.

The seconds were ticking by, making her answer, whatever she chose it to be, sound stranger with each tick of the clock. "Oh, right,"

she said. "Just the usual."

There was a lengthy pause. Zoe moved her chin forward and backward on her knee because stillness only amplified the intense physical reaction inside of her. Why the hell was she lying to him right now? She instantly wanted to take it back, but she couldn't. She needed to buy herself some time, find a way to explain her behavior that didn't make her seem like a silly twat, and yet come clean.

The microwave gave a reminding chirp. Josh pushed himself away from the door frame with his shoulder. She looked up at him, and saw that he was still looking at her, strangely, just before he gave a turn and walked back into the kitchen. "Must have been pretty boozy," Josh said.

Zoe was deep in thought, her stomach in knots, trying to figure out why she wasn't just spilling the whole truth to Josh. Why not?

This whole thing had been *his* idea. Wouldn't he be happy if she told him she had actually changed course, and was now going to enact his fantasy?

Why wasn't she saying that?

"How'd you get home?"

Josh's voice was coming back toward the door frame, his long shadow ahead of him.

Zoe's head was spinning.

She hit upon a realization just before answering him.

She was not telling Josh because she was afraid he might change his mind, and tell her not to do it after all.

He was twisting a fork in a Chinese takeout box. His eyes dropped to check on the noodles, and then he looked back at her, a genuine desire to hear her answer in his eyes.

"You didn't drive home like that, did you?"

"Of course not," Zoe said. But what would she say now? Her mind tried to find some way for her to be here, without having driven home drunk, and without Randy driving her home. What was it?

"No," she said, clearing her throat. She waved her hand in the direction of the street as she talked. "That thing was, you know, up here. So we, so I had Alicia follow me home, drop off my car."

Josh looked at her. She couldn't read the expression on his face very well, and the effect was chilling.

And oddly, as an afterthought, the effect was also *thrilling*.

"Thought you said it was the usual," Josh said, but shoved a ton of noodles in his mouth and turned around as he did, so he was walking away.

Zoe's head spun, and for a moment she didn't understand his statement.

"Oh. Yeah. Well... it was, just, bowling. The usual. But for some reason, it was over here."

One aspect of her company's training was occasional cross-departmental workshops. One of the most fascinating of those had been when the Special Investigations Unit had presented their jobs and daily tasks, one of which was to grill people they thought had committed insurance fraud. The head of the department was rumored to have worked for the CIA, which wasn't something Zoe really believed, but he *did* look the part. At a memorable moment in the Q&A, which everyone had enjoyed because it was infinitely less boring than their own daily tasks and responsibilities, someone had asked how he knew when people were lying. "People tend to talk too much when they're telling a lie," he had answered. "Adding a bunch

of details you never asked for, things they would never volunteer in an ordinary conversation."

Zoe didn't lie a lot or talk to a lot of people who did in her life, but this observation had stuck with her and she'd noticed it to be at least superficially true.

And now, as she rattled on and on, she recognized that it was *in fact* true that liars became blabbermouths, but she was powerless to close her own mouth even as this thought loomed large in her consciousness. She heard herself talking and wanted to put a gag in her mouth.

"I think it was because Gloria, who is supposed to arrange all this stuff, dropped the ball, and then - but, she lives over this way, too, you know. So

maybe she just didn't feel like driving all that way.

Actually, a lot of people live on this side of town so maybe it was even something she did on purpose, like maybe, yeah, actually, I think a few of us complained about having to drive home all the way from the other side of town all the time. Especially because then we can't drink. And also everyone is late the next day because they have to get their cars from the light rail station. And Neil can't really say anything about that, since they're trying to promote this no-drunk-driving policy, like corporate culture thing. Right? So yeah, thinking about it now, it might have been done on purpose. Anyway...

it was over here."

Josh was chewing the noodles, staring at her.

"That was a really long explanation," Zoe said, trying to make light of it.

"Sure was," Josh said.

"I must be drunker than I thought," she added. And then she literally bit her own tongue to stop herself from adding a litany of false details about *that*, because she did feel the urge.

Josh looked into his noodle carton to get the last of the noodles.

"We have anything else to eat around here? I don't think I ate all day."

"I can make you something," Zoe said, overly helpful. She jumped off the couch and scanned the floor for her nightie.

When she reached the kitchen, Josh was standing in front of the open freezer. "No, it's cool," he said, reaching for a box far in the

back of the overstuffed shelves. "I think there are some pizza pops from when you went to see your sister."

"Josh, gross," she said, as he turned and grinned at her. "Let me make you something not... you know, disgusting."

He was already opening the package, grinning at her.

The plastic tore, his eyes were on hers, and she couldn't be sure that they weren't glinting, almost maliciously. She couldn't know if there was anything behind that glint more than their constant ideological wars about food, in which Josh ate processed crap that didn't even *taste* good and Zoe frowned upon it.

"I like to have something a little bit trashy every now and then,"

he said.

The expression on his face was serious.

CHAPTER 13

"You seem nervous."

Randy's voice was much the same as the last time he had said this to her and she wondered, briefly, if he had talked like this for his whole life, or if being a shrink had just melded into his mind and he couldn't turn it off. She couldn't remember her past conversations with him, but then, she hadn't been paying attention in quite the same way back then.

Zoe pressed her hands together and shifted from one foot to the other. Then she laughed, and heard herself: the laugh didn't sound like her at all. It was high-pitched, almost hysterical. She gave her hair a toss as she crossed the room and set her purse on the counter. Then she looked back at Randy, who was closing his front door behind them.

"I, uh... yeah," Zoe said. Her hair was freshly washed, she could smell her new shampoo and the vague hint of heated hair that had been left by the straightener. The aromas from her body - the dab of perfume, the lotion she had applied after trimming and shaving her pussy into a tidy line, a leftover waft of the buttery cream she had used to avoid razor burn, and somewhere beneath it all, her own arousal - drifted up to her nose as the smell of deceit. She had done all of these things, deliberately and intentionally, while telling

herself she was coming here to tell Randy the truth so that he would talk her out of doing what she was so obviously intent on doing.

He leaned against his hands, behind his back and against the door. Crossed one foot over the other. His muscles were outlined in the casual t-shirt he wore, the kind of expensive, well-fitting t-shirt that wealthy and attractive men wore. Beneath the untucked shirt, jeans fit him snugly but not tightly, because Randy was a generation away from the hipster jeans that guys her age wore, and he seemed to desire to make the distinction.

And he looked hot.

Zoe's stomach did a flip, and her heart accelerated. She set her hand on the counter because it would otherwise reveal that she was shaking. Randy was giving her the kind of tell-me-what-you-did look that fathers give daughters, or shrinks give patients, or cops give reckless sixteen-year-old girls who were caught speeding. This didn't help the situation, and she realized that the way he made her feel was definitively perverse for that reason.

"I didn't tell Josh," she confessed, in a voice near a whisper.

Randy pushed himself away from the door - there was a symmetry to the way he did this and the way Josh had done it two nights before. His eyebrows were raised. "Why's that?"

Zoe lifted her wrist, leaving her fingertips on the counter. She could feel the way her body was moving, and she knew herself well enough to know perfectly well that she was being sexually suggestive with every move. "I don't know," she said. Her voice sounded helpless, which was a good approximation of how she felt, because in a way she was hostage to whatever was driving her to do something, right now, and right here, that was totally, totally *wrong*.

"But here you are," Randy said calmly. He was walking toward her.

Zoe looked at her fingers.

"So what does that mean?"

It was Randy who asked this question out loud, but his voice was like a chorus for her own thoughts. Why *was* she here?

She knew the answer, of course. Deep down inside she knew that all of the hand-wringing she was doing, all of the hesitation, all of the pondering and conflict, was almost theater. Theater performed inside her mind, for her mind, and for herself. What she really wanted was to be doing exactly what she was doing: something over-the-line, taboo, risky. With Randy. And she also knew that whatever she was telling herself about why she had lied (by omission) to Josh, at least part of the reason was that doing so made this all the more... exciting.

The only thing she didn't really know was where everything would go from here.

Zoe shook her head. "I don't... I don't know."

Randy reached for her hand, and used his fingers to grip it between his, in a detached, non-tender way. But the grip was possessive, and he pulled her with him into the next room, the living area with the sofa, where she had sat with him the first night she had come here.

"You want something to drink?" he asked, depositing her on the couch. He continued to his mini-bar and started to make a drink.

"Yeah, okay," she said.

He mixed the drinks in silence and handed one to her before sitting down. "Just one, though," he said.

He settled onto the couch. "You don't seem to be here in person to tell me that you've changed your mind," he said.

"No."

"But you decided not to tell Josh."

She shrugged. "It's... he kind of, I don't know. Said something that made me feel like he'd changed *his* mind. So now, I don't...

really know what to do. I don't know what I'm doing."

Randy smiled into his drink, as if the drink had told him a joke.

"I think you know *exactly* what you're doing, Zoe."

"I don't want to be this person," she complained.

Randy swallowed his drink and looked at her. "What kind of person is that, Zoe?"

Zoe curled her legs up next to her, without answering.

"Let me help you out of your dilemma," Randy said. He seemed to come closer to her on the couch, and his demeanor had changed from that of a therapist to that of a predator, but it didn't bother Zoe.

It exhilarated her.

"Would you be here, Zoe, if Josh didn't have this fantasy?"

She blinked.

"I... no," she said breathlessly.

Something about the logic of it was faulty, but Randy had chosen the question carefully. She could tell by the way he was looking at her that he had his reasons for doing so, and they were selfish and carnal, but she let herself be convinced.

"Do you think Josh's fantasy is real?"

She hesitated, and then nodded.

"So, whatever you do, you can always find a way to justify it to yourself, can't you? After all, you're only here because you're trying to give your

husband what he told you he wanted."

"I -" Zoe began, but not only was she unable to argue with that, but she didn't really want to.

"You decided, before coming here, what you were going to do."

Zoe's lips were parted, and disbelief washed over her face, she could feel it in her features. But something was stopping her from reacting to Randy's arrogance the way she would have reacted to any other man's.

"If I were you," Randy said, setting his drink on the coffee table,

"I would tell my husband that I just..." He looked up at the ceiling. He seemed to really be thinking about it, but Zoe recognized something of theatrics in the gesture. Like he *wanted* her to think he was thinking about it. "...needed some practice. Before the real thing," he finished.

"Who said -" Zoe began.

"Zoe, you're not sitting on my couch, smelling that good, wearing those clothes, because you want some more advice."

It was true, but she felt compelled to try and repudiate it.

"I -"

"You're here to make a mistake. And you know you're going to make it. So let me make it a little easier for you, once it's made.

You're doing it for Josh, and you're going to tell him you just needed the practice."

Her eyes dropped to Randy's groin. He sat like a much younger man, legs spread wide, elbows on knees. When he saw where she looked, he sat up, and spread his arms over the back of the sofa.

She could see the outline of his cock, she had felt it up against her before. Derek had a pretty big dick, as she recalled, but Randy's looked so much

larger. So much larger, in fact, that she couldn't get the idea of it out of her mind, which surprised her, because she was always the first person to say, "size doesn't matter."

Something about actually seeing a man's cock this large, pulsing beneath his jeans, for her, fascinated her, though. She could almost feel it spreading her open: it was thick enough that it would sting a little. If he fucked her even a little bit hard, her pussy would

be sore for days, and she could almost feel it now between her legs and it made her pussy ache for him.

"What are you thinking?" Randy asked, but he seemed to know exactly what she was thinking.

She met his eyes. She should probably be ashamed of what she was thinking, but the way he was looking at her, she didn't really.

After all, hadn't they already talked about this? Didn't she have permission from her husband to think about Randy like this? Isn't it what he wanted?

So when her hand, seeming to move of its own volition, floated from her lap to his, and her palm moved over the thick tube of meat underneath his jeans, she watched it almost as if she were watching a movie. When she heard her own voice, the experience was the same.

"It's just... it's, uh... really big."

"He's going to like that," Randy said, watching her hand on his cock. For a moment, he was still, watching her trace the shape of his dick through his jeans. He moved suddenly, too quickly for her to react: his hand was on her cheek, his mouth was close to hers, and he had done it all without making her hand fall from his cock. He tucked a strand of hair behind her ear. "And so are you."

Zoe was stunned for a moment. Randy's cock pulsed in her hand, and now that he had pushed against her, she could feel the strength in his body. The mismatch between their sizes and strengths became very apparent to her in

that moment: up until then, the idea had been almost academic. Maybe she had expected it to be more clinical, more detached, because of the way Randy had discussed it until now.

But now, she could feel him straining against his jeans, feel the hard muscle of his body, the man-strength inside of him that was so different than Josh. Now it seemed real. She felt fear snake through her body, and she knew that Randy would recognize it in her face, feel the slight shudder of her body beneath his hands. Her mouth fell open, and she gasped very quietly. She could almost feel her pupils dilate.

On the heels of that quick pulse of fear, came a welling of juices between her legs. The fear settled in as an ache between her legs -

curiously, this was where she felt her fear of heights, right in her cunt.

She shook her head, a rapid, almost desperate shake. "I don't know if..." she began. Randy was staring at her, a little bit of a smirk on his lips, and a little bit of that face most men made right before they come. His expression consumed her and she forgot how she had even begun her sentence.

What did she not know "if?" If she should be doing this? If it was a good idea? If she would like it? If she would be able to handle a man like Randy?

While she deliberated about this, Randy's hand traveled from her cheek, along her neck, down to the edge of her blouse. His fingertips lingered at the collar, stroking the skin just above it with a feathery touch. Zoe was mesmerized, staring at his lips, trying to think her way out of the spell she was under, out of doing this very bad thing that she was hurtling toward. But his fingers felt so good, and the shape of his cock was so appealing. Her breath was shallow and rapid.

Randy's fingers pulled apart the top button of her blouse, and the tips traveled further, to the swells of her breasts, playing between them, grazing the lace of her bra. Her eyes darted to his, and locked with his stare: in his eyes was a look of obsession that made her quite dizzy.

"I don't know if... we should... I should..." she whispered helplessly. He was pushing her back down onto the couch, gently, but just behind the gentleness there was a steely strength coiled in his touch. There wasn't any going back on this, she realized.

His fingers deftly opened another button as he climbed on top of her. She was between his thighs now, and he was on his knees, surveying what was laid out beneath him.

He moved his hands gently over her body as he removed her blouse, watching as he revealed new inches of her. Zoe stared at him. His clinical expression was gone. Had she expected it to stay?

There seemed to be something more to the way he was looking at her than just the anticipation of having sex. Something dark lurked in his eyes.

Fear rippled through her again, and she reached for his forearm. "Randy," she whispered. "I'm a little bit -"

His hands moved to her skirt as he scooted down, pulling the material with him, peeling it away from her, leaving her panties on.

"Don't be afraid," he said, soothingly. "I'm going to be gentle this first time."

He wrangled the skirt away from her legs and rose up on his knees again to survey the length of her body, now almost entirely exposed. His right hand was at his waist, unfastening his jeans.

Once they were loose, he reached up and over his head to pull his shirt off.

He tossed it to the side and Zoe stared at his body. A tattoo, unexpected, covered his left pec. For a man who was, in her mind, quite old, he was incredibly fit, really very sexy.

She plunged from that thought again into the abyss of feeling that everything about this was wrong. This was Derek's *father*, after all. And she had only the loosest of permissions from Josh. She wondered again if he

really, truly wanted her to be doing this, what he would think about this "practice session."

As she opened her mouth to object, one last time, even though she knew that there was no way to back out of it at this point, Randy edged up her body enough to put his finger on her lips. He shook his head slowly. "You can do this," he told her.

His tone was different now. Zoe recognized the change, recognized the implications of it. Gone was the doctorly, clinical Dr.

McIntyre, and in his place was a man who wanted to fuck, who *had* wanted to fuck her all along, and who was now in possession of her tacit permission.

Her stomach was tingling with excitement and guilt, because deep down inside, she knew this *was* what she wanted. A fantasy she maybe didn't realize she had - until Josh had brought it up - and one she certainly had never meant to enact, something she never would have put in motion herself. It was wrong - it was wrong because this man was so much older, because she could see in his eyes that he had wanted this since she was underaged, that he had been gently leading her in this direction. And all of that was taboo

and delicious. Maybe because no matter what she told herself, it couldn't be entirely cleansed of its wrongness.

His hand moved from her lips to her hand, which had fallen along with the other to her chest, where she was cradling it awkwardly, unsure of what to do. He guided her hand to his open fly, one hand pushing his boxers and jeans down and the other holding her wrist.

His cock sprang from the boxers and he closed her hand around it. It was smooth as sheepskin, dry, hot. Her fingers did not meet up around its girth, and it felt heavy in her hand. It was, without doubt, the biggest cock she had ever seen in real life, definitely the biggest she had ever felt, and she was a little alarmed now that she actually held it.

Randy was watching her hand on his cock. She felt it pulse beneath her palm. He moved her wrist so that she stroked him, and his mouth fell open.

Suddenly, he pushed her hand away, stuffing it between her hip and the couch, working it beneath her body weight. He leaned over her, both hands at her shoulder straps, pulling them down, peeling her bra away from her breasts. He kissed her chest, brushing his lips over her skin, and breathed on her nipple as he passed over it, making it form a hard ball. He did the same to the other, and flicked at her nipple with his tongue.

Her free hand went to his head, her fingers into his hair. Her back arched and she pushed herself to his mouth, craving his lips to close around the peaks of her breast. He pushed her arm impatiently to her side and pinned it to her body.

He took his time, kissing her and then brushing his sharp stubble against her skin, moving his lips over the sensitive center of her tits, never enclosing them in his mouth. She pushed up to him, but he only smiled and continued on his way.

His mouth traveled down her abdomen, to her panties, and then he was pulling them away. Both of his hands went to her wrists and held her as his mouth moved along her inner thigh, his breath was hot on her mound, his stubble grazed her thigh and then the center of her legs. He worked his tongue into her slit, which was pressed

closed by her thighs, because he still had her legs trapped between his.

His tongue was quick, finding her clit and massaging it with a dexterity she had never thought possible from a man. She pressed outward against his legs and squirmed as he brought her close to orgasm within minutes. She mewled in a sort of sweet agony: she had never before wanted so much to spread her legs wide for a man.

Just as she was about to sail over the edge of an intense orgasm, his tongue stopped, and he rose up on his knees and backed to the end of the couch before standing to free himself of his jeans and boxers.

She was released now: her wrists were free, and her legs were not pinned closed. Coming so close to an orgasm, however, had hit her like a belly flop. She was disoriented, panting, frozen in the pose he had left her in.

He surveyed her, his cock in his hand, stroking it slowly.

She didn't move, she remained as he had left her, and as he climbed on top of her, she realized that this is what he had wanted, that it gave him some kind of domination over her, or signified it at least.

And also, she realized, she didn't care.

He nudged her legs open with his knee, and then guided his cock to her wet hole. When his eyes dropped to look at her pussy, they glazed over with the frightening expression she had seen earlier: possessiveness, obsession, something dark, played across his face.

And then his eyes were on hers, and he was lowering his body over her slowly, the tip of his cock still pulsing against her entrance.

His fingers went to her lips, stroking them. "Relax, Zoe," he whispered. "And just let me slide right in. We'll go nice and gentle this time, nice and slow."

Zoe's body seized up when he slid into her. A sharp pain crackled and quickly dissolved. Her eyes went wide as the sensation, almost of a kind of micro-popping, rippled through her.

Was he going to actually break something inside of her? "Randy," she breathed. "I can't... you're too big..."

His hand was under her neck, and he pulled her up to him, her lips to his shoulder. "Shhh, just relax, you can take it," he coaxed.

And he pushed inside of her a little deeper.

She bit his shoulder as his fat prick spread her pussy lips wide.

Under his weight, her hips were crushed open, but it didn't hurt, maybe because she was so flexible. Between her legs, the pain of being stretched had faded, and now it was just a throbbing, sweet ache, as he filled her deeper and deeper.

It was like nothing she had ever experienced before. It was terrifying, in a way.

As he had promised, he fucked her slowly. The orgasm he had interrupted, that had derailed with the sharp pain of his huge cock, began to build again inside of her. She closed her eyes, and bit into his shoulder as the momentum of her pleasure began to build. "Oh,"

she heard herself mewl.

It wasn't like her to make a sound like that for real: she wasn't the howling type. She did it sometimes because Josh liked it, and it had never felt like she was "faking" anything, because she got a lot of pleasure from sex with Josh. Just... not so much that she couldn't control her vocal cords. But this mewl escaped her throat without her permission, and her nose began to feel tingly, a ringing building up in her ears.

She wrapped her legs around Randy's torso, and squeezed with her thighs to pull him deeper inside of her, and grind her clit against his pubic bone, anything to speed her rush toward the edge that she knew was out there. The size of him made him present everywhere inside of her, she could feel him pushing against her ass, through the canal of her anus, almost as if his thick crown was rubbing right on her tailbone.

Randy sank his full weight on top of her then, and he was deep inside of her, but she couldn't grind against him, because he was too heavy, and he was actively pinning her down. His mouth was on her ear as she struggled to wiggle beneath him. "Ssshhhh, settle down, not yet."

She whimpered: the orgasm building inside of her was too much to endure. She dug her heels into his lower back, and his cock sank into her even deeper, a vague discomfort somewhere deep in

her belly informing her his prick had bumped up against her cervix -

the sort of pornographic thing she had believed was half-nonsense when she read it in erotic stories. From her throat, all kinds of nonsensical noises were escaping, and she had lost control of them all.

Randy moved stealthily, rising up on his knees and sitting back on his heels, dragging her body with him, hands grasping her hips and holding her still, impaled on his cock. He was looking down at her with an expression of pure lust, and total dominance, and the wild cries escaped her throat again.

"Settle down," he said. "I'm going to fuck you nice and slow, Zoe. I want to enjoy this." He pushed against her hips, which he held in large, firm hands that practically encircled her hips.

Zoe looked down at where the slick length of his cock was emerging from inside of her, and the girth of it surprised her again.

"Randy," she panted. But whatever she had intended to say flew from her mind as he began to fill her slowly back up.

She could feel her pussy quivering uncontrollably around his cock, like some other part of her that she had no control over. She arched her back, and her hands flew to his forearms. She tried to pull on them, to press herself against him, but the strength of his grip on her hips was like steel. Her legs kicked behind him, useless in her efforts.

"Shhh, Zoe, there will be plenty of time for you to get wild later.

Right now, I'm going to fuck you nice and slow, and all you have you to do is take it. Fuck, you're so tight." He sank on top of her body again, and she dug her fingernails into his back and struggled to move, but could not.

He let her flail beneath him, a smile on his lips whenever she looked at him, whispering to her to quiet down. But his words only made her crave him more.

At last, she gave a whimper of defeat, and bit into his shoulder again, letting her body relax beneath him.

"That's good," he whispered.

He fucked her so slowly that she thought she might remain in that terrible crest just before release for an eternity. Tears welled up in her eyes, not of pain or sadness or frustration, but of being

overwhelmed. She thought, at one point, that she might lose consciousness completely. The orgasm only continued to build, her insides becoming more raw with every thrust of his cock. Her cervix began to feel sore, but the soreness was pleasant; it only aroused her more.

She was just about to plead with him, because the need between her legs was reaching a pitch so fevered she was sure she could not handle any more.

And then, at last, it swirled faster and faster, up and up, and broke.

The stars at the edges of her vision swarmed to the center and blocked out part of Randy's face, like a bad signal on satellite TV.

The ringing in her ears drowned out her own voice, which escaped in strangled, warped shapes from her open mouth. And all through her body, every fiber seemed to ring violently.

Randy was above her now, but she had no idea what he looked like. His cock was deep inside of her, then threatening to be gone, and then at last she felt, amid the hot liquid seeping from her own cunt and sliding to her anus, his hot burst of cum. He thrust into her deep enough that she squealed. Once, twice, and one final time.

She closed her eyes. Her body was spasming around his cock, her legs open and limp, sweat covering them both in a slippery sheen. He rested his weight on top of her for a moment, before rising onto his arms and looking down at her.

He sat back on his heels again, letting his cock slip from inside of her. Her pussy squelched as his cock flopped, still semi-hard, against his thigh.

She pulled her leg from the side of him closest to the couch, and crossed it over her left leg, but her hands refused to do anything for her, and she could feel the vacant stare on her face. It was one of the few times in her life that Zoe had been stunned absolutely speechless.

Randy dropped a hand to her right hip, looking at it with an intensity that she almost found frightening. He turned his fingers toward the crack of her ass and ran them from her lower back, into the valley between her buttocks, and over her asshole.

"That was a good start," he said.

His other hand was carelessly on his cock, not stroking it so much as loosely playing with it. Zoe wondered if he intended to fuck her again, and what she would do if he did. She felt as raw and depleted as she had ever felt in her life.

His fingers moved through the slippery cum dripping from her pussy, and back up over her ass. She heard a sound, and then realized it was her own voice. "Randy..." she whispered.

His finger slipped into her asshole, just to the knuckle. Josh had played with her ass before, so the pain didn't come as a surprise, and she knew how to open up for him.

But Josh had never fucked her in the ass before. She moaned and put a hand on his forearm.

He wiggled his finger inside of her, watching her face as her mouth fell open.

"Randy," she began again. "I can't..."

He pushed in a little deeper, and she gasped, but then he withdrew his finger. He was still looking at her hip, watching his hand slide through the

sweat on her skin. "I like this position," he said, almost as if talking to himself. Then he met her eyes. "When I fuck you in the ass, I'm going to do it like this."

Her eyes went wide, and she tried to laugh to play off how much that thought terrified her. "Who said I was going to let you do that?"

she asked, light-heartedly.

"You will," he said, moving his hand back between her thighs, sliding a finger over her slit and grazing her clit, making her whole body jump. "And you'll like it." He stroked her clit again, and though she fought it, she trembled violently for a second time. "So will Josh."

He looked up at her face. "Don't worry," he said. "We'll practice, nice and slow. At first."

Something had definitely changed in Randy, and she wasn't entirely sure she liked it. But then, she wasn't entirely sure she *disliked* it, either. She just hadn't expected him to be so... what?

Controlling? Sure of himself?

She should, she thought listlessly, tell him to fuck off. In fact, she would, because this was completely out of control.

He was turning her around, pushing her down to the floor on all fours. The movement brought Zoe's aching pussy back to the

forefront of her mind. "Randy," she whispered. "I... can't... I'm too sore...oh, *oh*, oh my God."

She heard herself, as if she were someone else, because his cock was already slipping inside of her again before she had finished her complaint about soreness. And she was letting him do it, because it felt... good.

So good.

He was all the way in, and this time, entering her from behind, his cock touched new places, pushing up from inside of her cunt against the canal of her ass. Once inside of her, he paused, one hand still holding her by the hip, the other reaching into her hair and winding it slowly into his fist, until it was tight and started to pull at her scalp. He tipped her head back, and then his cock was moving inside of her again.

"You don't know how long I've wanted to fuck you, Zoe," she heard him say, at some point in the delirium that began to build up inside of her again. She barely registered it at the time, because she was grinding against him, her body and mind swallowed by the next oncoming wave of pleasure, and the unbearable need for release that felt like it was burning her alive. She felt his palm on her lower back and part of her buttock before his thumb plunged into her ass.

His cock pushed against it, the flesh between her most intimate parts was squeezed between them, and the newness of the sensation made her shudder from head to toe.

And then, she was screaming, flying out of control, her pussy pulsing and quivering. She fell to her chest, and tried to dig her fingers into the carpet, as her orgasm came in a flurry of excruciating pleasure and a blizzard of stars across her eyes, and then went.

While Randy kept slamming deep inside of her, her ass pulsing around his thumb, her pussy squelching with each thrust. Zoe lay helplessly on the floor, feeling him saw in and out of her, the tacky scratch of his thumb in her ass turning to raw pleasure. The thought that she was "taking it," hard, from a man with a huge cock, floated around in her thoughts like an ember, landing somewhere between her legs to burn a patch of renewed arousal inside of her.

She felt Randy's thighs stiffen, his cock drive deep inside of her, the soft flesh of his balls that had been slapping her innermost thighs

crush between their bodies, and then heard him groan and felt the explosion of his hot cum, deep inside, then overflowing, running between her thighs.

He remained inside of her, and so she lay still, panting. She winced, but not entirely in pain, as he pulled his thumb from inside her ass, slowly, moving it in a leisurely circle when just the tip was still embedded in her flesh. She shuddered. He stroked her backside, his hands slipping over her wet skin as though she were covered in baby oil.

And then, as slowly as he had withdrawn his thumb, he slipped his cock from inside of her. Liquid ran in torrents between her thighs, and she heard his cock slap against his own skin. She started to roll over, but he caught her hip with his hand, pushing her gently against the couch. He held her there only a moment, but it seemed to last an eternity as he stared at her.

When the pressure of his hand softened, she rolled to the side, letting her left arm fall above her head. Her hair clung to her cheek, but she didn't push it away.

Randy was staring at her, another new expression on his face.

As his cum trickled between her thighs, and the rawness inside her pussy began to throb again, she was overtaken by a sudden attack of guilt, and fear: even though she had talked herself into it, the slippery semen between her thighs made it real. She had fucked a man other than her husband.

"Oh God," she said quietly, her eyes losing focus and staring emptily at the ceiling.

"Did I hurt you?" Randy's hand was running along her inner thigh, catching some of the cum and spreading it all over her leg with his caress.

Zoe shook her head, almost as if she were confused, and propped herself up on her elbows, still looking muddled. "I can't believe... I just did that," she said. Her eyes met Randy's. "Oh God.

Maybe this was a mistake."

Randy stroked her shoulder with the pads of his fingers and moved his hand behind her neck, pulling her up to sitting while sliding her legs over his lap

with his other hand. She felt his cock, still twitching, on her ass as she slid along. He pushed her head

against his shoulder. "We talked about this. You talked to him about this. He told you this is what he wanted. That's why you did it -"

"But what if -?"

Randy laughed a little, almost sardonically. "If he didn't mean it, that's not your problem. He can't tell you he has a fantasy, and that he really wants you to do it, and expect you to read his mind that he actually doesn't. You can't be a mind reader."

Zoe was silent.

"The only thing to question is, how do you feel?"

Zoe pushed herself off Randy's lap and, in a quick movement, onto the couch. She pulled her blouse to cover herself and took her panties in her hand. Randy looked up at her.

"Guilty, I think," she said.

"You shouldn't feel that."

"I know."

"Other than guilty?"

Clinical Randy seemed to have returned. Like a Dr. Jekyll.

Zoe opened her mouth, but had nothing to say. Or no way of saying it. The truth was that she felt guilty, but not so much because she had gone through with it, as that she *liked it* so much. She liked it much more than she had thought she would. She liked it *because* it was so wrong, because he was Randy, and because his cock was huge, and because he was doing things to her that she knew Josh never would.

And she liked them.

Randy gave her a few moments to say something, and then looked down, smiling, and tugged her leg toward him to kiss the inside of her knee. She stared at him. He pushed himself up to standing. "I'm going to take a hot shower," he said, arching an eyebrow. "You?"

Zoe brought her fingers to her lips. "I don't know."

Randy leaned over and kissed her. His kiss was possessive, purely sexual, and it plucked the cord inside of her that was almost orgasmic. His stubble scratched her cheek, and she felt a flush spread over her skin.

"If you're still here," he said, standing up, "I'll make you my infamous jambalaya."

"Infamous," she commented.

Randy had his shirt in his hand and swung for his discarded jeans. "It's really bad."

Zoe looked at him. She was grateful that he was trying - and largely succeeding - to make things light, normal again. He seemed to know that's what she needed.

But he would, wouldn't he? He was a shrink, after all.

"Sounds great," she said.

He started walking toward the stairway.

"I may not be here when you get done," she said quietly, almost unsure that she wanted him to hear her. He did, and he looked down at her as he walked up the stairs.

"Your loss," he told her, with a wink, but a trace of tenderness that bordered on disappointment flickered, however briefly, beneath his smiling features. He continued up the stairs.

Zoe's eyes shifted back to the scene around her in the living room. Another swell of guilt threatened to wash over her: Jesus, this was *Derek's fucking*

dad. And she was *married*. Her pussy was sore, and her legs were smeared with drying cum.

But below all of that lurked another thought, one she didn't let emerge in full: she liked it.

She stood up and dressed hurriedly, and, doing her best not to think about any of it, gathered her things and scurried out of the house.

CHAPTER 14

Zoe stared at herself in the mirror, wiping away the steam to look at her body. Her right nipple was red, but it seemed like the kind of thing that could go unnoticed. She was freshly showered, but sensed that her throbbing, sore pussy *must* still bear some traces of Randy's affections. She was still wet, but there was no way of knowing if that was the lingering arousal that he had left in her, making her from time to time feel like she wanted to masturbate it away, or his two loads of cum snaking out of her still.

Either way, she felt sure that Josh, if he came home and tried to have sex tonight, would be bound to notice.

Which left her with a decision to make, and one that had become muddled since she had gone through with it. It had all seemed so clear just before Randy had fucked her: she was doing something to please Josh, and she needed practice at it because she was so nervous. With Randy guiding her thoughts, she had been able to tell herself the right story. That one "practice run" would have ironed out the wrinkles, and then she could surprise Josh with the present of his fantasy.

She had expected to like it: she wasn't delusional enough to think that all along she hadn't felt an attraction to Randy. Looking back on it, maybe she'd told herself lies about that fact, but there was a reason she had gone to Randy.

And that's where the problem was, because now she wasn't sure that she had gone to Randy after finally deciding to fulfill Josh's fantasy, or if she had

decided to fulfill Josh's fantasy *because* Randy was there as an option.

Which had it been? she wondered, smearing a balm over her lower lip and looking at herself.

She really didn't know.

And even if she had expected to like Randy, or the danger of doing this, she hadn't expected to like the part that she did like about it. She hadn't expected her mind to drift, in the car as she drove

home, to thoughts about the *next* dirty thing Randy could do to her.

Would he really put that big cock in her ass? Would she be able to take it? Surely he would want her to suck on it some night, and the thought of getting on her knees and feeling the head of his dick slide against her back palate while she gagged and he pressed on the back of her head, his eyes burning into hers while she looked up at him in total submission... *that* idea got her going so much that she had fallen on the bed when she got home and made herself come within seconds, her belly on the mattress, her fingers soaked, her knuckles grazing the hardened juices in her panties.

Josh had *told* her this is what he wanted. But was *this* - this particular feeling - what he had wanted? Had he wanted her, really, to crave another man's cock, to want him to do really filthy things to her? Had Josh actually wanted her to think about scenarios with Randy that she would never, ever do with Josh? Or even tell him about?

She pressed her lips together.

She should tell him everything now, see what he wanted her to do now that the stakes had somehow changed. She should tell him the entire truth: her intentions, and what had happened afterward.

But looking into her own eyes, as the steam clouded over her face, she knew, deep down inside, that she might not.

That she probably wouldn't.

Eventually, of course.

Just not yet.

CHAPTER 15

Zoe stared at her phone, her thumb hovering over the screen, ready to swipe Randy's message into oblivion. But she failed to move her finger, and a long time passed before she realized that she wasn't even breathing.

I thought about you all night.

The words had made her freeze, cold traveling all over her body. She had felt like she had been caught red-handed doing something, sweat forming at her temples. She had dropped her phone into her purse and hurried to her desk, planning to get straight to work and get caught up on her diary of daily tasks, and its entire backlog, by working as hard as she could all day long with no break, just to keep any thoughts of Randy, or Josh, or any of it, out of her mind.

But that had lasted only a moment, and as her computer slowly powered up, she had the phone back in her hand and was staring at it.

The cold had faded from everywhere but the insides of her cunt, where it throbbed, almost like fear and almost like arousal, some strange in-between that she got right before jumping from a plane.

Sexual, and not.

But it quickly turned to a burning sexual heat, and her thoughts disintegrated into deranged scenarios no matter how hard she tried to keep them from wandering in that direction.

For the first two hours in the office, she got almost nothing done.

Alicia slinked by, and Zoe heard her say something, but her thoughts were so deep in perverse sexual fantasies that she mumbled a reply that made Alicia stop, walk backward, and lean on her cubicle wall. Alicia's eyes moved up and down Zoe's face, scrutinizing, when Zoe looked up.

"You want *a donut*, " Alicia said, her nasal Bronx low and disbelieving, particularly Spanish-tinged. "From the break room."

Zoe floundered. "Uh... yeah."

Alicia stacked the files she was carrying on the partition and folded her arms over them. "Uh-huh. Yeah really? Which kind?"

Zoe shrugged. "Chocolate?"

"You know, you are looking a little bit flushed," Alicia said, but any trace of concern for sick people was edged out by the suspicious tone in her voice.

Zoe turned quickly back to her computer screen, because Alicia's accusatory, predatory stare was becoming too much for her.

"What are you talking about?" she huffed weakly.

"Uh-huh," Alicia tsked. And then she let out a wild laugh and sauntered toward the kitchen. Zoe heard the first part of a sentence that began with "Zoe's hubby got some kind of new sexual technique or something, that girl is..." as the door swung open and shut.

Zoe exhaled. That was typical Alicia, and as long as she thought that Josh was the cause of her flush and distraction, it was...

annoying and embarrassing, but better than the alternative.

Alicia was not exactly Zoe's number one bet for "Most Discreet Coworker."

She was back in a few moments. She set a chocolate donut carefully on Zoe's desk. Then she leaned against it. Zoe kept her eyes determinedly on her screen, attempting to type, and ultimately making up a sentence that had nothing to do with what she was working on, while Alicia burned a hole in the side of her head.

"You pregnant?" Alicia demanded after a few minutes.

"God, no," Zoe said, and then a new kind of terror seized her momentarily, one she hadn't really given much thought. She was on birth control, but that sort of thing failed all the time...

"No," she repeated. She picked up the donut and took a bite.

Zoe hated donuts and all pastries, because she considered them a massive waste of calories and way too sweet. This opinion was one that everyone was aware of.

"No?" Alicia challenged. "You know that you are eating a Krispy Kreme donut."

Zoe chewed and started typing.

"That is like 800 calories you just put in your mouth."

"I'm hungry."

"Dish."

Zoe typed and shook her head.

"You are not even writing anything, *loca*, that's gibberish."

Zoe sighed. She looked up at Alicia, planning to tell her she was too nosy. But, like most people who thought of "saying something" to Alicia, her resolve failed when she saw Alicia's face. It was one of those pretty Latina faces that you could imagine, all too easily, turning into a demonic countenance.

"Nothing is up. I swear. I just... I'm hungry. I had a good night. I am fine."

Alicia's mouth fell open a little, and then, to Zoe's surprise, she snapped it shut, rolled her eyes away from her desk, and followed them back to her side of the office.

Zoe tossed the donut in her trash can and deleted the paragraph she had just typed. Her heart was kicking her violently inside her chest.

I thought about you all night.

Zoe tried to work for another half hour or so, but found herself taking her phone from her purse to stare at the message. It had been joined by another.

I'm thinking about you now.

"Crazy," she whispered.

It was crazy: he sounded obsessive, this was all too far over the line. It wasn't good, that he was thinking of her, and writing to her.

This wasn't their agreement. Though, now that she thought about it, in the heat and intensity of last night's fucking, did they ever discuss the terms of any "agreement?"

Her fingers hovered over the keyboard while her stomach twisted.

Okay, she thought. She needed to shut this down, if it was what she was thinking. She needed to clarify, to reassert herself, to get

back in control of what was happening like she had originally intended to be.

Just checking that you're not getting sappy on me

Her finger hovered, and she sent the message.

She dropped her phone back into her purse. There. That had been the right move. If Randy was getting weird, it would be a good out, actually. She almost hoped that he was, because then she would have a clear exit from this situation... she could just tell Josh...

she had wanted to surprise him with this adventure, but Randy had gotten too involved.

She felt the pulse of her phone, and tried to ignore it, but was digging into her purse again almost maniacally, to her own chagrin, within minutes.

Don't worry. This is purely carnal. As promised. I'll re-phrase: I'm thinking of all the purely carnal things I want to do to you.

Zoe was almost unable to believe that her own mind was making her fingers work, as she watched her thumbs tap out: *Like what?*

She dropped her phone into her purse and laughed nervously.

Like what.

Like what?

What did she really expect, or want Randy to say to that?

But as soon as she thought that thought, another surfaced in her head. *Fuck you like a little whore until you can't walk.*

Zoe closed her eyes and tried to think about anything else.

Her cunt clenched at nothing, and the still-sore tissue inside of her throbbed away.

"Fuck," she whispered, and opened her eyes, fixing them rigidly on the figures in front of her.

CHAPTER 16

"Okay," Pete said, with a sigh that sent a dull throb of annoyance through Josh. He had been working on Stark's team for months now. The tone of the guy's voice had once felt like acid poured through his spinal column, but Josh - or his nervous system -

had learned to react with less enthusiasm. "What do we all think?"

He looked at Josh as he said this, with the kind of pointed, accusatory stare that he gave to no one else. The rest of the group shifted uncomfortably but offered no opinion. They had evidently learned the same lesson from working with Stark: it was best to keep your mouth shut and wait for him to

tell you it had to be scrapped, because that's where all of this "collaboration" was headed, no matter what.

Josh sighed and pulled his fingers together in a two-handed fist, squeezing to remind himself to keep his temper under control.

Pete cut away from his icy stare at Josh and swept his eyes around the room. His cocky, snarky smile was beginning, accompanied by a faint head-bobbing that would grow in size as he worked himself up to the grand speech he was almost certainly about to give.

Josh looked around the room, hiding his hopefulness behind a blank expression. As was to be expected, everyone was staring at their screens or had discovered a tremendous amount of lint on their clothing that needed their undivided attention.

The inhale. The steepled fingers to the lips. "Joshy, bud, " Pete said in a saccharine voice. " *I think... what do I think?*"

Josh pulled his stomach in to clench his respiratory system in a freeze. Pete had to ramble on like this for a few annoying minutes, before dropping the hammer.

"It's not so much that it isn't *good*. I see what you're trying to do.

But really - from my perspective at least, and this is the perspective shared by the client - I don't think it's exactly up to our standards."

"Right." Josh folded his hands over his stomach.

"We're looking for *excellence*. I realize this sort of corner-cutting will save you a lot of time, but Joshy, frankly, that's what it looks like.

It looks like something you did to save you a lot of time."

"It is."

Pete's eyebrows went up. In the periphery of his vision, Josh saw that he had the attention of some of the team members who normally managed to

sleep with their eyes open. Marsha Holland's fingers went straight to the bridge of her nose, which she squeezed with enough force that everyone in the room felt a phantom tingle.

"Sorry - you, you... did you just say you did this to save yourself some time?" Pete's sentence ended with an inhaled, car-salesman's laugh.

"Yeah, Pete," Josh said quietly. In his daydreams, in the car, he called Pete "Petie," but he never managed to get the word out in real life. "It saves me, and you, and everyone else here, a ton of time.

And then when -"

A sharp laugh from Pete interrupted him. "Joshy, we aren't really doing this to *save time*, we're doing it to turn out a -"

"I know that, Pete, but because there's almost always discussion about the renderings -"

" - we're here to make a superior quality product -"

"Yes, and that's why I'm saying, let's use this program to render the 3D to specifications and give the script guys the specifications to make sure -"

Pete shut his laptop. "It isn't going to work."

"It's temporary," Josh said, detesting the pleading tone in his voice. "It's a temporary placeholder, and we can generate them three times as quickly so that we can get working on the -"

Pete stood up. "This is not 'Uncle Bob's Wordpress Web Design,' Joshy. You know that. You contract for TopTier, not BottomRung. I thought you understood the difference. Ribbit doesn't need rotating... I don't know what -"

"They are *temporary* objects that we can render three times as -"

"

"We don't do this quality of work, Joshy. That's it."

"Pete, could you *just* do me a favor and *listen to what I am fucking saying?*"

The silence that fell over the room was sudden, timed, as if by the hand of God, to coincide with an equally sudden stoppage of the ventilation system, leaving an eerie absence of sound throbbing in their ears. Everyone was wide-awake, pupils dilated, mouths open, staring straight ahead.

Pete was looking at Josh, who had not closed his own mouth.

He glared for a few tense moments, then nodded, and the horrible smirk Josh so desired to slap off his face came crawling back to the corners of his mouth. He continued to nod quietly, like someone who has just won a strategy game, as he unplugged his laptop and picked it up with two fingers.

He held it like a file folder, vertically, and jabbed the corner of it in Josh's direction. "No on the program. Do it the way you've been asked to do it, and, Joshy, if it's too much work for you, then I'm happy to call in for a replacement."

His expression telegraphed an addendum: *I'd be thrilled, actually. As you know.*

Josh looked down at the table. He was already halfway to living out his dream: telling Pete to fuck off, quitting, calling him a fucking little brat-ass, no-talent tyrant, and then walking out the door.

But in the field of his vision, superimposed over the black top, the figures of his mortgage took shape, as real as if a piece of paper were in front of him. And then, he thought of Zoe's face, an expression of disappointment bleeding through her attempt to look supportive: *that* would be the expression that she would stab him through the heart with repeatedly if he had to go home and tell her he'd lost his current contract, and probably his position at TopTier.

"Fine," Josh said, through clenched teeth.

"I need that before SanFran goes home today, buddy. Okay?"

Great. Let's all get back to work."

Pete strode out of the meeting room. The others hurried to follow suit, saying nothing.

"I thought it was a good idea," Jim Reid said, as quietly as possible. "I could have worked with it."

"Sweet," Josh told him. "Thanks for your support, then."

Josh stuffed his laptop into his backpack. When he looked up, Jim was looking at him. "Gonna give you piece of advice about Pete

Stark," he said coolly. "That guy is seriously - actually - sucking somebody's cock, way up the ladder. So, you want to pick a fight with him, be my fucking guest. I've seen it before and you know what? None of those guys work for TopTier anymore. They're making stay-at-home mom blogs and are maximizing revenue by attracting ads for acrylic paint and diapers. They live in Idaho. Just get this project finished and hopefully you don't run across the guy again."

Josh ground his teeth together. Jim was right; he was always right. Everyone knew that Pete Stark got away with murder, and everyone suspected he had to be either sucking cock or blackmailing someone to do that, because he was a bad designer and a terrible manager - it wasn't merit that kept that smug smile on his project-manager-lips.

Josh zipped up his backpack violently. "It's gonna take me all fucking night to get that done."

"I know," Jim said. He put a hand on Josh's shoulder.

"I haven't seen my wife in two weeks."

Jim shrugged. "It's a bitch."

Jim was thirty-five, which in this echelon of web design made him a dinosaur. Jim would have made a great project manager, but as far as Josh knew, he had never been put in charge. Whether this was the reason for his cynicism and dedication to mediocrity, or the other way around, was anybody's guess.

Jim started to walk out. Josh put his hand to his forehead and wiped his face. Then he headed to his workspace, wondering if Pete was, at that very moment, pulling levers to get him fired.

Because if he was, then it wasn't worth working on this project until ten.

He sat down and opened his laptop, angling it so that he could look over the edge of it and see Pete. Pete worked at the far end of the large, open-concept area that TopTier acquired for projects like this one, where they expected maximum cooperation and perfect quality in record speed.

Pete, however, had enclosed himself in the small private meeting room, with the shades up. It seemed as if he wanted Josh to know that he was on the phone, having a conversation he didn't want Josh to hear.

Josh's stomach turned with dread, and he waited a few moments, thinking over his options, as he always did after any interaction with Pete.

But those had always been a little different, because he had never said anything quite so aggressive before. TopTier had pretty strict communications policies, and Josh was fairly sure he'd run afoul of them in there. Normally, this wasn't a big deal: everyone got upset and threw a fit at least once or twice in the middle of a project.

But not everyone was Pete Stark, and not everyone had some kind of personal vendetta with Josh.

His eyes moved back to his screen. The end of the day in San Fran was 10pm here. It wasn't, as usual, an *impossible* task.

Just one that would put him home at ten-thirty.

Again.

He fished his phone from his pocket and started to type a message to Zoe.

I'm going to be late. AGAIN. I'm sorry.

But something made his thumb hover over the send icon instead of pressing it. Maybe he could finish sooner, if he got lucky or inspired. It was such a long shot that he knew it was fantasy even as he slipped his phone back into his pocket, but he just didn't feel like sending Zoe yet another text about being late.

Not yet.

Later.

*

"It's nine-thirty."

Jim's voice had been saying something for a long time, like a drone in the distance, when the words finally reached Josh's consciousness and collided with their meanings and his sense of place and time.

He threw his headphones, which had ceased piping in music long ago, and squinted in the direction of a sad analog clock that hung slightly off-center above a white board. "What?" he said, even

though he had heard him perfectly and was already starting to panic.

"Fuck. Fuck!" He fished his phone from his pocket. As he was doing this, he realized he'd had to pee for a long time, and the ache was spreading out in his lower back. His kidneys were going to burst.

Phone in hand, fingers swiping, he stumbled out of his chair, grabbing Jim by the arm, mumbling a thank you, and "I gotta pee,"

and "fuck," almost simultaneously, so the resulting sentence was a garbled word salad.

Jim understood, as did anyone who worked with Josh and had seen him zone out while he worked. Jim leaned on the edge of the table and peered at Josh's screen as Josh hurried down the hall.

Nine-thirty? Fuck. He slammed himself into a stall and sat down on it so he could use his phone at the same time. There was a string of messages from Zoe.

Do you think you'll make it home tonight?

Hello? Are you zoned out?

I'm asking because some of the girls want to do happy hour.

If I don't hear from you by five I'm going with them.

Okay. I'm going out. See you... around.

Hope work isn't terrible. I love you xoxoxoxo

The final message had been sent half an hour after the next most recent. Like an afterthought. The timestamp stung him a little, but he tried to be fair: Zoe couldn't be expected to sit around waiting for him to answer her. Especially when he almost never came home in time to do anything with her.

The memory of Zoe returning from Teambuilding Tuesday with Randy percolated into his thoughts, as it often did, and the pang of jealousy reverberated in his chest while his perverse arousal kicked around inside his groin.

He looked at his messages from Zoe. Then he closed his eyes.

He was tired, he was under stress: Zoe wouldn't lie to him about what she was doing.

He hoped.

The little demon that lived with his dick, though, whispered a thought at the same time:

You also hope she is lying.

He wrapped it up in the bathroom, washing his hands quickly.

He didn't have time to think about this shit - he needed to get Pete his beloved, high-quality renderings, which he would promptly shit all over and ask to be "modified slightly," because they "weren't exactly what he had in mind."

He hurried back to his desk and got to work. But the little demon never stopped whispering at him, or throwing clouds of dust into his vision, which turned into images, however fleeting, of his wife and Randy, laughing together at the bar. Or his wife and Randy, fucking in a bathroom stall.

*

Randy's hands, which were cupping her breasts and rolling her nipples into reddened balls, moved down to her waist when her body went rigid.

Her ring tone for Josh, unmistakable, had slammed the cold, paralyzing fear of being caught right into her face. She had been sitting on Randy's lap, his prick pressing hard against the root of her clit, his stubble grazing her back along with his lips as he whispered commands to her, told her to squeeze his cock and ride him harder and milk his cum into her tight little pussy. His words, like his skilled hands and his thick cock, had been driving her wild. They were on his bed, and a full-length mirror in the corner of the room gave her a glimpse of herself: her wild hair, Randy's hands on her tits, and the thick pink shaft that moved stickily inside of her with every panting rock of her body.

"Oh God," she said, when she heard the phone.

Randy pulled her down, settling her buttocks on his abdomen.

"Don't stop, keep riding my cock," he hissed.

"It's Josh," she said, leaning back against him. His hands pushed her hips down hard, until her slippery cunt was being crushed against him and her legs began to ache from being spread so wide. Her pussy throbbed around his dick and she moved against

him, in spite of her phone call. She couldn't help it, it felt so good, and her pussy ached from three orgasms and the many different directions that Randy's cock had entered her body. Now that she was sore, fucked-out, and full of slippery cum, he was making her work hard and fuck him like a whore. It was humiliating. But she loved it.

"He never calls me," she whispered, in a shaky stammer.

"What... if... he was... he was... looking for me..."

"Answer it," Randy growled against her back. His hands pushed her body against his groin. The message was clear: answer it while my cock is inside of you.

"Randy..."

"He'll love it. He'll love it when you tell him about it later. Trust me."

"I can't reach it," she complained. The complaint was partly about his demands, partly that she didn't want to feel Randy's cock slide from inside of her.

Randy pushed up, taking her with him, and rose to his knees.

She fell forward onto the bed, and he pushed her forward toward the edge, where she could reach for her phone, which had spun out on the floor when she had dropped her purse. He kept pushing until she was hanging over the edge of the bed, still impaled on his cock. "Get it. Answer him."

"Randy," she said, looking back at him. She met his cool stare, a stare he only wore when he was fucking her. It was the kind of look that she couldn't argue with. She just did what he said, whatever it was. She could hardly

believe what she'd already done, and what she was going to do, that she *was* doing just what he asked.

Shaking, she swept the call open and placed the phone next to her ear. Her skin was damp and it nearly slid from her fingers.

"Josh?" she said, mustering the most regular-sounding voice that she could.

This definitely wasn't the right moment to talk to him about what she had done.

Randy pushed her and pulled her, handling her like a blow-up doll, moving her into a position where he could drive his cock into her deeply, slowly. Now that she was hanging over the bed, pushing up

on one arm to hold herself away from the floor, his cock was rubbing against new and unexpected places. She felt a whimper gathering in her throat and closed her eyes to try and stifle it. In the corner of her eye she saw the whole scene in the mirror, and it made a sickening wave of guilt wash over her.

"Honey," she heard Josh say. "I'm sorry, I'm sorry I didn't get back to you, Pete dropped all this stuff on me last minute and I just got to churning, zoned out, you know how it is... are you... are you out? Or are you home?"

She felt a warm drop of spit land between her buttcheeks. She closed her eyes. This was all so *wrong*, so very, very *wrong*. She looked toward the mirror when she opened her eyes, to see her sluttiness in its complete form.

She couldn't take her eyes away from it.

Out.

Out?

The seconds were ticking by, she was holding her breath as Randy's finger moved in circles around her asshole, teasing her, making her thrash from the waist down against his cock. "Um," she said. "I, yeah, I'm still out..."

"Where'd you go? I can try to stop by."

Randy's finger drew some of the slop from her pussy up to her eyelet and then pushed inside of her. He had already loosened her up, many times, all evening long, so he slipped into her ass with ease, and she had learned to push out, so that no sharp pain marred the sensation in her ass.

"Mm..mmm... maybe that's, uh, you know, we're... all the way in the Center. Some place, uh, I don't know. I'm... are you home?"

Randy started to finger fuck her ass, and her arm was getting sore, and she was being a horrible little slut.

"You okay?"

"Yeah, why?"

"You sound... I don't know. Out of breath."

Randy swirled his finger around the rim of her stretched ass.

Another hot glob of spit spilled directly into the hole, sinking inside of her, plunging in with his finger.

"Zoe?"

"I was, uh.. dancing," she said. "I'm just... out of breath."

She squirmed as Randy played with her ass. He was rocking inside of her pussy, his shaft squeezing the thin flesh between his cock and invading finger. He was going to work her up to taking his cock in the ass, and to her surprise, she loved the idea.

There was a long pause on the other end of the line. Randy's cock slid slowly in and out of her, and her eyes went wide as a sharp pain announced the entrance of two fingers into her ass. She felt herself clench, and then pushed out, as he had instructed, and the pain faded to a dull ache, diving in slowly, filling her up.

A noise left her mouth.

"Zoe?" Josh asked.

Her eyes flew open.

"Sorry," she said, her breath leaving her in a throaty huff. "I'm just... distracted. I can barely hear you. I have to, uh, get back... get back inside. I'll be home soon. Like an hour, okay?"

In the pause that ensued, her pussy slurped as Randy slid his cock out of her to the very tip. Her heart turned to ice: would Josh hear that? Would he know what it was? What was she *doing*?

"Okay," Josh said uncertainly. "I'll wait up for you -"

"No! No, uh no, no..." her voice ended in a whine, because Randy had begun to finger-fuck her with two fingers in the ass, and the pain was as sweet as it was intolerable. "I... don't do that," she said hoarsely. "Don't... I'll be home, I mean, I'm really tired. I'll... see you in... the morning..."

Another long pause, while the tip of Randy's cock teased her pussy and his fingers plunged in and out of her ass. Her mouth fell open: she could feel a scream building in her chest, the tidal wave of another orgasm rising up inside of her. If Randy rubbed her clit, she would lose herself.

"Okay," Josh said, after what seemed like an eternity. She could tell he didn't think it was okay, and she felt a pang of guilt before he added, "I'll see you in the morning, then. I guess. But I might still be up. So... I love you."

"I love you," Zoe said. When she did, Randy's fingers curled upward, toward her tail bone, and almost lifted her, as he thrust himself to the hilt into her pussy. She swept her fingers over her

screen as quickly as she could to end the call and dropped the phone on the floor as Randy jerked her up and onto his lap.

His fingers were still in her ass, and he had moved his hand to be cupping her by the tail bone, fingers clawing inside of her, pinching her flesh between his fingers and the thumb he held against the valley between her cheeks. He lifted her and lowered her, forcing her to stroke his cock with her cunt as she rose up and then he let her sink again.

"Oh!" Zoe screamed. "Randy... oh!"

"Now ride my cock again. Make yourself come."

She did as he asked, raising herself up and letting herself fall, his minimally lubricated fingers scraping at her flesh as she rose, his cock sloshing inside her pussy. Her thighs began to burn, and she was grunting and rutting, she realized, like a pig. But she couldn't stop, she needed to feel that sweet, mind-altering release...

At last, she went over the edge, and was gripped so forcefully for a few moments that she could not breathe or make any sound.

Her vision blurred, and her cunt and ass spasmed, sucking at Randy's cock and his fingers, pulling them inside even more deeply.

"Keep going," Randy encouraged. "Keep it up, keep fucking me."

"Ooooh," she cried. "I can't, I can't Randy, my pussy is so sore..."

"Good. Keep going until you get filled up with another load of cum."

She was bouncing slowly, obeying him, even though each movement was pure torture, rubbing her over-sensitive body into a pleasure too intense to handle. "I...can't, I can't take it, please, Randy, I... can't..." she slumped against his chest.

His mouth was next to her ear when he spoke next, and the stubble near his lips grazed the lobe, making her shiver but with such amplification that her thighs twitched. "Do it, little girl. If I have to do it, I'm going to put it in your ass. You ready for that?"

Zoe let out a howl. She wasn't ready for that, but she was ready for the thought of it. "I can't, Randy," she whispered. "Please."

"Start fucking, little girl," he said, and she felt a smile on his lips.

His free hand slid between her legs and into her soaked slit, crushing her swollen clit. She screeched and tried to pull her legs together and wriggle away, but Randy was too quick for her. He must have anticipated her move, because he expertly flipped his heavy calves over hers and pinned them to the bed. She was trapped, his big cock pushing out against the root of her clit, his fingers deep in her ass and wiggling, and his other hand abusing her clit and making her jerk against him violently - to no avail.

"Stop, stop, Randy, please, I can't... I... can't..."

But just as his relentless stroking reached an unbearable high, and she heard herself making unintelligible sounds, arousal began to creep back into her body. She tried to twist and wriggle free of him, but she could not. "Oh God," she panted, whimpering. "Randy, oh God, oh God..." her breath caught in the back of her throat and she tipped her head forward, her hair hanging into her face. She had her hands on his thighs and was digging her fingers into his flesh.

"Do it," Randy commanded. "Ride my cock and make me come."

She whimpered again. But she was already rocking her hips, obeying him.

"That's it," he said. His fingers left her cunt and he leaned back on that arm, forcing his cock into new places, his chest leaning away from her. He pushed up with his fingers to prompt her to go.

And so, head hanging, partly in shame, partly in exhaustion, partly in a filthily erotic humiliation, she rode his cock.

"That's good, that feels good, Zoe. You're being a good little slut, honey. My little slut. Keep going."

She was starting to feel another orgasm brewing. She feared it: each one had attacked her more violently. But there was no stopping the craving that was coming for her, that made her do whatever Randy told her to do. She looked at the mirror and saw her shining skin and damp, messy hair, heard the squishing of her pussy, and then began to climb toward the peak of her own pleasure, even though her thighs were burning and her ass was being rubbed raw...

But suddenly she was careening forward, falling onto her hands and knees, and Randy was slamming into her, pulling upward with his fingers in her ass, lifting her up.

She was moaning, kicking with her legs, trying to get her knees onto the bed, but Randy was lifting her like a flesh puppet, and there was nothing to do but let him suspend her and fuck his cum inside of her while he did.

He spluttered and jerked, three waves of cum making his body jerk as he spurted into her pussy. Then he let her knees fall to the bed and moved his fingers languidly in her ass. She looked at the mirror and saw him staring at her as he fucked her.

She had been so close. She pushed against him, and tried to move, but he gripped her with his other hand and held her still against his groin.

"You want to come again," he remarked, his fingers scraping inside of her ass.

She whimpered into the bed.

"Pull your hair up," he said. "Push it up, like that, there." He helped her push her hair above her head, exposing her neck and the side of her face.

"That's good," he said, still staring at her body. "That's beautiful."

His fingers were still fucking her ass, and she squirmed and moaned, and started to push herself up to hands and knees. "Stay like that," he growled.

He finger-fucked her ass for a long time, staring down at her.

Zoe had a view of her own face, her submissive posture, in the mirror. She could hear herself whimper and mewl as Randy hooked his fingers in every direction, stretching her and pulling her, moving his fingers slow and fast. He watched her body and his own work as he pulled her anus around like taffy in a machine, with changes of direction and jerks that pulled her open and made her squeal.

Her pussy was dripping, his cum and her own juices pouring below her, some of it snaking down her thighs. She was transfixed by the image in the mirror, by her own lack of agency, by the idea that Josh might see the same thing someday.

"You want to come?" Randy asked at last. "Hmm? You want me to make you come?"

She mewled and nodded, not sure she could do anything else.

"Show me. Be a good girl. Get that hand up here." He reached for her right arm and pulled her hand toward him, resting her wrist on her lower back. "I want to watch you finger-fuck your own ass," he said.

She turned her head and tried to look up at him. He withdrew his fingers and his cock flopped out of her pussy. He pushed her hand between her legs as he rested on his calves. He pulled her hand down to her soaked pussy and shook her fingers around in the slurping folds, before guiding her back to cup her ass, her fingertips on her stretched anus. "Do it," he said. "Fuck your ass with your fingers. I want to watch it."

She moaned and put her face in the bedding. It was soaked: she was sweating from head to toe. She turned her head to face the mirror again, and saw herself in the mirror, hand over her back, ass up in the air, fingers dipping into her anus...

It didn't seem like she was looking at herself. She pushed her cum-coated fingers into her ass. It was easy: Randy's fingers were large, and he had tugged her asshole around so much that her own slender fingers barely had to stretch it.

"Now fuck yourself," Randy repeated.

She plunged her fingers in and out of her ass. Randy was leaning back on his calves, staring at her fingers. His cock, which had never really softened completely, was twitching to life, erect between his legs. She could see it in the mirror.

She howled, and tears formed in her eyes. "Randy, I can't, I can't take any more -"

"Just keep going, you're being such a filthy little slut, be a good girl. That's it. Just a little bit more and I'll make you come. You want that don't you?"

"Yes," she whimpered.

"Show me. Show me how much you want it."

Zoe plunged her fingers into her ass more quickly, moaning, her eyes closed to block out the torturous pleasure, then opening to watch herself behave like a porn star.

At last, she felt the smooth tip of Randy's cock, hotter even than her own fevered flesh, slipping into the folds of her dripping cunt.

"Don't stop," he said, when her fingers paused because her attention was sucked away to the head of his cock.

She could hear the sounds that she was making but could not believe they were her own. Whimpering, begging in grunts and moans, she was humiliated by the sound of herself but unable to stop. She could hear her fingers and the sticky spluttering they made as they plunged into her hole.

All the while, Randy's cock was nearing her clit. Her legs began to tremble in anticipation, almost as if she could feel the pleasure of his touch before it reached her.

He rubbed his cock slowly over her clit. Dull pleasure was spiked by the fleeting moments when he grazed the raw bundle of nerves on the face of it, or pressed hard against it, making her hard nub squirm and wriggle away.

The pleasure was always dashing away, failing again and again to crest, swelling and then disappearing like a misjudged ocean wave. "Oh God," she heard herself say.

"Keep it up, be a good little slut," Randy coaxed. "You feel how silky and hot your ass is, that's why I want to fuck you there."

She whimpered again, as he stroked her clit with a rhythm, taking her close to the edge.

"Randy, please," she begged, her voice barely above a whisper, ragged like a sob. "Please. I can't... I have to..."

He pushed her fingers deep into her ass and held her hand against her backside before he began to rub his cock against her clit in earnest. "I want you to feel that, feel it when you come. That's why I want to be in your ass when I make you come, that's why you're going to be a good girl."

She was already going over the edge, so his words fell over but would not be processed until later. "Oh my -" she started to say, but when she came this time it knocked the wind out of her. Her ass squeezed and massaged her fingers, her pussy squelched, her thighs turned to mush. Her body was rock hard for a screaming moment, and then she felt as if she had been turned to liquid, and she melted into the bed.

Randy fucked her after that, but it was a blur and she could barely do anything but lie there, wet with sweat and cum and her

own juices. Her hand fell out of her ass, Randy let it flop to the side of her body. She watched as he grasped her hips and hammered into her, for a very long time, but she was so spent she could only lie there and take more of him until he came.

He stayed inside of her when he was done, looking down at her body, running his hands over her skin. He squeezed her ass and then slowly receded from her pussy. Hot liquid gushed down her thighs. Her pussy ached, and she was almost asleep. She felt herself roll over, felt him drag

her along the bed so that she could lie out, felt his fingers on her body, caressing her...

When she opened her eyes, the first thing she saw was the mirror. The bedsheets were scattered around her, clumped into a landscape of debauchery. She saw Randy's skin intermingled in the white waves, and the whole sordid evening came back to her in a rush.

Now that the inebriation of sex had worn off, she was horrified.

And then, as she looked around the room, her horror deepened.

Behind the opaque curtains over the windows she hadn't even noticed, the sky was a very dark, but very unmissable, shade of blue.

"Fuck," she almost yelled, sitting up. Her pussy and her ass were achy with the use Randy had gotten from them, and juices spilled out beneath her. Shame coursed through her, and then a desire to act: she had told Josh she would be home in an hour, probably hours ago.

Randy didn't stir. She looked at him and realized she didn't want him to. She moved as quietly as she could, gathering her clothing and her purse, searching in the shadows at the foot of the bed for her phone. With everything in her hands, she crept out of the bedroom and down the hallway before pausing to hurriedly put on her skirt, her bra, and her blouse.

She didn't have her panties, and that was bad, because cum was snaking down her thighs, but she didn't dare go back into the room for them. She didn't want Randy to wake up. She didn't want to face him right now.

As she walked down the stairs, all the places that Randy had stretched and pumped full of cum sent varying levels of discomfort

back to her. There was a pleasantness to it, but in her state of panic about being so late getting back to Josh, the sensations came to her as aches and pains. A reminder of what a raging slut she had been.

Her stomach was twisting, cold and fearful. Outside, the very first birds of the day were starting to chirp loudly. Sprinklers had come on up and down the street. It was the coldest time of day and she shivered.

She prayed that her keys had not fallen out of her purse.

Shaking, she got into the car and started it. A light fog was streaked across the dash.

She pulled out her phone while she waited for the defrost to work.

4:38.

"Fuck. Fuck, fuck, fuck."

She swept through her calls, trying to see when she had spoken to Josh.

11:27pm.

He had called her three times after that - but not after 2am.

"Oh God," she said. She pushed her hair from her face and looked in the rear-view mirror. Her lips were puffy, her light mascara smudged beneath her eyes, a faded brown stain trickling down her right cheek. Her hair was tangled and frizzy from getting wet with sweat and pushed around by Randy, then drying while she slept in a pool of cum.

She could feel the cum dried to her thighs: even if she managed to make an excuse to Josh about coming home so late (she could say she had closed down the club, and not thought to call, for example. That would put her out on the street by four, driving home for an hour, and home about the same time she would get there now.

But why, why would she not have called Josh?)

The thing was, that Zoe was notoriously unreliable about coming home when she went out. This would not be the first time she stayed out much later than she said she would, not the first time they would have had a fight

about her not calling him to say she was okay, at least, and Josh being worried, and her promising not to be so thoughtless again.

It had happened before.

It wasn't good, but it was a lot better than being fucked by Randy so hard that she fell asleep.

She watched the fog on the windshield slowly recede toward the top, exasperation gripping her. What would she tell him?

She didn't know. She no longer knew what she was doing.

Sure, this had begun as one thing, but it had turned into something completely different. *Why* had she let Randy talk her into this crazy plan? Why had she come back for a second time, why had she lost all control? Why had she done any of this? What if Josh didn't actually want this, what if she had made a terrible mistake? And what if she had crossed the line tonight?

Because she had, she knew. She hadn't meant to. That first night with Randy, this had all made sense. She really hadn't believed that she could go through with it unless she had that first time out of the way.

"Oh God," she said helplessly.

Now, what to do?

She looked at the clock on her dashboard. 4:40.

She put the car in gear, and, hunkering over the steering wheel, began to drive home. Because as crazy as her "story" was, and as much as she thought she might *not* tell it, and that she might come clean to Josh that very morning - she didn't want the option to get taken away just because she sat in her car indecisively.

The drive home was ten minutes long. Maybe something would occur to her - the perfect thing to say, the perfect excuse, the best compromise, some idea of what the fuck she was doing - and everything would be fine.

CHAPTER 17

Nothing occurred to her. Her thoughts would not remain on track, as much as she wanted them to. They dissolved, each and every time she tried to right them, into a sleazy, filthy, shameful, and shamefully arousing, montage of all the things she'd done with Randy.

She drove the last half-block with her lights out. It was sneaky, and it felt terrible, but if she was honest with herself, there was a hope brewing in her heart that Josh would have fallen asleep, and she would be able to sneak in, take a shower, and pretend like she had been home all along and was just getting up for work. She would claim to need to be in early, dash out the door, and come back after Josh had gone to work himself.

Of course that was a crazy plan, she admonished herself. And deceitful, and shameless. But she just needed to sleep for a moment, to think for a moment, to clarify what it was she was going to tell Josh when she explained how her plan had become... this.

She reached behind her seat and found a box of tissues she had tossed back there, was grateful there was still a handful in the box, and wiped between her legs. She stuffed the tissue back in the box and made a solemn mental note not to forget about it - a vague tableau of horrors flitted through her thoughts - and stepped out of the car in her bare feet, holding her shoes.

The house was quiet. She expected, at each turn and stage of her progression to the bedroom, to be confronted by Josh as if it were a movie: a light clicking on, her husband staring at her, her having no explanation but the truth.

Or her lie.

Which one would she tell, if light suddenly flooded one of these rooms and she met Josh's eyes?

She reminded herself, standing outside the partially cracked door to the bedroom, that Josh had given her permission to pursue a sexual encounter with Randy. To feel him out. He had wanted her to

do what she had done, just maybe not like this. The cheating was not really cheating so much as a foul, one she could explain to Josh, if she could just get away with it for tonight and get some sleep.

The door to the master bath had a second door, which let out into the hallway. If it was unlocked, and if Josh was still asleep, she could go into the bathroom, undress and stash her clothes, turn on the water and the light, and pretend to have been there all along.

Or rather, wait to see if Josh didn't know any different.

Guilt gripped her again. Her eyes got wet. This was a mess, and she hated it, and she didn't want to do any of this, but the thought of coming clean right now was too much for her. She had to try. She needed to sleep and get her story just right. True, but phrased so that Josh would understand what had happened.

She pushed on the bedroom door and listened. There was no movement, not a sound at all from the bedroom. Surely, if Josh wasn't asleep, he would have stirred? She pushed a little further and strained to see the bed, but could not.

She decided to go for it. She turned the handle of the hallway bathroom door slowly, and squeezed her eyes, heart pounding, for the first half turn, expecting to feel the hard push-back of the locked door. But it kept turning, and so she slipped into the dark bathroom.

She tried to look through the mirror at the bed, but it was too dark. She didn't see movement, so that was a good sign.

Hurriedly, her heart pounding and her body shaking with nerves, she undressed and stashed her clothes at the bottom of the hamper.

She opened the shower door, stared into the murky image in the mirror and saw nothing moving, and so took a deep breath. With one hand on the shower handle and one on the light, she flipped them at the same time and jumped into the shower.

The first seconds of ice-cold water were almost unbearable, but she remained in the stream and didn't scream. Now that the light was on, it was even harder to see the dark interior of the bedroom in the mirror, but the shape of Josh's body on the bed didn't move.

The fear and adrenaline in her bloodstream, fed by this news, began to turn into a high. Excitement at getting away with something, relief at not being caught, and - though she hated to admit it - a thrill, all started to drown out what she had been feeling before.

"I didn't want to wake you up," she was going to tell him, about why she hadn't called.

It was weak, it was crazy, it would start a fight, but it would get her off the hook for just long enough to get some sleep and think of a plan.

She tipped her head under the water, now warming, and closed her eyes. Maybe she had bought herself some time to think about what to tell Josh.

With her eyes closed, she dumped a copious amount of soap into her hands and lathered herself up. She washed herself down, and then opened her eyes to look into the bedroom - still perfectly quiet, no movement - before rubbing her fingers through the folds of her pussy and her ass, making sure that any trace of Randy would disappear. Her folds were still slick and it was hard to get rid of it all.

Her pussy was sore and her clit still so sensitive that when she brushed over it made her muscles jerk.

Guilt started to creep in again. She hurried to finish the shower before he woke up, so that she could be in the closet getting dressed and he wouldn't try to have sex with her. She was sure that he would realize what she had done if he pushed into her stretched cunt, and she was too sore to endure it.

She turned off the water and reached for a towel.

What would she do if she really had started her day and Josh was asleep?

"Hey, sleepy-head," she said loudly, walking into the bedroom, her eyes on Josh's figure. "You better get going if -"

She stopped dead in her tracks a few feet into the bedroom.

Josh's body, which had been growing strangely small and contorted as she neared it, had evaporated. In its place - and how she had ever thought it was anything else - was a crumpled duvet cover, perhaps the size of a small child at the most.

"Josh?" she said quietly. Her mind, tired, running on fear of getting caught and the thrill of not getting caught, on whatever it was that Randy had made course through her blood, was not able to process what she was seeing immediately.

"Josh?" she repeated. Now her voice sounded panicked, and her feelings came along for the ride. She spun around, looked all

over the room, and could not figure out what she was seeing.

The house, dark and empty, suddenly seemed like something out of a horror movie to her. Her heart leaped into her throat, she wondered where a weapon was. "Josh!" she said sharply. She threw open the door to the bedroom.

As so often happened with Zoe, fear of this kind - the kind that was not something she had control over, the kind of fear that crawled out of some very reptilian part of her mind, the fear of things she knew nothing about - solidified into a wild rage in less than a second.

"Josh what the fuck?!" she hollered, creeping down the hall.

"This isn't funny!"

She was moving with her hands in front of her as though it were pitch black, even though by now the sky was almost blue and the windows of the other rooms were letting in plenty of light to see.

Gray shadows lurked everywhere, and they all seemed to be moving at once. "Josh!" she repeated, her voice strangled like a scolding mother's.

Flying through her head were thoughts, all of them incomplete: Josh was doing this to teach her a lesson. He'd seen her creep in and watched her deceitful display. She had made everything worse.

He had been murdered and she had been out fucking her brains out.

"Josh!"

She began to move quickly, angrily, irrationally mad and scared.

She flipped on the lights and started yelling. "Josh whatever the hell you're doing it's not funny!"

But Josh was nowhere. The lights flooded the kitchen and the house was still empty.

"Josh what the -?!"

On the counter, a note.

Zoe approached it trembling.

Coffee's ready to go. Love you

She stared at it, her mouth open, her face, she knew without seeing it, crumpled into an expression of horror.

"What?" she said at last, to the empty room.

Her purse was on the kitchen floor, where she had set it, carefully and quietly, upon entering the house. She dug into it and found her phone.

Messages.

Why hadn't she checked her messages? She had been in such a hurry to see what time she had spoken to Josh, in such a hurry to try and think of what

she, Zoe the liar could do and say, that she had not even registered the messages on her phone. She had forgotten they even existed.

No messages on her voicemail.

One text message.

Okay... well, I tried calling you and I guess you lost track of time.

So text me when you get this so I know you're okay. I'm having a hard time sleeping, thinking, Pete's giving me nightmares. I'm going to try to get some work done at Reggie's.

And then, ten minutes later, like an afterthought: *CALL ME WHEN YOU GET THIS party animal*

She stared at the message.

The feelings that began to crawl through her now were strangely dark. The message should have made her feel relief: she was off the hook. She could tell him her phone died, that she got home not much later than Josh had left for Reggie's.

But something about it didn't sit right with her. Was it her own guilt? Had she wanted to get caught, to have to come clean about what she was doing and the fact that it had gotten outside of her control? Was she disappointed that she was free to lie again?

Why would that be?

She set the phone down on the table, and her eyes blurred over with tears.

Was it because she was afraid that now, given the chance to continue what she had started with Randy, that she was going to?

Randy, she realized now, had been a mistake.

She wished that she could just make him disappear. Take back everything she'd done.

And for a moment it had seemed as if that was impossible, and she would have to own up to her mistakes, untangle herself from this web.

She closed her eyes, and realized she was very tired.

She trudged back to the bedroom and fell onto the bed. She would make this decision after some sleep. She set her alarm for half an hour.

She had only to close her eyes to fall asleep, in spite of the turmoil of her thoughts.

CHAPTER 18

Josh "slept" in the TopTier office rental, in the only room with a closing door other than the room Pete Stark had claimed as his

"office," even though no one was supposed to have as much as an assigned workspace. He was crammed between a wall and an uncomfortable table, because the room was impossibly small and cramped with even one person in it. It was for sensitive phone calls and interviews. He wondered if the idea was to make people hurry up and finish so they could stretch their legs.

He didn't so much sleep as stare at the teak laminate floor and watch it slowly warm in the sunlight. His phone was face-down on the table, set to vibrate, but it didn't ring.

He had no idea if Zoe was home by now, and a very large part of him wanted to call her and scream into her voicemail, or go home and wait for her to return. He pictured himself sitting in the dark, turning on the light when she crept into the house, like an assassin in a movie.

He hadn't known what to do. This wasn't the kind of "not knowing" that comes with not knowing what to have for lunch, or whether to take a new job, or buy a certain house, or even marry a certain girl. This was the kind of free-falling, floating off into outer space, facing a mushroom-cloud paralysis that defied any sort of description.

After he jerked off, which he did without thinking about, because his cock had been so painfully hard that the idea of jerking off didn't even reach his consciousness until it was over, and his cum was sinking into his pants, and he was alone in the dark with a picture of his wife's smiling face hovering over the text: *Call Ended 1:13:20*

He would never be able to extract what he had heard from his mind, or the images that it had conjured. The sound of Zoe moaning, squealing, whining and begging, the filthiness of her pleading. The knowledge that some other man, almost certainly Randy, was

making her come over and over again, and if the layer of sounds beneath her voice and his was any indication, it was done with wet, spluttering penetrations of everything but Zoe's mouth.

After he jerked off he sat, his cum getting cold, and stared at the phone, with nothing at all occurring to him for many minutes.

She had lied to him. She had done it on purpose. She had known this was actually what he wanted and had orchestrated it for him. She had betrayed him. She had been fucking Randy all along and was just going to use his desires as an excuse. She had been revolted by his fantasy and was teaching him a lesson. She was leaving him - that was the last he would ever hear from her. It was a carefully orchestrated vignette for his pleasure. It wasn't.

On and on the thoughts went, in circles, never-ending circles and blind alleys of loathing. Loathing of himself, of Zoe, of Randy. Of the fact that even as he sat there, feeling like his heart had been ripped out, he was also aroused. His cock was twitching back to life, Zoe's filthy moans were creeping back into his thoughts.

At some point, he was sure he was going to vomit. It came in waves, and then it ebbed. It was like a bad - the only - trip he had taken with some friends who had assured him mushrooms would be fun. They were, and then they weren't, and that was the hell he lived in for an hour while he sat, the cum now dry, his cock now hard again, thinking no complete thought and having no complete feeling.

He didn't know why he had decided on the tack he took. He called her back, and she didn't answer. What would he have said to her, if she had answered, panting, telling him she was just now on her way home? Or what if she had panted, "Did you like that?"

He was glad she didn't answer. He didn't leave a message.

Why had he decided to do what he did? He didn't know.

He knew that he could have diffused everything by making the story become what he wanted it to be. *That was hot*, he could have told her. *I like the twist you put on it. Really had me going for a minute.*

And then, Zoe would have nothing to say but, "Oh good, so glad you liked it." Whether it had been a mistake, a moment of getting caught, or whether it had been her plan all along.

The fantasy would become the exact reality he wanted it to.

He would never know the difference.

In the end, he had decided to punt it back to Zoe. It was the same move he had used before, and there was a certain kind of symmetry to it, an appealing loss of control. There was also a level of emasculation, and it quivered deep in his groin in a way he'd rather not think about.

But he could tell himself it was all about faith, and testing it.

If she had *meant* to have him hear that phone call, and he didn't mention it - then she would have to ask about it.

And if she didn't ask about it...?

There were many possibilities if that was what happened next.

He would have to cross that bridge when he came to it, which would be very soon, because daylight was creeping across the sky, and there was no lurking deadline that would keep his part of the team here late tonight.

So he would be home.

And so would Zoe, he hoped.

END BOOK I

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